

# Orkneyinga saga

Kings' Sagas

Norse Sagas

*translated by Jon A. Hjaltalin and Gilbert Goudie, 1873*

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app1.1

## SKOTLAND

## Chapter 1 · OF THE EARLS

1.1

IT IS SAID that the Orkney Islands were colonised in the days of Harald the Fairhaired, but previously they were a station for Vikings.

1.2

The first Earl of the Orkneys was called Sigurd. He was the son of Eystein Glumra (the loud-talking), and brother of Rögnvald, Earl of Moeri.

1.3

After Sigurd his son Guttorm ruled one year.

1.4

Torf-Einar, son of Earl Rögnvald, succeeded him. He was a man of great power, and was Earl a long time. Hálfðán Hálegg (high-legs) made an expedition against Torf-Einar, and drove him from the Orkneys. Einar returned, and slew Hálfðán in Rinansey. Thereupon King Harald brought an army over to the Orkneys. Then Einar fled to Scotland. King Harald made the Orkneymen swear oaths of fealty to him for themselves and all their possessions. The Earl and King Harald were afterwards reconciled. He became the King's man, and held the land as a fief from him. He had, however, no tribute to pay, as there was much predatory warfare then in the islands; but he paid the king sixty marks of gold (once for all). After this, King Harald made a raid on Scotland, as is told in the Glumdrapa.

1.5

After Torf-Einar, Arnkell, Erlend, and Thorfinn Hausakliuf (skull-splitter), his sons, succeeded him. In their days Eirik Blóðöx (bloody axe) came over from Norway, and the Earls were his vassals. Arnkell and Erlend fell in battle, but Thorfinn governed the land and became an old man. His sons were Arnfid, Hávard, Lödver, Ljót, and Skúli; their

mother was Grélaug, daughter of Earl Dungad (Duncan) in Caithness. Her mother was Gróa, daughter of Thorstein the Red.

1.6

In the days of Earl Thorfinn the sons of Eirik Blóðöx arrived from Norway, when they had fled from Earl Hákon, and they did many deeds of violence in the islands. Earl Thorfinn died on a sickbed, and his sons, of whom there are extensive histories, succeeded him. Lödver survived his brothers, and ruled the land alone. His son was Earl Sigurd the Stout; he was a powerful man, and a great warrior.

1.7

In his days Olaf, Tryggvi's son, returning from a viking expedition to the west, came to the Orkneys with his men, and seized Earl Sigurd in Rörvág, as he lay there with a single ship. King Olaf offered the Earl to ransom his life on condition that he should embrace the true faith and be baptized; that he should become his man, and proclaim Christianity over all the Orkneys. He took his son Hundi or Hvelp (whelp) as a hostage, and left the Orkneys for Norway, where he became King; and Hundi stayed with him some years, and died there.

1.8

After that Earl Sigurd paid no allegiance to King Olaf. He married the daughter of Malcolm, King of Scots, and their son was Earl Thorfinn; his elder sons [by a former marriage] were Sumarlidi, Brúsi, and Einar.

1.9

Five years after the death of King Olaf, Tryggvi's son, Earl Sigurd went to Ireland. He set his elder sons over his domains, and sent Thorfinn to the King of Scots, his mother's father. While on this expedition Sigurd was killed in Brian's battle; and as soon as the news came to the Orkneys his sons Sumarlidi, Brúsi, and Einar, were accepted as Earls, and they divided the islands among them, each taking one third.

1.10

Thorfinn was five winters old when their father fell. When the King of Scots heard of the Earl's death he bestowed Caithness and Sutherland upon his grandson, with the title of Earl, and gave him men to rule the

domain along with him. Earl Thorfinn was very precocious in the maturity of all his powers. He was of large stature and strong, but ungainly. As he grew up it soon became apparent that he was avaricious, harsh, and cruel, yet a very clever man.

## 1.11

The brothers Einar and Brúsi were different in their dispositions. Brúsi was clever and fond of company, eloquent and beloved. Einar was stubborn and taciturn, disagreeable and avaricious, yet a great warrior. Sumarlidi was like Brúsi in his disposition. He was the eldest, and the most short-lived of the brothers. He died on a sickbed.

## 1.12

After his death Thorfinn demanded his share of [Sumarlidi's portion of] the Orkneys, although he already had Caithness and Sutherland which had belonged to his father Sigurd. This Einar considered to be much more than a third of the Orkneys, and he would not give up any part of them to Thorfinn. Brúsi, however, consented to give up his share [of the portion belonging to Sumarlidi], saying that he did not covet more of the land than his own proper third. Then Einar took possession of two shares of the islands. He became then a powerful man, and had a large number of retainers. In the summer he made war expeditions, calling out great levies of his men from their homes; but these expeditions were not always successful, and the Bœndr began to grow tired of them, but the Earl exacted all his services with violence, and did not suffer any one to speak against them. He was indeed a man of the greatest violence. Then there arose great scarcity in the islands on account of the labour and large expense to which the Bœndr were thus subjected. However, in the parts belonging to Brúsi there were good seasons and easy life, and he was greatly liked by the Bœndr.

## Chapter 2 · OF AMUNDI AND THORKEL

## 2.1

THERE WAS A powerful and wealthy man, by name Amundi, who lived in Hrossey, at Sandvik on Laufandaness. He had a son, by name Thorkel,

who was the most accomplished man in all the Orkneys.

## 2.2

One spring the Earl called out the Bœndr as usual, but they murmured greatly, and brought their grievances before Amundi, and asked him to say a good word for them to the Earl. He replied that the Earl was not disposed to listen to advice, and it would be of no avail to ask him to do this, as he and the Earl were such good friends; he further said that, from what he knew of his own temper and that of the Earl, there was great danger that they might become enemies, and he would have nothing to do with the matter. Then they asked Thorkel, and he was very reluctant, although at last he yielded to their solicitations, but Amundi thought he had been too rash to promise.

## 2.3

When the Earl held a meeting (Thing) Thorkel spoke on behalf of the Bœndr. He begged the Earl to spare the people, and told him of their distress. The Earl answered blandly, and said he would give great weight to Thorkel's words. "I had intended," he said, "to take out six ships, but now I shall not take more than three; but thou, Thorkel, do not ask this of me a second time."

## 2.4

The Bœndr were very grateful to Thorkel for his assistance, and the Earl made an expedition during the summer, and again in the autumn.

## 2.5

Next spring the Earl again called out his men, and held a meeting with the Bœndr. Thorkel spoke again on their behalf, and begged the Earl to spare them. The Earl became wroth, and said that for his speech the lot of the Bœndr should be far worse than before. Then he became so mad with rage, that he said that one or other of them should not leave the meeting unhurt, and immediately dissolved the meeting.

## 2.6

When Amundi heard what Thorkel and the Earl had said to each other, he bade his son go abroad, and Thorkel went to Earl Thorfinn in Caithness. He stayed there a long time, and became foster-father to the

Earl, who was still young. From that time he was called Thorkel Fóstri, and became a man of great repute. Other men of note and influence fled from the Orkneys on account of Earl Einar's violence; some to Earl Thorfinn, some to Norway, and some to other countries.

## 2.7

When Earl Thorfinn came to man's estate, he sent to his brother Einar, and demanded from him what he considered his share of the Orkneys. Einar was not inclined to divide his possessions: so, when Earl Thorfinn heard this, he called out men from Caithness, and set out for the Orkneys. When Earl Einar had news of this, he collected an army, with the intent to defend his possessions. Earl Brúsi also collected an army, and went to meet them, and tried to reconcile them; and peace was made on condition that Thorfinn should have one-third of the Orkneys as his own proper share.

## 2.8

Then Brúsi and Einar joined their portions, on the footing that the latter should rule them and defend them for both, and that he who survived the other should inherit his portion. But this compact was thought unfair, as Brúsi had a son, by name Rögnvald, and Einar had no son. Thorfinn appointed his own deputies to manage his possessions in the islands, but he himself lived for the most part in Caithness.

## 2.9

In the summer Einar went on expeditions to Ireland, Scotland, and Bretland (Wales). One summer, when ravaging Ireland, he fought in Ulfreksfiord with Konufögr, an Irish king, and was defeated, with a heavy loss of men. The next summer Eyvind Urarhorn (bull's horn) came from Ireland on his way to Norway, and being overtaken by a violent gale, he turned his ships into Asmundarvag, and lay there for a while. When Earl Einar heard this, he went thither with many men, seized Eyvind, and caused him to be killed, but gave quarter to most of his followers. They went to Norway in the autumn, and when they met King Olaf, they told him of Eyvind's murder. He said little about it, but it was afterwards found that he considered this a great loss and a

serious offence against himself, though he never said much about things with which he was displeased.

2.10

Earl Thorfinn sent Thorkel Fóstri to collect his revenues, but Earl Einar regarded it as chiefly owing to Thorkel that Earl Thorfinn had come into [his possessions in] the Islands. Thorkel left the islands suddenly, and went to Ness (Caithness). He told Earl Thorfinn that he had become aware that Earl Einar had intended to kill him, if his relatives and friends had not given him warning. “And now,” he added, “I will avoid the risk of having such a meeting with the Earl as shall bring matters to a crisis between us, and I will go farther away, where his power does not reach me.”

2.11

Thorfinn persuaded him to go to King Olaf, in Norway, and spend the winter with him in great friendship; “for you will,” he said, “be highly esteemed wherever you come among noble men; but I know your temper and that of the Earl to be such that you will not long refrain from hostilities.”

2.12

Thorkel then prepared for his departure, and in the autumn he went to Norway to visit King Olaf, and spent the winter with him in great friendship. The King often sought Thorkel’s advice, because he considered him a wise man and a weighty counsellor, and such was the truth. In telling of the Earls, the King found that he was very partial, a great friend of Thorfinn, and an enemy of Earl Einar. Early in the spring the King sent a ship with a message to Earl Thorfinn, asking him to come and see him; and the Earl did not put off the journey, for protestations of friendship had accompanied the message.

### Chapter 3 · THORKEL SLAYS EARL EINAR

3.1

THORFINN WENT EAST to King Olaf in Norway, where he was well received, and spent the summer there; and when he prepared to go

westward again, King Olaf gave him a large and excellent war-ship, fully equipped. Thorkel Fóstri went with the Earl, who gave him the ship in which he had come from the west in the summer. The King and the Earl parted great friends.

## 3.2

In the autumn Earl Thorfinn came to the Orkneys. When Earl Einar heard of it, he stayed with many men in his ships. Brúsi went to meet the two brothers, and tried to reconcile them; and once more they made peace and confirmed it with oaths. Thorkel Fóstri should be pardoned, and be a friend of Earl Einar, and each of them should give the other a banquet, and the Earl should first come to Thorkel at Sandvik.

## 3.3

When Einar came, he and his men were most sumptuously treated, yet the Earl was not cheerful. The banqueting hall was a large one, with doors at each end. When the Earl was going away, Thorkel was to accompany him, and he sent men to examine the way by which they were to go. When they returned, they said they had discovered three divisions of armed men in ambush, and were certain that foul play was intended. Upon hearing this, Thorkel delayed starting, and called his men together. The Earl asked him to make himself ready, and said it was now time to go. Thorkel replied that he had many things to see to, and kept going out and in.

## 3.4

There were fires on the floor, and Thorkel walked about, and once when he entered by one of the doors he was followed by an Iclander, by name Hallvard, from the east of Iceland, who shut the door after him. As Thorkel passed between the fire and where the Earl sat, the latter said: "Are you ready now?"

## 3.5

Thorkel replied: "I am ready now," and struck the Earl a blow on the head, so that he fell forward on the floor.

## 3.6

Hallvard said: "I never saw people with so little presence of mind as you who are here. Why do you not take the Earl out of the fire?"

3.7

With his axe he again struck the Earl on the back of the head, and pulled him towards the bench. Then Thorkel and his men walked out quickly by the door opposite to that by which he had entered, and there, outside the door, were the rest of his men fully armed.

3.8

The Earl's men took hold of their master and found that he was dead. They were too much stupified to take revenge, as the thing was done so suddenly, and no one expected such a deed from Thorkel; besides, the Earl's men were mostly without arms, and many of them were good friends of Thorkel's before. Thus Thorkel had to thank his good fortune that he enjoyed a longer life.

3.9

The Earl's men went away, and Thorkel to his ship. In a few days, shortly after the beginning of the winter, he left for the east, and arrived safely in Norway. He went immediately to see King Olaf, who received him very graciously, and felt much pleasure at his deed; and with him Thorkel spent the winter.

## Chapter 4 · OF EARL BRÚSI

4.1

AFTER THE DEATH of Earl Einar, Earl Brúsi took possession of that portion of the domain which had belonged to his brother (Einar), for there had been many witnesses to the compact which they had made. Thorfinn thought it right that they should each have one-half of the Islands, yet Brúsi had two-thirds that year. Next year Thorfinn demanded one-half, to which Brúsi did not consent, and they had many meetings about it. Their friends tried to settle matters between them, but Thorfinn would not take anything less than half of the Islands.

4.2

Brúsi said: “I was satisfied with that third part which I inherited from my father, and no one claimed it from me, and I have inherited a second third after my brother according to a lawful agreement; and although I am unable to contend with you, brother, I will have recourse to other means than giving up my lands and title at present.”

4.3

Thus the meeting ended. But Brúsi saw that he had no strength to hold his own against Thorfinn, because he had much larger possessions, and, besides, some hope of assistance from his grandfather, the King of Scots. He therefore resolved to go to Olaf, King of Norway, taking with him his son Rögnvald, who was then ten years old. The King received him well, and he told him his business and explained to him how matters stood between him and his brother, and begged his assistance to keep his possessions, offering in return his full friendship.

4.4

The King replied by stating that Harald the Fairhaired had reserved to himself all odal rights in the Orkneys, and that the Earls since that time always held those lands as fiefs, and never as their own.

4.5

“It is a proof of this,” he said, “that when Eirik Blóðöx and his sons were in the Orkneys, the Earls were their vassals; and when Olaf, Tryggvi’s son, my kinsman, came there, your father, Earl Sigurd, became his man. Now, I have succeeded to the entire heritage of Olaf, Tryggvi’s son. I will give you the islands as a fief, on condition that you become my man, and then I will try whether my help will not be of more avail to you than the aid and assistance of the King of Scots to your brother Thorfinn. But if you will not accept these terms, I will try to recover the possessions and dominion which my kinsmen have inherited and possessed there in the west.”

4.6

The Earl considered these words thoughtfully, and sought the advice of his friends as to whether he should consent to King Olaf’s terms and become his man. “I do not see,” he said, “how matters will go with me

at our parting if I refuse, because the King has made an unequivocal claim, and regards the Islands as his property. Now, considering his great power, and the circumstance that we are here, he will have no scruples in making my case such as he likes.”

4.7

Thus, although the Earl had objections to both alternatives, he resolved to give up all, himself and his dominions, into the King’s power. Then King Olaf asserted his suzerainty over all his hereditary possessions, and the Earl became his man, and confirmed this compact with oaths.

4.8

Earl Thorfinn heard that his brother Brúsi had gone east to King Olaf to solicit his assistance; but as he had himself seen the King before, and secured his friendship, he thought that his case had been well prepared there, and he knew that many would advocate his cause. Nevertheless, he resolved to prepare to go to Norway as quickly as possible, intending that he should arrive there very nearly at the same time with his brother, so that he might see the King himself before his brother had concluded his business. This, however, turned out otherwise than the Earl intended, for he did not see King Olaf until the treaty between Earl Brúsi and the King was fully concluded; and he did not know that Earl Brúsi had given up his dominions until he came to the King.

4.9

At their first interview the King made the same claim to the dominion of the Orkneys which he had made before to Earl Brúsi; and he made the same request of Thorfinn — namely, that he should acknowledge the King’s suzerainty over his portion of the islands.

4.10

The Earl gave a courteous answer to this demand, saying: “I consider your friendship of great importance; and if you think you require my assistance against other chiefs, you have well deserved it; but I cannot

well pay you homage, as I am already an Earl of the King of Scots, and his vassal.”

4.11

But when the King found from these words that the Earl wished to avoid the claims which he had put forward, he said: “If you will not become my man, there is the other alternative — viz. that I place that man over the Islands whom I choose. But I wish you to promise me with oaths not to claim those lands, and to leave him in peace whom I place over them. Now, if you will not accept any of those conditions, he who governs the land will say that hostilities may be expected from you, and in that case you must not think it strange if a dale meets a hill.”

4.12

The Earl answered by requesting time to consider these matters. The King gave him time, and permission to consult with his friends; but then the Earl asked the King for a further delay to the next summer, so that he might go home; “for,” said he, “my counsellors are at home, and my judgment is not yet mature on account of my age.” The King told him to make his choice.

4.13

Thorkel Fóstri was with the King at the time, and he sent a message to the Earl secretly, telling him that whatever else his intentions were he should not think of parting with the King without being reconciled to him for the present, as he had got him in his power. Now the Earl thought there was no alternative but to let the King have his will, although he did not consider it by any means a desirable thing to relinquish all hope of his patrimony, and to promise with oaths to leave those in undisturbed possession of his dominions who had no hereditary right to them. But because he was not certain about his departure (if he refused), he chose to submit to the King, and to become his man, as Brúsi his brother had previously done.

4.14

The King perceived that Thorfinn was a man of much stronger will than Brúsi, and distrusted him therefore more. He saw that Thorfinn would think himself sufficiently powerful, with the aid of the King of Scots, though he broke this treaty; and the King was sagacious enough to perceive that, while Brúsi agreed to everything sincerely, and made only such promises as he intended to keep, Thorfinn agreed cheerfully to everything, while at the same time he had resolved within himself what course he would take; and though he made no objections to anything which the King proposed, yet the King suspected that he intended to act upon their agreements afterwards in his own way.

## Chapter 5 · OF THE EARLS BRÚSI AND THORFINN

### 5.1

WHEN KING OLAF had considered all these matters, he had a general meeting summoned by the blowing of a trumpet, to which the Earls were also called.

### 5.2

The King said: “I will now make publicly known the treaty between me and the Earls of the Orkneys. They have acknowledged my suzerainty over all the Orkneys and Hjaltland (Shetland), promising to become my men, and confirming these their promises with oaths. In return, I will give to Brúsi one-third of the land, and to Thorfinn another third, which they had before; but the last third, which belonged to Earl Einar, I adjudge to be forfeited to me, because he slew Eyvind Urarhorn, my henchman and beloved comrade. Of this portion I will dispose as I shall think fit; and I make it a condition with you, my Earls, that you be reconciled to Thorkel Amundi’s son concerning your brother Einar’s slaying, and I wish to act as an arbitrator between you if you agree to this.”

### 5.3

The Earls consented to this, as to everything else which the King proposed. Then Thorkel stepped forward and submitted his case to the King’s decision, after which the meeting was dissolved. King Olaf

awarded a weregild for Earl Einar as for three Lendermen; one-third, however, should be remitted in consideration of the Earl's guilt.

5.4

Earl Thorfinn asked permission to depart, and when he had obtained it, he made himself ready in great haste. One day, when all was ready, and the Earl was drinking on board his ship, Thorkel, Amundi's son, came and laid his head on the Earl's knees, and asked him to do with it what he liked.

5.5

The Earl said: "Why do you do this? We are reconciled according to the King's arbitration; arise."

5.6

He rose and said: "I will abide by the King's arbitration concerning differences between me and Brúsi; but, as far as you are concerned, I leave everything to you. Although the King has reserved for me possessions and safety in the Orkneys, I am so well acquainted with your disposition that I know it would be impossible for me to go there unless I have your confidence; and I will promise you never to go to the Orkneys, whatever the King says."

5.7

The Earl replied slowly, and said: "Would you rather have me to adjust our affairs than abide by the King's decision? If so, I make it the first condition that you shall go with me to the Orkneys, and remain with me, and not leave me except with my permission; that you shall be in duty bound to defend my land, and to do everything I wish to have done while we are both alive."

5.8

Thorkel replied: "I leave this to you, like everything else that concerns me." Thereupon he submitted his case to the Earl's decision.

5.9

The Earl said he would fix the money payment [for his brother's death] afterwards, and received oaths from Thorkel according to their

agreement; and Thorkel prepared to go with him. The Earl left as soon as he was ready, and he and King Olaf never met afterwards.

5.10

Earl Brúsi remained behind, and prepared for his departure more leisurely. Before he left, King Olaf had an interview with him, and said: "I think it advisable to make you my confidential agent in the western parts. I intend to give you two-thirds of the islands, which you had before, because I do not wish you to have less power, now that you are my man, than you had before; and as a pledge of my good faith, I will keep your son Rögnvald with me. I see that with two-thirds of the land and my assistance you may well hold your own against Earl Thorfinn."

5.11

Brúsi was thankful for two-thirds of the land. He stayed a little while yet before he left, and came west to the Islands (the Orkneys) in the autumn. His son Rögnvald remained with King Olaf. These facts are mentioned by Ottar Svarti (the swarthy):

5.12

Readily these noble people  
Will obey thee as thy subjects.

5.13

Use your power with moderation;  
Hjaltlanders! your fame is well known.

5.14

Till we had thee, fierce in battle,  
To these eastern shores, there was not  
Any prince on earth who conquered  
Those far distant western islands.

5.15

When the brothers Thorfinn and Brúsi came west to the Islands, Brúsi took possession of two-thirds of the domain, and Thorfinn of one, but he was all the time in Caithness, in Scotland, and placed deputies over the islands. Brúsi alone had to defend them, for they were in those times very much exposed to the ravages of Norwegians and Danes, who

called there on their viking expeditions to the west, and plundered in the outlying parts. Brúsi made complaints to his brother Thorfinn on account of his not contributing anything to the defence of the Orkneys or Hjaltland (Shetland), although he received his full share of all the land-dues and revenues. Then Thorfinn proposed to Brúsi to take two-thirds of the Islands, undertaking the defence of the whole, and leave Brúsi one-third. Although this division did not take place immediately, yet it is said in the History of the Earls that it did take place, and that Thorfinn had two-thirds of the Islands, and Brúsi one-third, when Canute the Great conquered Norway, after the flight of King Olaf.

5.16

King Olaf, Harald's son, received no homage from Earl Thorfinn after he made the treaty with him and Brúsi.

5.17

Earl Thorfinn now became a powerful chief. He was a man of very large stature, uncomely, sharp-featured, dark-haired, and sallow and swarthy in his complexion. Yet he was a most martial-looking man, and of great energy; greedy of wealth and of renown; bold and successful in war, and a great strategist. He was five years old when he received the title of Earl and the revenues of Caithness from King Malcolm, his grandfather, and fourteen when he went forth from his own territory on maritime expeditions, and attacked the possessions of other chiefs. So says Arnór Jarlaskáld (the Earls' poet):

5.18

By the prince in storm of helmets  
Was the sword's edge deeply crimsoned.

5.19

Scarcely fifteen, the great-hearted  
Sought renown on fields of battle,  
Ready to defend his own land,  
Or to ravage in another's.

5.20

Under heaven a braver leader  
Ne'er was found than Einar's brother.

5.21

Earl Thorfinn was greatly supported by the King of Scots. This assistance being so near, it much increased his power in the Orkneys.

5.22

The King of Scots died after the reconciliation of the brothers. Karl Hundason took the kingdom in Scotland. He considered Caithness to belong to him, as to the former kings, and demanded tribute from it as from other places. Thorfinn, however, did not think his inheritance from his mother's father large, though he had Caithness; and besides, according to his own opinion, it had been given to him first; he was therefore unwilling to pay any tribute. Thus they became open enemies, and made war on each other. King Karl wished to appoint a chief, by name Moddan, over Caithness; he was his sister's son, and he gave him the title of Earl. Then Moddan went down from Scotland and collected forces in Sutherland.

5.23

When Earl Thorfinn heard of this, he gathered together an army in Caithness. Thorkel Fóstri also came to Earl Thorfinn from the Orkneys with many men, and their united forces were somewhat more numerous than those of the Scots. When the Scots knew this they hesitated in their invasion, and returned to Scotland. Earl Thorfinn subdued Sutherland and Ross, and plundered far and wide in Scotland, and returned again to Caithness, and Thorkel went back to the Islands; their men also returned home. Earl Thorfinn stayed at Dungalsbæ, in Caithness, where he had five war-ships and followers numerous enough to man them.

5.24

Moddan came to find King Karl (at Beruvik) and informed him of his unsuccessful expedition. The King became very angry at his land being plundered, and started immediately with eleven war-ships and a numerous army. He sailed northward along Scotland, after having

despatched Moddan to Caithness a second time with many troops. Moddan went by land, and it was intended that he should make the attack from that side, so that Earl Thorfinn might be placed between the two armies.

5.25

Now, it is to be told of King Karl that he did not stop until he arrived at Caithness, and he and Earl Thorfinn were not far from each other. Thorfinn went on board his ships, and sailed out on the Pentland Firth, intending to go to the Orkneys; and so near were they that King Karl saw their sails as he sailed into the Firth from the east, and immediately sailed after them. Earl Thorfinn directed his course to the east of the Orkneys, intending to go to Sandvik. He moored his ships on the east side of Dyrness, and immediately sent word to Thorkel to collect troops.

5.26

Earl Thorfinn arrived at Dyrness late in the evening; but as soon as it was daylight next morning, King Karl came upon them unawares with eleven war-ships. There were only two alternatives — one to run on shore, and leave the ships with all their valuable contents to the enemy; the other was to meet the King, and let fate decide between them. Earl Thorfinn exhorted his men, and ordered them to have their arms ready. He said he would not flee, and told them to row briskly towards the enemy. Then both parties fastened their ships together. Earl Thorfinn addressed his men, advising them to be smart and to make the first attack fiercely, and saying that few of the Scotsmen would be able to make a stand. The fighting was long and fierce. Arnór Jarlaskáld says:

5.27

Once, off Dyrness, to the eastward,  
Came King Kali in a mail-coat  
Famous for its strength and brightness;  
But the land was not defenceless,  
For, with five ships, nothing daunted,

Scorning flight in warlike temper,  
Valiantly the Prince went forward  
‘Gainst the King’s eleven vessels.  
Then the ships were lashed together —  
Know ye how the men were falling?  
All their swords and boards were swimming  
In the life-blood of the Scotsmen;  
Hearts were sinking — bowstrings screaming,  
Darts were flying — spear-shafts bending;  
Swords were biting, blood flowed freely,  
And the Prince’s heart was merry.

5.28

Now Earl Thorfinn incited his men to the utmost, and a fierce conflict ensued. The Scots in the King’s ships made but a feeble resistance before the mast, whereupon Thorfinn jumped from the quarter-deck, and ran to the foredeck, and fought fiercely. When he saw the crowd in the King’s ships getting thinner, he urged his men to board them. King Karl, perceiving this, gave orders to his men to cut the ropes, and get the ships away instantly; to take to their oars, and bear away. At the same time Thorfinn and his men fastened grappling-hooks in the King’s ship. He called for his banner to be borne before him, and a great number of his men followed it. King Karl jumped from his ship into another vessel, with those of his men who still held out; but the most part had fallen already. He then ordered them to take to their oars; and the Scots took to flight — Thorfinn pursuing them. Thus says Arnór:

5.29

Never was a battle shorter;  
Soon with spears it was decided.  
Though my lord had fewer numbers,  
Yet he chased them all before him;  
Hoarsely croaked the battle-gull, when

Thickly fell the wounded king's-men;  
South of Sandwick swords were reddened.

5.30

King Karl fled all the way south to Breidafiord, where he went on shore, and collected an army anew. Earl Thorfinn went back after the battle, when Thorkel Fóstri came to him with a numerous army. They then sailed south to Breidafiord in pursuit of King Karl, and when they came to Scotland they began to plunder. Then they were told that Earl Moddan was at Thurso, in Caithness, with a large army. He had sent to Ireland for men, because he had there many relatives and friends, and he was waiting for these troops. Then it was thought advisable that Thorkel should go to Caithness with a portion of the army; but Thorfinn remained in Scotland, and plundered there. Thorkel went secretly, because all the inhabitants of Caithness were true and faithful to him; and no news went of his journey till he came to Thurso by night, and surprised Earl Moddan in a house, which they set on fire. Moddan was asleep in an upper storey, and jumped out; but as he jumped down from the stair, Thorkel hewed at him with a sword, and it hit him on the neck, and took off his head.

5.31

After this his men surrendered, but some escaped by flight. Many were slain, but some received quarter.

5.32

Thorkel did not stay there long, but went to Breidafiord, bringing with him all the men he had been able to collect in Caithness, Sutherland, and Ross. He met Earl Thorfinn in Moray, and told him what he had done in his expedition, for which he received hearty thanks from the Earl, and there they both stayed for a while.

## Chapter 6 · OF THE ORKNEYMEN

6.1

NOW IT IS to be told of King Karl that he went to Scotland after the battle with Earl Thorfinn, and collected an army as well from the

south as the west and east of Scotland, and all the way south from Satiri (Kintyre); the forces for which Earl Moddan had sent also came to him from Ireland. He sent far and near to the chieftains for men, and brought all this army against Earl Thorfinn. They met at Torfnæs, on the south side of Bæfiord. There was a fierce battle, and the Scots were by far the most numerous. Earl Thorfinn was among the foremost of his men; he had a gold-plated helmet on his head, a sword at his belt, and a spear in his hand, and he cut and thrust with both hands. It is even said that he was foremost of all his men. He first attacked the Irish division, and so fierce were he and his men, that the Irish were immediately routed, and never regained their position. Then King Karl had his standard brought forward against Earl Thorfinn, and there was the fiercest struggle for a while; but it ended in the flight of the King; and some say he was slain. Thus Arnór Jarlaskáld:

## 6.2

Reddened were the wolf's-bit's edges  
 At a place — men call it Torfnæs; —  
 It was by a youthful ruler  
 This was done, upon a Monday.  
 Pliant swords were loudly ringing  
 At this War-Thing, south of Ekkial,  
 When the prince had joined in battle  
 Bravely with the King of Scotland.  
 High his helm the Lord of Hjaltland  
 Bore amid the clang of weapons;  
 In the battle ever foremost,  
 Reddened he his gleaming spear-point  
 In the wounds it gave the Irish.  
 Thus my lord his mighty prowess  
 Showed beneath his British buckler —  
 Taking many warriors captive;  
 Hlödver's kinsman burnt the country.

## 6.3

Earl Thorfinn drove the fugitives before him through Scotland, and subdued the country wherever he went, and all the way south to Fife. Then he sent Thorkel Fóstri away with some of his men. When the Scots heard that the Earl had sent away some of his men, those that had submitted to him meant to attack him. As soon, however, as he was aware of their treachery, he called his men together and went to meet them; but when they knew he was prepared, they hesitated to make the attack. Earl Thorfinn resolved to give battle to the Scots as soon as he met them; but they had not the manliness to defend themselves, and ran away into woods and deserted places; and when he had pursued the fugitives, he called his men together, and said he would burn the whole district, and thus pay the Scots for their treachery. Then the Earl's men went over hamlets and farms, and burnt everything, so that scarcely a hut was left standing. Those of the men whom they found they killed, but the women and old people dragged themselves into woods and deserted places, with wailings and lamentations. Some of them they drove before them, and many were taken captives. Thus says Arnór Jarlaskáld:

## 6.4

Fast the flames devoured the homesteads;  
Lives that day were in great peril;  
Fire the Scottish kingdom ravaged —  
All reduced to smoking ashes;  
Great the mischief done that summer  
By the mighty Slaughter-Teacher;  
Three times were the luckless Scotsmen  
By the Prince completely vanquished.

## 6.5

After this Thorfinn went through Scotland to the north, till he reached his ships, and subdued the country wherever he went, and did not stop till he came to Caithness, where he spent the winter; but every season after this he went out on expeditions, and plundered in the summer time with all his men.

## Chapter 7 · OF THE FAMOUS DEEDS OF EARL THORFINN

## 7.1

EARL THORFINN MADE himself famous in the Orkneys by entertaining his own men and many other men of note throughout the winter, so that no one had to go to inns — providing food and drink at his own charges, in the same manner as chiefs in other countries, Kings, and Earls entertain their henchmen and guests at Christmas time. About this time Earl Brúsi died, and Earl Thorfinn took possession of all the islands. But of Rögnvald, Brúsi's son, it is said that he was in the battle of Stiklestad when King Olaf was killed. Rögnvald escaped, with other fugitives, and carried away King Olaf's brother, Harald Sigurdson, who was dangerously wounded, and brought him to a small Bondi to be cured; but he himself crossed the Kjöl, and went to Jamtaland, and thence to Sweden to see King Onund. Harald stayed with the Bondi until he had recovered from his wounds. The Bondi then gave him his son as an attendant, and he went through Jamtaland to Sweden secretly. At their parting, which took place in a certain copse, Harald sang:

## 7.2

Though now thus here and there I'm hunted  
Through the covert — small's the honour,  
Who knows but that far and wide yet  
Some day shall my name be famous?

## 7.3

Harald met Rögnvald in Sweden, and they went both of them east to Gardariki (Russia), along with many others who had been with King Olaf. They did not stop till they came east to King Jarizleif, in Hólmgard; and he received them most heartily for the sake of King Olaf the Holy. He took them both, as well as Erling, Rögnvald's son, into his service as defenders of his country.

## Chapter 8 · MAGNUS, OLAF'S SON, ACCEPTED KING OF NORWAY

### 8.1

RÖGNVALD, BRÚSI'S SON, remained in Gardariki (Russia) when Harald, Sigurd's son, went to Mikligard (Constantinople); he had the defence of the frontier in summer, and spent the winters in Hólmgard. The King as well as the people esteemed him highly. Rögnvald was a man of large stature and great strength, and one of the handsomest men in appearance, and his accomplishments were such that his equal was hardly to be found. Arnór Jarlaskáld says that he fought ten battles in Gardar:

### 8.2

So it happened that ten battles  
Fought the soldier fierce in Gardar.

### 8.3

Einar Thambarskelfir and Kálf Arnason brought Magnus, Olaf's son, from Gardariki (Russia). Rögnvald met them in Aldeigiuborg. He had nearly made an attack on Kálf before he had informed him of their business. Einar said that Kálf repented of (his share in) the great crime of having deprived King Olaf the Holy of his life and kingdom, and that he now wished to make amends to his son Magnus. He further told Rögnvald that Kálf wished to place Magnus on the throne, and support him against the Vikings in the pay of the Canutes. By this Rögnvald was softened, and now Einar Thambarskelfir asked him to go with them up to Hólmgard, and introduce them and their business to King Jarizleif. He should tell him that the Norwegians were so disgusted with the rule of the Canutes, but most of all with Alfifa, that they would prefer any hardships to serving them longer; and then he should ask King Jarizleif to permit Magnus, Olaf's son, to become their chief. When they came there, Rögnvald, Queen Ingigerd, and many of the noblemen, pleaded their cause. King Jarizleif was unwilling to trust Magnus into the hands of the Norwegians, because of their treatment of his father. At last, however, they succeeded so far that twelve of the

noblest men made oaths to the effect that their offers were sincere; but King Jarisleif trusted Rögnvald so much that he did not require him to swear. Kálf promised King Magnus with an oath that he would accompany him both within his kingdom and out of it, and do everything to support his power and to secure his safety. Thereupon the Norwegians accepted Magnus as their King, and swore fealty to him.

## 8.4

Einar and Kálf stayed in Hólmgard till after Christmas. Then they went down to Aldegiuborg (Ladoga), and procured ships. As soon as the sea was open in the spring, Rögnvald, Brúsi's son, made himself ready to go with King Magnus. They went first to Sweden, then to Jamtaland, crossed the Kjöl, and came to Veradal. When King Magnus came to Thrándheim, all the population submitted to him. Then he went down to Nídarós, and was accepted King of the whole country at the Eyrar-Thing. After this came the dealings of King Magnus and King Sveinn.

## Chapter 9 · RÖGNVALD ASKS MAGNUS FOR LEAVE TO GO TO THE ISLANDS

## 9.1

WHEN RÖGNVALD, BRÚSI'S son, came to Norway, he heard of the death of his father Brúsi, and at the same time, that Earl Thorfinn had taken possession of the whole of the Islands. Then he wished to visit his odal possessions, and asked King Magnus to permit him to go. The King saw that it was necessary for him to go, and willingly gave him permission. At the same time, he gave him the title of Earl, and three war-ships well equipped. He also gave him a grant of that third part of the Orkneys which King Olaf had possessed, and had given to his father Brúsi. At last King Magnus promised his foster-brother his full friendship, adding that his assistance should be at his service whenever he required it. Thus they parted the best of friends.

## Chapter 10 · OF ROGNVALD'S VOYAGE

## 10.1

EARL RÖGNVALD SAILED for the Orkneys, and went first to the estates which his father had possessed. Thence he sent messengers to his kinsman, Earl Thorfinn, and asked for that third part (of the Islands) which had belonged to his father. He also requested them to tell him that he had obtained from King Magnus a grant of that third which had belonged to King Olaf. He therefore demanded two-thirds, if it was the pleasure of his kinsman Thorfinn. At this time Thorfinn had great quarrels with the Irish and the inhabitants of the Sudreyar (Hebrides), and felt himself greatly in want of assistance. He therefore gave Rögnvald's messengers the following reply: — That Rögnvald should take possession of that third which rightly belonged to him. "As for the third which Magnus calls his own," he said, "we gave that up to King Olaf the Holy because we were then in his power, but not because we thought it just. I and my kinsman Rögnvald will agree all the better the less we talk of that third, which has been long enough a cause of dispute. But if Rögnvald wishes to be my faithful friend, I consider those possessions in good hands which he has for his pleasure and for the good of us both. His assistance will soon be of greater value to me than the revenues which I derive from them."

## 10.2

Upon this the messengers returned, and said he had yielded up to Rögnvald two-thirds on condition that they should be allies, as it was right they should be, on account of their relationship. Rögnvald said, however, that he did not demand more than what he considered his own; but as Thorfinn had so willingly given up the lands, he would indeed assist him, and be his firm friend, which was but natural, as they were so nearly related. Accordingly Rögnvald took possession of two-thirds of the islands.

## Chapter 11 · THE BATTLE OF THE KINSMEN THORFINN AND ROGNVALD

### 11.1

EARLY IN THE spring Thorfinn sent word to his kinsman Rögnvald, and asked him to go out with him on an expedition, bringing as many men as he could. As soon as Rögnvald received this message, he collected together as many men and vessels as he could, and when he was ready he went to meet Earl Thorfinn, who was also ready with his band. He received his kinsman Rögnvald very well; and they joined their forces. During the summer they plundered in the Sudreyar (Hebrides), and in Ireland, and in Scotland's Fiord; and Thorfinn conquered the land wherever he went. They had a great battle at a place called Vatnsfiord. It began early in the morning, and the kinsmen gained the victory. This is mentioned by Arnór Jarlaskáld:

### 11.2

Know ye that place, Vatnsfiord?  
There was I in greatest danger;  
Marks are there of my Lord's doings,  
He who tries the strength of warriors.  
Forth the people quickly carried  
From the ships the shields of many;  
Then was heard the dismal howling

### 11.3

f the gray wolf o'er the corpses.

### 11.4

After this battle they returned to the Orkneys, and stayed at home during the winter. Thus eight winters passed that Earl Rögnvald had two-thirds of the islands without any objection on the part of Earl Thorfinn. Every summer they went out on war expeditions, sometimes both together, sometimes separately, as Arnór says:

### 11.5

The chief beloved did many deeds.

### 11.6

Everywhere there fell before him  
Irishmen, or British people;  
Fire devoured the Scottish kingdom.

## 11.7

The kinsmen agreed very well whenever they met; but when bad men went between them dissensions often arose. Earl Thorfinn dwelt for the most part in Caithness, at the place called Gaddgedlar, where Scotland and England (?) meet.

## Chapter 12 · OF EARL THORFINN'S WARFARE

## 12.1

ONE SUMMER EARL Thorfinn made war in the Sudreyar (Hebrides) and in Scotland. He had sent men into England to foray, and they carried away all the spoil they could find. But when the English became aware of the presence of the Vikings, they gathered together and attacked them. They took from them all the cattle, and killed all the men that were of any note, but sent back some of the reivers, and requested them to tell Earl Thorfinn how they had made the Vikings tired of plunder and rapine, to which they added many insulting words. Thereupon the reivers went to Earl Thorfinn and told him of their mishaps. He was greatly annoyed at the loss of his men, yet he said he could not then do anything, and that they would have to refrain at this time; but he said he was quite able to repay the Englishmen for their mockery, and would do so if he were well next summer.

## Chapter 13 · OF EARL THORFINN'S EXPEDITION TO ENGLAND

## 13.1

AT THAT TIME Hardicanute was King of England and Denmark. Earl Thorfinn went to the Orkneys and spent the winter there. Early in the spring he called out a levy from all his domains, and sent word to his kinsman Rögnvald. Rögnvald assented, and called out men from all his possessions. Earl Thorfinn collected troops in Caithness and the Orkneys. He also had many from Scotland and Ireland, and from the

Sudreyar (Hebrides), and with all these forces he sailed to England as he had promised. Hardicanute was in Denmark at the time. As soon as the Earls came into England they began to harry and plunder; but the chiefs whose duty it was to defend the land went to meet them with an army. There was a great and fierce battle, in which the Earls gained the victory. After this they plundered far and wide in England, slaying men, and burning the dwellings of the people. This is mentioned by Arnór:

## 13.2

Not forgotten was this battle  
 By the English, or men ever.  
 Hither came the rich ring-giver,  
 With his warriors, nearly doubled;  
 Swords cut keenly; under shield-boss  
 Rushed all Rögnvald's men together;  
 Strong were all the old one's people.  
 South of Man did these things happen.  
 On the native land of Britons  
 Brought the Earl his banner forward;  
 Reddened then his beak the eagle;  
 Forward pressing hard his warriors,  
 Battle waxed, and men diminished;  
 Fugitives were chased by victors;  
 Blazed the fire, with red rays gleaming  
 Of the wood's foe, leaping heavenward.

## 13.3

Earl Thorfinn had two pitched battles in England. Besides, he had many casual encounters, and slew many people. He stayed there throughout the summer, and went back in autumn to the Orkneys for the winter.

## Chapter 14 · KALF FLEES TO THE ORKNEYS

## 14.1

ABOUT THIS TIME Kálf Arnason was banished by King Magnus. He crossed the seas, and went to Earl Thorfinn, his brother-in-law. Thorfinn's wife was then Ingibjorg, the mother of the Earls (Paul and Erlend), and daughter of Earl Finn Arnason. There was great friendship between Kálf and Earl Thorfinn. The Earl had a great many of his men about him, which became very expensive to him. Then there were many who advised him not to leave two-thirds of the Islands to Rögnvald, since his own expenses were so large. Thereupon Earl Thorfinn sent men into the Islands to demand from Rögnvald that third portion which had belonged to Earl Einar Rangmuth (wry-mouth).

## 14.2

Upon receiving this message, the Earl (Rögnvald) consulted with his friends. Then he called Earl Thorfinn's messengers, and told them that he had received that portion of the Islands which they claimed as a fief from King Magnus, and that the King called it his patrimony. "It was therefore," he said, "in the power of King Magnus to decide which of them should have it; and he would not give it up if the King wished him to retain it."

## 14.3

The messengers went away, and told these words to Earl Thorfinn, adding that the third portion [which he had demanded] would certainly not be got without trouble. On hearing this, Earl Thorfinn became very angry, and said that it was unfair if King Magnus should have the inheritance of his brother, adding that he had yielded to the demand more because he was then in King Olaf's power than because it was a just claim. "Now," he said, "I think Rögnvald does not return me well my good will in having left him in quiet possession for a time, if I am not to have the inheritance of my brother now except by fighting for it." Now Earl Thorfinn became so enraged that he straightway sent men to the Hebrides and to Scotland, and collected together an army, making it known that he would march against Rögnvald, and demand

that without abatement which he had not got when he asked peacefully for it.

## 14.4

When this was told to Earl Rögnvald, he called his friends together, and complained to them of his kinsman Thorfinn intending to come and make war on him. He then asked what help they would offer him, saying that he would not give up his own without a trial of strength. But when he asked them to declare themselves, their opinions were very different. Some spoke in favour of Earl Rögnvald, and said that one could not be hard upon him for not being willing to part with his possessions; others again said it was excusable on the part of Earl Thorfinn to desire to have those possessions for a while which Rögnvald had had before, and which had belonged to Earl Einar. Further, they said it was the greatest foolishness for Rögnvald to fight with such troops as he could get from two-thirds of the Islands against Thorfinn, who had one-third, with Caithness, a great deal of Scotland, and all the Hebrides besides. There were also those who advised reconciliation. They asked Earl Rögnvald to offer Earl Thorfinn one-half of the Islands, so that they might still be friends, as it was meet they should be, owing to their relationship. But when Rögnvald found that their opinions were divided, and that they all dissuaded him from resistance, he made known his determination that he would not part with his possessions by any arrangement, but that he would rather leave them for a time, and go to King Magnus, his foster-brother, and see what assistance he would give him to retain them. Then he made ready, and went to Norway, and did not rest until he came to King Magnus, and told him how matters stood.

## 14.5

The King received Earl Rögnvald very well, and invited him to stay as long as he liked, and to receive such lands from him as were sufficient to keep him and his men; but Earl Rögnvald said he wished assistance to recover his possessions. King Magnus said he would certainly give him such aid as he stood in need of. Rögnvald stayed a short time in

Norway, until he had made ready his expedition for the Orkneys. He had a numerous and well-equipped army, which King Magnus had given him. The King also sent word to Kálf Arnason that he should have his estates restored to him, and be permitted to stay in Norway, if he took Earl Rögnvald's part in his dispute with Earl Thorfinn.

## Chapter 15 · BATTLE OF RAUDABIORG

### 15.1

EARL RÖGNVALD SAILED from Norway for the Orkneys, and landed in Hjaltland (Shetland), where he collected men, and went thence to the Orkneys. There he summoned his friends to meet him, and obtained reinforcements. Earl Thorfinn was in Caithness, and news soon reached him of Earl Rögnvald's proceedings. He collected forces from Scotland and the Sudreyar (Hebrides). Rögnvald immediately sent King Magnus's message to Kálf Arnason, who apparently received very well all that the King had said. Earl Rögnvald collected his army together in the Orkneys, intending to cross over to Caithness, and when he sailed into the Pentland Firth he had thirty large ships. There he was met by Earl Thorfinn, who had sixty ships, but most of them small. They met off Raudabiorg (red cliff), and at once prepared for battle.

### 15.2

Kálf Arnason was there also; he had six ships, all of them large, but did not take part in the fight.

### 15.3

Now the battle began with the utmost fury, both Earls encouraging their men. When the fighting had thus continued for a while, the loss of men began to be heaviest on Earl Thorfinn's side, the chief cause being the great difference in the height of the ships. Thorfinn himself had a large ship, well equipped, in which he pressed forward with great daring; but when the smaller vessels were cleared, the Earl's ship was attacked from both sides, and they were placed in great danger. Many of the Earl's men were killed, and others dangerously wounded. Then Earl Rögnvald commanded his men to leap on board; but when

Thorfinn perceived the imminent danger, he caused the ropes to be cut with which his ship was fastened to the other, and rowed towards the shore. He had seventy dead bodies removed from his ship, and all those who were disabled by wounds went also on shore. Then Thorfinn ordered Arnór Jarlaskáld, who was among the Earl's men and high in his favour, to go on shore; and on landing he sang these verses: —

## 15.4

This will I not hide from comrades,  
Though 'tis right one's chief to follow,  
Yet am I myself unwilling  
Thus to meet the son of Brúsi.  
When these Earls so fierce in battle  
Close in fight, then will our case be  
Hard beyond the case of most men  
In this trial of our friendship.

## 15.5

Earl Thorfinn selected the ablest of his men to man his ship, and then he went to see Kálf Arnason, and asked his assistance. He said that Kálf would not be able to buy king Magnus's friendship, since he had already been banished, and was therefore unable to keep the king's favour, even when they were once reconciled. "You may be sure," he added, "that if Rögnvald overcomes me, and he and King Magnus become masters here in the west, you will not be welcome in this quarter, but if I come off victorious you shall lack nothing that it is in my power to give you. If we two keep together we shall be a match for any one here in the west, and I hardly think you will allow yourself to lie crouching aside like a cat among stones while I am fighting for behoof of us both. Moreover our ties are so close that it is more seemly for us to aid each other, since you have no ties of blood or affinity with our enemies."

## 15.6

When Kálf heard Thorfinn's persuasions he called his men and gave orders to fall to and fight on the side of Earl Thorfinn. Now Thorfinn

and Kálf both rowed back to the fight, and when they arrived Thorfinn's men were ready to fly, and many of them had been slain. The Earl pushed his ship forward against that of Earl Rögnvald, and a fierce fight ensued. As is said by Arnór Jarlaskáld —

15.7

Then I saw the two wealth-givers  
Hewing down each other's warriors.  
Fierce the fight was in the Pentland,  
As the sea swelled and the red rain  
Crimsoned all the yielding timbers,  
While from shield-rims sweat of hot blood  
Dripping, stained the warriors' garments.

15.8

Kálf attacked Rögnvald's smaller ships, and speedily cleared them, as there was a great difference in the height of the ships. When the hired troops from Norway saw the vessels beside them cleared they cut away their ship and fled. Then only a few ships remained with Earl Rögnvald, and the victory began to lean the other way. So says Arnór Jarlaskáld: —

15.9

Then the prince so fierce in battle,  
Valiant kinsman of the Vikings,  
All the old land might have conquered  
With assistance of the Islesmen.  
Fewer were his slaughtered heroes;  
But the chief's strong men in helmets,  
All the way to northern Hjaltland,  
Chased the weak and flying remnant.

15.10

And when the main portion of the troops had fled, Kálf and Earl Thorfinn attacked Earl Rögnvald's ship together, and then a great number of his men were slain. When he saw the imminent danger, and

that he would not be able to overcome Thorfinn and Kálf, he had the cables cut, and fled.

15.11

It was now late in the day, and darkness was coming on. Earl Rögnvald stood out to sea the same night, and sailed for Norway, and did not stop till he found King Magnus, who received him well, as he had done before, and invited him to remain with him, and there he stayed some time.

## Chapter 16 · EARL THORFINN SUBDUES THE ISLANDS

16.1

NOW IT IS to be told of Earl Thorfinn that on the morning after the battle he sent boats to all the islands to search for the fugitives. Many were killed, and some were pardoned. Earl Thorfinn subdued all the Islands, and made all the inhabitants his subjects, even those who had sworn allegiance to Earl Rögnvald. Thorfinn then fixed his residence in the Orkneys, keeping a great number of men about him; he imported provisions from Caithness, and sent Kálf Arnason to the Sudreyar (Hebrides), and ordered him to remain and maintain his authority there.

16.2

When Earl Rögnvald had stayed with King Magnus for some time, he said to the King that he wished to go back to the Islands. When the King heard this he said it was not wise, and advised him to remain until the winter had passed away and the sea was free from ice. Yet he said that he would give him as many men as he wanted, and a sufficient number of ships. Rögnvald in reply said that this time he would go without the King's men, adding that he could not lead an army against Earl Thorfinn without a great loss of men, as he had such extensive dominions in the west. "This time," he continued, "I intend to go to the west in a single ship, as well manned as possible; thus I expect there will be no news of us beforehand; and if I get to the Islands I shall take them by surprise, and then we may speedily gain such a victory as

could hardly, if at all, be gained by a number of troops; but if they become aware of our movements we can still let the sea take care of us.”

16.3

King Magnus said he might go as he pleased, and return to him when he wished.

16.4

After this Rögnvald made his ship ready, and selected the crew carefully. Several of King Magnus’s henchmen went with him, and altogether he had a picked crew in his vessel. When they were ready they sailed out to sea and had a fair wind. This was early in the winter.

## Chapter 17 · RÖGNVALD COMES TO THE ISLANDS

17.1

RÖGNVALD FIRST CAME off the coast of Hjaltland (Shetland), and heard that Earl Thorfinn was in the Orkneys with few men, because he did not expect any enemies in the depth of winter. Rögnvald went straightway to the Orkneys. Earl Thorfinn was in Hrossey, suspecting nothing. When Rögnvald arrived in the Orkneys, he went where he had heard that Earl Thorfinn was, and came upon him unawares, so that his presence was not known until he had secured all the doors of the house in which the Earl and his men were. It was in the night time, and most of the men were asleep, but the Earl was still sitting over his drink. Rögnvald and his men set fire to the house. When Earl Thorfinn became aware of the presence of enemies he sent men to the door to know who they were. They were told that it was Earl Rögnvald. Then they all leaped to their weapons, but they were unable to do anything in the way of defence, as they were all prevented from getting out. The house was soon in flames, and Earl Thorfinn said that permission should be asked for those to go out who were to receive quarter. When this was asked of Earl Rögnvald he permitted all the women and thralls to go out, but he said that most of Thorfinn’s henchmen would be no better to him alive than dead. Those who were spared were dragged out, and the house began to burn down. Earl Thorfinn bethought him

of a plan, and broke down part of the woodwork of the house and leaped out there, carrying Ingibiorg, his wife, in his arms. As the night was pitch dark he got away in the smoke unperceived by Earl Rögnvald's men, and during the night he rowed alone in a boat over to Ness (Caithness). Earl Rögnvald burnt the house, with all who were in it, and no one thought otherwise than that Earl Thorfinn had perished there.

## 17.2

After this Rögnvald went over the Islands and took possession of them all. He also sent messages over to Ness (Caithness), and to the Sudreyar (Hebrides), to the effect that he intended to have all the dominions of Thorfinn, and nobody spoke against him. Earl Thorfinn was then in Caithness in hiding with his friends, and no news went abroad of his escape from the burning.

## Chapter 18 · EARL RÖGNVALD SLAIN

## 18.1

EARL RÖGNVALD RESIDED in Kirkiuvag (Kirkwall), and brought there all necessities for the winter; he had a great number of men, and entertained them liberally. A little before Christmas the Earl went with a numerous following into little Papey to fetch malt for the Christmas brewing. The evening which they stayed in the islands they sat a long time round the fires to warm themselves, and he who had to keep up the fires said they were running short of fuel. Then the Earl made a slip of the tongue in speaking, and said: "We shall be old enough when these fires are burnt out," but he intended to have said that they would be warm enough; and when he noticed his blunder he said: "I made a slip of the tongue in speaking just now; I do not remember that I ever did so before, and now I recollect what my foster-father King Olaf said at Stiklestad when I noticed a slip of the tongue which he made — namely, that if it ever so happened that I should make a slip in my speech I should not expect to live long after it. It may be that my kinsman Thorfinn is still alive."

## 18.2

At that moment they heard that the house was surrounded by men. It was Earl Thorfinn and his men. They set the house on fire immediately, and heaped up a large pile before the door. Thorfinn permitted all others to come out except Earl Rögnvald's men, and when most of them had gone out a man came to the door dressed in linen clothes only, and asked Earl Thorfinn to lend a hand to the deacon; this man placed his hands on the wall and sprang over it and over the ring of men, and came down a great way off, and disappeared immediately in the darkness of the night. Earl Thorfinn told his men to go after him, saying: "There went the Earl, for that is his feat and no other man's." They went away, and divided into parties to search for him. Thorkel Fóstri with some others went along the beach, and they heard the barking of a dog among the rocks by the sea. Earl Rögnvald had had his favourite dog with him. Thorkel had the Earl seized, and asked his men to kill him, offering them a reward in money. But no one would do it. So Thorkel Fóstri slew Earl Rögnvald himself, as he knew that one of the two (Earls) must die. Then Earl Thorfinn came up, and did not find fault with the deed. They spent the night in the island, and all were killed who had accompanied Earl Rögnvald thither.

## 18.3

Next morning they took a barge and filled it with malt; then they went on board and ranged the shields which had belonged to Earl Rögnvald and his men along the bulwarks, neither had they more men in the barge than Rögnvald had had. So they rowed to Kirkiuvag (Kirkwall); and when those of Rögnvald's men who were there saw the vessel they thought it was Earl Rögnvald and his men returning, and they went unarmed to meet them. Thorfinn seized thirty of them and slew them; most of them were henchmen and friends of King Magnus. To one of the King's henchmen the Earl gave quarter, and told him to go east to Norway and tell King Magnus the tidings.

## Chapter 19 · EARL RÖGNVALD'S BURIAL

19.1

THE BODY OF Earl Rögnvald was brought to the larger Papey and buried there. Men said that he was one of the most accomplished and best-beloved of all the Earls of the Orkneys; and his death was greatly lamented by all the people.

19.2

After this Earl Thorfinn took possession of the whole of the Islands, and no one spoke against him.

19.3

Early in the spring these tidings came east to Norway to King Magnus. He regarded the death of Rögnvald, his foster-brother, as a great loss, and said he would avenge him by and by, but just then he was at war with King Swein, Ulf's son.

## Chapter 20 · EARL THORFINN COMES TO KING HARALD

20.1

ABOUT THIS TIME King Harald, Sigurd's son, King Magnus's uncle, arrived in Norway, and King Magnus gave him the half of the kingdom. One winter they called out men from the whole of Norway, intending to go south to Denmark, but while they lay in Seley two war ships rowed into the harbour and up to King Magnus's ship. A man in a white cloak went from the [strange] ship, and along the [King's] ship, and up to the quarterdeck. The King sat at meat; the man saluted him, and taking up a loaf he broke it and ate of it. The King received his salutation, and handed the cup to him when he saw that he ate the bread. The King looked at him and said: "Who is this man?"

20.2

"My name is Thorfinn," he said.

20.3

"Art thou Earl Thorfinn?" said the King.

20.4

“So am I called in the west,” he said, “and I am here with two ships of twenty benches, well manned considering our means, and I wish now to join in this expedition with you, if you will accept my assistance; all my men and I myself are in God’s power and yours, my lord, on account of my great misdeeds by which I have offended you.”

20.5

In the meantime some men gathered together and listened to their conversation.

20.6

“It is true, Earl Thorfinn” (said the King), “that I intended, in case we should meet, that you should not have to tell of our parting, but now matters stand so that it does not become my dignity to have you slain, and you shall go with me now, but the terms of our reconciliation I will declare when I am more at leisure.”

20.7

Earl Thorfinn thanked the King and returned to his ship. The King stayed a long time in Seley, and men gathered to him from Vík; for he intended to sail to Jutland when he obtained a fair wind. Thorfinn was often in conversation with the King, who treated him in a friendly manner, and had him frequently present at his councils.

20.8

One day the Earl went on board the King’s ship, and went up to the poop. The King asked him to sit down. The Earl sat down, and they both drank together and were merry. A tall brave-looking man, dressed in a red tunic, came to the poop and saluted the King, who received his greeting graciously. He was one of the King’s henchmen. He said: “I have come to see you, Earl Thorfinn.”

20.9

“What is your business with me?” said the Earl.

20.10

“I wish to know what compensation you intend to give me for my brother who was killed by your orders out west in Kirkiuvag (Kirkwall), along with others of King Magnus’s henchmen.”

20.11

“Have you never heard,” said the Earl, “that it is not my wont to pay money for the men whom I cause to be killed?”

20.12

“I have nothing to do with how you have treated other people, if you pay the manbote for him for whom it devolves on me to seek compensation. I also lost some money there myself, and was shamefully treated. It is more binding on me than any one else to seek redress for my brother and myself, and therefore I now demand it. The King may remit offences committed against himself, even if he thinks it of no importance that his henchmen are led out and slaughtered like sheep.”

20.13

The Earl answered: “I understand it to be to my advantage here that I am not in your power. Are not you the man to whom I gave quarter there?”

20.14

“True enough,” said he, “it was in your power to have killed me like the others.”

20.15

Then the Earl said: “Now the saying proves true— ‘That often happens to many which they least expect.’ I never thought I should be so placed that it would be injurious to me to have been too generous to my enemies; but now I have to pay for having given you quarter; you would not have denounced me to-day in the presence of chiefs if I had caused you to be killed like your comrades.”

20.16

The King looked at the Earl and said: “There it comes out still, Earl Thorfinn, that you think you have killed too few of my henchmen without compensation.” While saying this the king turned blood-red [with anger]. The Earl started up and left the poop, and returned to his own ship, and all was quiet during the evening. In the morning, when the men awoke, a fair wind had sprung up, and they rowed away from the harbour. The King sailed south to Jutland with the whole fleet. In

the earlier part of the day the Earl's ship stood out farther to sea, and in the afternoon he took a westerly course, and there is nothing to be told of him till he arrived in the Orkneys, and resumed the government of his dominions.

20.17

King Magnus and Harald sailed to Denmark, and spent the summer there. King Swein was unwilling to meet them, and stayed in Skàney with his army. That summer King Magnus was seized with an illness of which he died; but he had previously declared that he gave the whole kingdom of Norway to his uncle Harald.

## Chapter 21 · EARL THORFINN'S MESSAGE TO KING HARALD (HARDRADI)

21.1

EARL THORFINN NOW ruled the Orkneys and all his dominions. Kálf Arnason was frequently with him. Sometimes he made viking expeditions to the west, and plundered in Scotland and Ireland. He was also in England, and at one time he was the chief of the Thingmen.

21.2

When Earl Thorfinn heard of the death of King Magnus, he sent men to Norway to King Harald with a friendly message, saying that he wished to become his friend. When the messengers reached the King he received them well, and promised the Earl his friendship. When the Earl received this message from the King he made himself ready, taking from the west two ships of twenty benches, with more than a hundred men, all fine troops, and went east to Norway. He found the King in Hördaland, and he received him exceedingly well, and at their parting the King gave him handsome presents. From thence the Earl went southwards along the coast to Denmark. He went through the country, and found King Svein in Alaborg; he invited him to stay, and made a splendid feast for him. Then the Earl made it known that he was going to Rome; but when he came to Saxland he called on the Emperor Heinrek, who received him exceedingly well, and gave him many

valuable presents. He also gave him many horses, and the Earl rode south to Rome, and saw the Pope, from whom he obtained absolution for all his sins.

## 21.3

Then the Earl returned, and arrived safely home in his dominions. He left off making war expeditions, and turned his mind to the government of his land and his people, and to the making of laws. He resided frequently in Birgishérad (Birsay), and built there Christ's Kirk, a splendid church; and there was the first Bishop's see in the Orkneys.

## 21.4

Thorfinn's wife was Ingibiorg, [called] the mother of the Earls. They had two sons who arrived at manhood; one was called Paul, the other Erlend. They were men of large stature, fine-looking, wise, and gentle, more resembling their mother's relations. They were much loved by the Earl and all the people.

## Chapter 22 · OF EARL THORFINN'S DEATH

## 22.1

EARL THORFINN RETAINED all his dominions to his dying day, and it is truly said that he was the most powerful of all the Earls of the Orkneys. He obtained possession of eleven Earldoms in Scotland, all the Sudreyar (Hebrides), and a large territory in Ireland. So says Arnór Jarlaskáld —

## 22.2

Unto Thorfinn, ravens' feeder,  
Armies had to yield obedience  
From Thussaker right on to Dublin.

## 22.3

Truth I tell, as is recorded.

## 22.4

Earl Thorfinn was five winters old when Malcolm the King of Scots, his mother's father, gave him the title of Earl, and after that he was Earl

for seventy winters. He died towards the end of Harald Sigurdson's reign. He is buried at Christ's Kirk in Birgishérad (Birsay), which he had built. He was much lamented in his hereditary dominions; but in those parts which he had conquered by force of arms many considered it very hard to be under his rule, and [after his death] many provinces which he had subdued turned away and sought help from the chiefs who were odal-born to the government of them. Then it soon became apparent how great a loss Thorfinn's death was to his dominions.

## 22.5

The following stanzas were made about the battle between Earl Rögnvald, Brúsi's son, and Earl Thorfinn: —

## 22.6

Since the Earls have broken friendship  
 Peace I can enjoy no longer.  
 Feasts of corpses to the ravens  
 Each has in his turn provided.  
 Off the Islands were the blue tents  
 By the mighty rent asunder,  
 Dabbled were the foul birds' feathers  
 In red blood 'neath lofty branches.  
 Have ye heard how Kalfr followed  
 Finn's son-in-law in battle?  
 Quickly didst thou push thy vessels  
 'Gainst the Earl's ships on the water.  
 To destroy the son of Brúsi,  
 Thou, courageous ship's commander  
 Wast unwilling, but of hatred  
 Mindful, didst thou help Thorfinn.  
 When the Earls had joined in battle  
 Misery there was unbounded.  
 Thick and fast the men were falling  
 In the struggle; sad the hour when  
 Nearer went the daring Eastmen

To the unexampled fire-rain.  
 In that battle off the Red Biorg  
 Many a noble man was wounded.  
 Swarthy shall become the bright sun,  
 In the black sea shall the earth sink,  
 Finished shall be Austri's labour,  
 And the wild sea hide the mountains,  
 Ere there be in those fair Islands  
 Born a chief to rule the people —  
 May our God both help and keep them —  
 Greater than the lost Earl Thorfinn.

## Chapter 23 · OF THE EARLS PAUL AND ERLEND, AND GENEALOGIES

### 23.1

NOW THE SONS of Earl Thorfinn succeeded him. Paul was the elder of the two, and he ruled for both of them. They did not divide their possessions, yet they almost always agreed in their dealings.

### 23.2

Ingibjorg, the mother of the Earls, was married to Malcolm, King of Scots, who was called Langhál (Longneck), and their son was Duncan, King of Scots, the father of William the excellent man; his son was called William Odling (the Noble), whom all the Scots wished to have for their King.

### 23.3

Earl Paul, Thorfinn's son, married the daughter of Earl Hákon, Ivar's son, by whom he had many children. They had a son called Hákon, and a daughter called Thóra, who was married in Norway to Haldór, son of Brynjúlf Ulfaldi (camel). Another son of theirs, named Brynjúlf, married Gyrid, Dag's daughter. A second daughter of Paul, called Ingirid, was married to Einar Vorsakrák. Herbiörg was the third daughter of Paul. She was the mother of Ingibjorg Ragna, who was married to Sigurd of Westness; their sons were Hákon Pík, and

Brynjúlf. Sigrid was a second daughter of Herbiörg. She was the mother of Hakon Barn and of Herborg, who was married to Kolbein Hruga. The fourth daughter of Earl Paul was Ragnhild, who was the mother of Benidikt, the father of Ingibiorg, the mother of Erling Erkidiákn (archdeacon). Ragnhild had a daughter, by name Bergliót, who was married to Hávard, Gunnar's son. Their sons were Magnus, Hákon Kló (claw), Dúfniál, and Thorstein. All those were the families of Earls and chiefs in the Orkneys, and all of them will be mentioned in this Saga afterwards. The wife of Earl Erlend, Thorfinn's son, was Thóra, the daughter of Sumarlidi, Ospak's son; the mother of Ospak was Thórdís, the daughter of Hall of Síða (in Iceland). Their sons were Erling and Magnus, and their daughters Gunnhild, and Cecilia, who was married to Isak, and their sons were Indridi and Kol. Erling had a natural daughter called Játvör; her son was Berg.

## Chapter 24 · HERE IS TOLD OF THE DEATH OF KING HARALD AND HIS DAUGHTER

### 24.1

WHEN THE BROTHERS Paul and Erlend had succeeded to the government of the Orkneys, King Harald Sigurdson (Hardradi) came from Norway with a large army. He first touched Hjaltland; from thence he went to the Orkneys, and left there his Queen Ellisif, and their daughters Maria and Ingigerd. From the Orkneys he had many troops; both the Earls went with him on the expedition. He went from Orkney to England, and landed at a place called Klifland (Cleaveland), and took Skardaborg (Scarborough). Then he touched at Hallarnes (Holderness), and had a battle there, in which he was victorious. The Wednesday next before Matthiasmas (20th September) he had a battle at Jórvík (York) with the Earls Valthióf and Mórúkári. Mórúkári was slain there. Next Sunday the borg at Stamfordbridge surrendered to him; and he went on shore to arrange the government of the town; and there he left his son Olaf, the Earls Paul and Erlend, and his brother-in-law Eystein Orri. While he was on shore he was met by

Harald Gudínason (Godwinson) at the head of a numerous army. In that battle King Harald Sigurdson fell. After the death of the King, Eystein Orri and the Earls arrived from the ship, and made a stout resistance. There Eystein Orri fell, and almost the whole army of the Northmen with him.

## 24.2

After the battle King Harald (Godwinson) permitted Olaf, the son of King Harald Sigurdson, and the Earls to leave England, with all the troops that had not fled. Olaf sailed in the autumn from Hrafnseyri to the Orkneys. The same day and at the same hour as King Harald fell, his daughter Maria died, and it is said that they had but one life.

## 24.3

Olaf spent the winter in the Orkneys, and was very friendly to the Earls, his kinsmen. Thóra, the mother of King Olaf, and Ingibiorg, the mother of the Earls, were daughters of two brothers. In the spring Olaf went to Norway, and was made King along with his brother Magnus.

## 24.4

While the brothers (Paul and Erlend) ruled the Orkneys they agreed extremely well a long time; but when their sons came to manhood Erling and Hákon became very violent. Magnus was the quietest of them all. They were all men of large stature, and strong, and accomplished in everything. Hákon, Paul's son, wished to take the lead among his brothers; he considered himself of higher birth than the sons of Erlend, as he was the daughter's son of Earl Hákon Ivar's son, and Ragnhild, the daughter of King Magnus the Good. Hákon wished his friends to have the lion's share of everything before those who leant to the sons of Erlend, but Erlend did not like his sons to be inferior to any in the Islands. Matters went so far that the kinsmen could not be together without danger. Then their fathers persuaded them to compose their differences. A meeting was appointed, but it soon became apparent that each [of the fathers] was inclined to take the part of his sons, and therefore they did not agree. Thus dissensions

arose between the brothers, and they parted without coming to an agreement, which was by many considered a great misfortune.

## Chapter 25 · A MEETING OF PEACE

### 25.1

AFTER THIS WELL-DISPOSED men interfered and tried to reconcile them. A meeting for reconciliation was appointed in Hrossey, and at that meeting they made peace on the understanding that the Islands should be divided in two shares, as they had been between Thorfinn and Brúsi, and thus matters stood for a while.

### 25.2

When Hákon had arrived at the age of manhood he was continually on war expeditions. He became a very violent man, and greatly molested those who adhered to Erlend and his sons; and this went so far that they came to open enmity a second time, and attacked each other with numerous troops. Hávard, Gunnar's son, and all the principal friends of the Earls, consulted once more and tried to make peace between them. This time Erlend and his sons refused to make peace if Hákon remained in the Islands; and because their friends considered their quarrels so dangerous to themselves, they besought Hákon not to let the condition that he should leave the Islands for a time stand in the way of peace. Then, by the advice of good men, they became reconciled.

### 25.3

After this Hákon left the Islands, and first went east to Norway, and saw there King Olaf Kyrri (the quiet), and stayed with him for a while. This was towards the end of his reign. After that he went east to Sweden to King Ingi, Steinkel's son, who received him well. He found friends and kinsmen there, and was highly honoured on account of the esteem in which Hákon, his mother's father, was held. He had possessions from Steinkel, the King of the Swedes, ever since he was banished by King Harald, Sigurd's son, and became greatly beloved both by the King and the people. A second daughter's son of Earl Hákon, Ivar's son, was Hákon who was called the Norwegian; he was the father of King Eirík

Spaki (the wise), who was King of Denmark after Eirík Eymuni (the ever-remembered).

25.4

Hákon remained in Sweden for a while, and was well treated by King Ingi. But when some time had passed in this way he felt so home-sick that he wanted to go west again to the Islands. Christianity then was young, and newly planted in Sweden. Many men still dabbled in ancient lore, and were persuaded that by such means they were able to ascertain future events. King Ingi was a good Christian man, and loathed all those that meddled in ancient [superstitious] lore, and made strenuous efforts to abolish the evil customs which for a long time had accompanied heathenism; but the chiefs and leading Bøendr murmured loudly if they were reproved for their evil habits, and at last matters went so far that the Bøendr elected another King, Swein, the brother of the Queen, who permitted them to make sacrifices, and was therefore called “Sacrificing Swein.” King Ingi had to flee from him to Western Gautland (Gothland); but their dealings ended thus, that King Ingi caught Swein by surprise in a house, and burnt the house and him in it. After this he subdued the whole country, and uprooted many wicked customs.

## Chapter 26 · OF THE WORDS OF THE SPAE-MAN

26.1

WHEN HÁKON, PAUL’S son, was in Sweden he had heard of a man in that country who practised sorcery and spae-craft, whether he used for those purposes witchcraft or other magical arts. Hákon became very curious to see this man, and anxious to know what he could ascertain about his future. So he went in search of the man, and at last he found him in a seaside district, where he went from one feast to another, and foretold the seasons and other things to the country people. When Hákon had found this man, he inquired of him whether he would succeed in regaining his dominions, or what other fortune

awaited him. The spae-man asked him who he was, and he told him his name and family — that he was the daughter's son of Hákon, Ivar's son.

26.2

The spae-man then said: "Why should you ask foresight or knowledge of the future from me? You know well that your kinsmen have had little liking for such men as I am; and yet it might be necessary for you to try to ascertain your fate from your friend, Olaf the Stout, in whom all your faith is placed; but I suspect that he would not condescend to tell you what you are anxious to know, or else he may not be so mighty as you call him."

26.3

Hákon answered: "I will not reproach him, and I should rather think I was not worthy to learn wisdom from him, than that he was incapable; so that I might learn from him for that matter. But I have come to you, because I thought that we had no reason to envy each other on account of virtue or religion."

26.4

The spae-man replied: "I am glad to find that you place your entire trust in me, and not in that faith which you and your kinsmen profess. Truly they who apply themselves to such things are strange men. They keep fasts and vigils, and believe that by such means they will be able to ascertain that which they desire to know; but the more they apply themselves to these things, the less they ascertain of what they wish to know when it is most important to them to know it. But we undergo no bodily pains, yet we always obtain knowledge of those things which it is of importance to our friends not to be ignorant of. Now matters will go between us in this way, that I shall help you because I understand that you think you will rather obtain the truth from me than from the preachers of King Ingi, in whom he puts his entire trust. After three nights' time you shall come to me, and then we shall try whether I may be able to tell you any of the things you wish to know."

26.5

Upon this they parted, and Hákon stayed in the district. When three nights had passed, he went again to see the spae-man. He was in a certain house alone, and groaned heavily as Hákon entered. He passed his hand across his forehead, and said that it had cost him much pain to obtain the knowledge which Hákon desired. Hákon then said he wished to hear his future.

26.6

The spae-man said: "If you wish your whole fate unfolded, it is long to tell, for there is a great future in store for you, and grand events will happen at certain periods of your life. I foresee that you will at last become the sole ruler of the Orkneys; but you will perhaps think you have long to wait. I also see that your sons will rule there. Your next journey to the Orkneys will be a very eventful one, when its consequences appear. In your days you will also commit a crime, for which you may or may not obtain pardon from the God in whom you believe. Your steps go farther out into the world than I am able to trace, yet I think you will rest your bones in the northern parts. Now I have told you what has been given me to tell you at this time, but what satisfaction you may have derived from your visit rests with yourself."

26.7

Hákon replied: "Great things you have foretold, if they turn out to be true; but I think my fate will prove itself better than you have said; and perhaps you have not seen the truth."

26.8

The spae-man said he was free to believe what he liked of it, but that such events would not the less surely come to pass.

## Chapter 27 · OF THE SCHEMES OF HAKON, PAUL'S SON

27.1

AFTER THIS HÁKON went to see King Ingi, and stayed with him a short while. Then he obtained leave from the King to depart. He went first to Norway to see his kinsman, King Magnus, who received him very well. There he heard that the government of the Orkneys was almost

exclusively in the hands of Earl Erlend and his sons, and that they were greatly loved, but that his father Paul took little part in the government. He also thought he could perceive from conversations with men from the Orkneys, who gave him a true account of the state of matters, that the Orkneymen had no desire for his return home. They were living in peace and quiet, and were afraid that Hákon's return would give rise to disturbance and strife. When Hákon was turning this over in his mind, he thought it likely that his kinsmen would try to keep him out of his possessions, and that it would be dangerous for him if he did not go west with a numerous retinue. Then he devised a scheme to induce King Magnus to put him into his possessions in the Orkneys.

## Chapter 28 · HAKON'S INTERVIEW WITH KING MAGNUS

### 28.1

THIS WAS AFTER King Magnus had put Steigar Thórir and Egil to death, and put down all opposition to his rule. Hákon was a sagacious man, and he thought he could understand from King Magnus's conversation that he was ambitious of grand undertakings, and covetous of the possessions of other rulers. Hákon began to tell the King that it would be a princely feat to make an expedition to the west, and subdue the Islands, as Harald the Fairhaired had done. He also said that if he established his power in the Sudreyar (Hebrides), he might easily make forays into Ireland and Scotland from them. Then, having subdued the western countries, he might attack the English, with the help of the Northmen, and thus take revenge for his grandfather Harald, Sigurd's son.

### 28.2

When they were speaking about these things, it became evident that the King was pleased with this proposal, and said it was spoken like a nobleman, and quite according to his own mind. "But I wish you not to be surprised, Hákon," said the King, "in case I shall be persuaded by your words to carry an army into the west, if I put forward a strong

claim to the possessions there, without regard to the claims of any man.”

28.3

When Hákon heard this suggestion, he was not so well pleased, because he suspected the real meaning of the King's words; and after this he no longer persuaded the King to go; neither was it required, for after their conversation, the King sent messages throughout his dominions to make known that he was soon to lead out an expedition, and then he made it known to the people that he was going to the west, whatever might be the result. Preparations were made for the expedition throughout the whole kingdom. King Magnus took with him his son Sigurd, who was eight winters old, and a hopeful boy.

## Chapter 29 · THE WESTERN EXPEDITION OF MAGNUS BARELEGS

29.1

WHEN THE BROTHERS Paul and Erlend ruled the Orkneys, King Magnus came from Norway. He had a large army. Many of his vassals followed him, among whom were Vidkunn Jonsson, Sigurd Hrani's son, Serk from Sogn, Dag Eilif's son, Skapti from Gizki, Ogmund, Finn and Thórd, Eyvind Olnbogi (the King's High Steward), Kali, Snæbiörn's son from Agdir, the son of Thorleif Spaki (the wise) who was maimed by Hallfred, and Kol his son. Kali was a very wise man, much esteemed by the king, and made verses well.

29.2

When King Magnus came to the Orkneys, he seized the Earls Paul and Erlend, and sent them east to Norway, but placed his son Sigurd over the Isles, and gave him counsellors. King Magnus went to the Sudreyar (Hebrides), accompanied by Magnus and Erling, the sons of Earl Erlend, and Hákon, Paul's son. But when King Magnus came to the Islands, he began hostilities first at Liódhús (Lewis), and gained a victory there. In this expedition he subdued the whole of the Sudreyar, and seized Lögman, the son of Gudröd, King of the Western Islands. Thence he

went to Bretland (Wales), and fought a great battle in Anglesea Sound with two British chiefs — Hugh the Stout and Hugh the Bold. When the men took up their arms and buckled for the fight, Magnus, Erlend's son, sat down on the foredeck, and did not take his arms. The King asked why he did not do so. He said he had nothing against any one there, and would not therefore fight.

29.3

The King said: "Go down below, and do not lie among other people's feet if you dare not fight, for I do not believe that you do this from religious motives."

29.4

Magnus took a psalter and sang during the battle, and did not shelter himself. The battle was long and fiercely contested, and both swords and missiles were used. For a long time the result of the battle was doubtful. King Magnus shot from a bow, and a man from Hálogaland was with him. Hugh the Bold fought valiantly. He had a suit of armour which covered him entirely, except his eyes. King Magnus ordered the man from Hálogaland to shoot at the same time as he did, and they shot both at once. One of the arrows struck the nose-piece of the helmet, and the other pierced the eye, and that was said to be the king's arrow.

## Chapter 30 · KALI'S DEATH

30.1

AFTER HUGH'S DEATH the British (Normans) fled, and King Magnus obtained a great victory. He lost there many brave men, and many others were wounded. Kali had received many wounds, but none mortal. After the battle King Magnus sailed from the south along the coasts of Bretland and Scotland, having conquered all the Sudreyar and Anglesea, which is one-third of Bretland.

30.2

King Magnus had appointed Magnus, Erlend's son, as one of the waiters at his table, and he performed continually the duties of that office; but

after the battle in Anglesea Sound the king showed that Magnus had incurred his serious displeasure. He had not been wounded, although he had not sheltered himself. During the night he stole away from the King, and hid himself for some time in the woods, while the King's men made a search for him. Magnus made his way to the court of Malcolm, the King of Scots, and remained there a while. For some time he was with a certain bishop in Bretland. He was also in England; but he did not come to the Orkneys while King Magnus was alive.

## 30.3

King Magnus held northward, along the coasts of Scotland, and messengers came to him from Malcolm, the King of Scots, to ask for peace. They said that the King of Scots was willing to give him all the islands lying west of Scotland, between which and the mainland he could pass in a vessel with the rudder shipped. Thereupon King Magnus landed in Satiri (Kintyre), and had a boat drawn across the neck (isthmus) of Satiri, he himself holding the helm, and thus he gained possession of the whole of Satiri, which is better than the best island of the Sudreyar, Man excepted. It is in the west of Scotland, and on the land side there is a narrow isthmus, across which vessels are frequently drawn. Thence King Magnus went to the Sudreyar, and sent his men into Scotland's Fiord. They rowed in along one coast and out along another, and thus took possession of all the islands west of Scotland.

## 30.4

Then the King made it known that he was going to spend the winter in the Sudreyar, but gave permission to those who had most urgent business to go home. When the troops knew this, they all wished to go home, and murmured greatly at being longer detained. The King then held a council with his advisers, and looked at the wounds of his men. He saw Kali, and asked about his wounds. Kali said they did not heal well, and that he did not know what the end would be. The King asked for his advice. Kali said: "Is it not so that your friends are now failing you?" The King said he did not think so. Kali asked him to hold a wapinschaw, and thus to ascertain the number of his troops. This the

King did; then he missed many men. This he told to Kali. Then Kali sang:

30.5

How do thy great chiefs repay thee  
For the bounties lavished on them?

30.6

Now, O King, of this make trial —  
On western currents ships are shaken.

30.7

The King replied:

30.8

Surely it was in my folly  
That my wealth I gave to these men;  
Yet my long ships, swiftly speeding,  
Still shall climb the chilly billows.

30.9

After this the King kept a watch to prevent men from deserting.

30.10

When King Magnus was in the Sudreyar, he obtained the hand of Biadmonia, the daughter of Mýrkiartan, the son of Thiálbi, the King of the Irish in Kunnáttir (Connaught), for his son Sigurd, who was then nine winters old, and she five. This winter Kali died from his wounds. Sigurd Sneis (slice), Kali's kinsman, a Lenderman from Agdir, had fallen in Anglesea Sound.

## Chapter 31 · BIRTH OF KALI, SON OF KOL

31.1

EARLY IN THE spring King Magnus left the Sudreyar, and went first to the Orkneys, where he heard of the death of the Earls. Erlend died in Nidaros, and was buried there; and Paul died in Biörgvin (Bergen). Then King Magnus married Gunnhild, the daughter of Earl Erlend, to Kol, Kali's son, in order to compensate him for (the loss of) his father. Her dowry consisted of possessions in the Orkneys, including a farm at

Papul. Some say that Erling, Erlend's son, fell in Anglesea Sound, but Snorri Sturluson says he fell in Uladstir with King Magnus. At his wedding Kol became King Magnus's vassal. Afterwards he went to Norway with the King, and home to Agdir with his wife, and went to reside at his estates there. Kol and Gunnhild had two children; their son was called Kali, and their daughter Ingirid. They were both very promising children, and brought up with affectionate care.

## Chapter 32 · SIGURD MADE KING

### 32.1

WHEN MAGNUS HAD been king nine winters, he went to the west, and made war in Ireland, and spent the winter in Kunnáttir (Connaught). The next summer, on St. Bartholomew's Day, he fell in Uladstir (Ulster). When Sigurd heard in the Orkneys of the death of his father, he went immediately to Norway, and was made king, along with his brothers Eystein and Olaf. He had left the daughter of the Irish king in the west.

### 32.2

One winter or two after the death of King Magnus, Hákon, Paul's son, came from the west, and the kings gave him an earl's title and possessions beseeming his birth. Then he returned to the west and took possession of the Orkneys. He had always accompanied King Magnus while he was alive. He was with him in his expedition to Gautland, which is mentioned in the song made about Hákon, Paul's son.

## Chapter 33 · MAGNUS (ERLEND'S SON) OBTAINS THE TITLE OF EARL

### 33.1

WHEN EARL HÁKON had ruled the Orkneys for some time, Magnus, the son of Earl Erlend, came from Scotland, and wished to take possession of his patrimony. The Böendr were highly pleased with this, for he was beloved among them, and had many kinsmen and connections who wished to help him to his dominions. His mother was married to a man

called Sigurd. Their son was named Hákon Karl (man). They had estates in Papul. When Earl Hákon heard that Earl Magnus had come to the Orkneys, he collected men together, and refused to give up any part of the Islands. But their friends tried to make peace between them, and at last they succeeded so far that Hákon consented to give up half of his dominions if the Kings of Norway approved of it. Magnus went immediately to Norway to see King Eystein, for King Sigurd had then gone to Jerusalem. King Eystein received him exceedingly well, and gave up to him his patrimony, one-half of the Orkneys, with the title of Earl. Thereupon Magnus went west to his dominions, and his kinsmen and friends and all the people were glad to see him back. Through the kind offices of mutual friends, Magnus and Hákon agreed very well. So long as their friendship continued there were good times and peace in the Orkneys.

### Chapter 34 · OF EARL MAGNUS (ERLEND'S SON)

#### 34.1

THE HOLY MAGNUS, Earl of the Islands, was a most excellent man. He was of large stature, a man of a noble presence and intellectual countenance. He was of blameless life, victorious in battles, wise, eloquent, strong-minded, liberal and magnanimous, sagacious in counsels, and more beloved than any other man. To wise men and good he was gentle and affable in his conversation; but severe and unsparing with robbers and vikings. Many of those who plundered the landowners and the inhabitants of the land he caused to be put to death. He also seized murderers and thieves, and punished rich and poor impartially for robberies and thefts and all crimes. He was just in his judgments, and had more respect to divine justice than difference in the estates of men. He gave large presents to chiefs and rich men, yet the greatest share of his liberality was given to the poor. In all things he strictly obeyed the divine commands; and he chastened his body in many things, which in his glorious life were known to God, but hidden from men. Thus, he made known his intention to espouse a maiden of a

most excellent family in Scotland, and having celebrated his marriage, he lived with her for ten winters free from the defilement of carnal lusts, for he was pure and spotless with regard to all such sins, and if he were tempted, he bathed in cold water, and prayed for divine assistance. Many other glorious virtues he exhibited to God himself, but concealed from men.

## Chapter 35 · OF MAGNUS AND HAKON

35.1

MAGNUS AND HÁKON ruled their lands and defended them for some time, the two agreeing very well. In a song made about them, it is said that they fought with a chief called Dúfniál, their third cousin, who fell before them. They also slew a famous man named Thorbiörn, in Borgarfiord, in Hjaltland. Other deeds of theirs are set forth in song, though not specially narrated here. When they had ruled the land for some time, it happened, as often is the case, that men of evil dispositions were found who destroyed their good understanding. Hákon was more disposed to listen to these miserable men, because he was very jealous of the popularity and greatness of his kinsman Magnus.

## Chapter 36 · OF EARL MAGNUS

36.1

TWO MEN WITH Earl Hákon are chiefly mentioned as being the worst in creating enmity between the two kinsmen. These were Sigurd and Sighvat Sokki (sock). Through the slander of wicked men this enmity went so far that the Earls gathered troops together and went to meet each other. Both went to Hrossey, where the Orkney Thingstead was, and when they arrived there, both drew up their troops in battle array, and prepared to fight. There were both the Earls and all the chief men, many (of whom) were friends of both, and did all they could to make peace between them, showing much goodwill and virtuous disposition. This meeting was during Lent. But, as many well-disposed

men joined themselves together to avert hostilities between them, and to assist neither of them against the other, they confirmed their reconciliation with oaths and shaking of hands.

## 36.2

Some time after this, Earl Hákon, with hypocrisy and fair words, appointed a day of meeting with the blessed Earl Magnus, so that their friendship and the newly-made peace should neither be disturbed nor destroyed. This meeting, which was to confirm their peace and reconciliation, should take place in the spring, in the Pasch week, in Egilsey. Earl Magnus was well pleased with this arrangement, as he thought it was meant to confirm a sincere peace, without any suspicions, treachery, or covetousness. Each of them should have two ships and an equal number of men (at the conference). Both swore to keep the peace, on conditions dictated by the wisest men.

## 36.3

Immediately after Easter, preparations were made for the meeting. Earl Magnus summoned all those whom he knew to be best disposed to him, and most likely to make matters smooth between them. He had two ships, and as many men as had been agreed upon, and when he was ready he went to Egilsey. As they were rowing in calm and smooth water a great wave rose under the ship, which was steered by the Earl, and broke over it where he sat. His men wondered very much at such an occurrence, — that a breaker should rise in smooth water where no man could remember a breaker to have arisen, and where the water was so deep. Then the Earl said: “No wonder that you are surprised at this. Indeed, I take this as a foreboding of my death. Perhaps it will come to pass as was prophesied about Earl Hákon, and this may be to prepare us for Hákon, my kinsman, not dealing honestly with me at this meeting.” The Earl’s men became very sorrowful when he spoke of his death being near at hand, and begged him to take care of his life, and not to trust himself to the good faith of Earl Hákon. Earl Magnus answered: “Let us go this time, and let all that depends on our journey be in God’s will.”

## Chapter 37 · EARL HAKON AND EARL MAGNUS

37.1

NOW IT IS to be told of Earl Hákon that he gathered together a numerous army, and had many ships equipped as if for battle. And when the troops were assembled, he made known to his men that he intended that this meeting should decide between him and Earl Magnus, so that both of them should not rule over the Orkneys. Many of his men approved of this plan, adding many wicked suggestions to it, yet Sigurd and Sighvat Sokki counselled the worst things.

37.2

Then they began to row fast, and went along quickly. Hávard, Gunnar's son, who was the friend and counsellor of the Earls, and equally faithful to both, was on board the Earl's ship. Hákon had concealed this wicked plan from him, in which he would by no means have had any part. And when he knew that the Earl was so resolute in this wicked purpose, he jumped overboard, and swam to a certain uninhabited island.

37.3

Earl Magnus arrived first with his men at Egilsey, and when they saw Earl Hákon coming they perceived that he had eight war-ships. Then Earl Magnus suspected that he intended to act treacherously towards him. So he walked along the island with his men, and went into the church to pray. His men offered to defend him. The Earl replied: "I will not put your lives in danger for mine, and if peace cannot be established between us, let it be as God wills." His men now recognised the truth of his words, and as he foreknew the hours of his life — whether from his wisdom or from a divine revelation — he would neither fly nor avoid his enemies. He prayed devoutly, and had a mass sung for him.

## Chapter 38 · THE OFFERS OF EARL MAGNUS

38.1

HAKON AND HIS men came up in the morning, and ran first to the church and ransacked it, but did not find the Earl. He had gone to another part of the island, to a certain hiding-place, accompanied by two men. But when the holy Earl Magnus saw that they searched for him, he called to them, and thus made known to them where he was, and said they need search no farther. And when Hákon saw him, he and his men ran thither with loud yelling and clangour of their weapons.

38.2

Earl Magnus was praying when they came up to him, and when he had finished his prayer he made the sign of the cross, and said firmly to Earl Hákon: “You did not act well, kinsman, when you broke your oaths, and it is highly probable that you were instigated to this more by the wickedness of others than your own. Now, I will make you three offers, that you may rather accept one of them than break your oaths, and slay me who am innocent.”

38.3

Hákon’s men asked what these offers were.

38.4

“The first is, that I shall go to Rome, or away to Jerusalem, and visit the holy places, taking with me two ships from the Orkneys, with the necessary equipment for the journey, and obtain benefits for the souls of us both. I shall swear never to return to the Orkneys.”

38.5

This offer was promptly rejected.

38.6

Then said Earl Magnus: “Now, because my life is in your power, and I have offended against Almighty God in many things, you shall send me to Scotland, to our mutual friends, and keep me in custody there, with two men for companionship. Make such provision that I shall not be able to escape from this custody.”

38.7

This too was promptly refused.

38.8

Magnus then said: “There is yet one more offer which I will make, and God knows that I think more of your soul than of my own life, for it were better that you should do as I shall offer you than that you should take my life. Let me be maimed as you like, or deprived of my eyes, and throw me into a dark dungeon.”

38.9

Then said Earl Hákon: “This offer I accept, and I ask for no more.”

38.10

But the chiefs started up and said to Earl Hákon: “One of you will we kill now, and from this day you shall not both rule the lands of the Orkneys.”

38.11

Earl Hákon replied: “Slay him then, for I will rather have earldom and lands than instant death.”

38.12

Thus their conversation was related by Höldbodi, a truthful Bondi in the Sudreyar, who was one of the two of Earl Magnus’s men who were with him when he was taken.

## Chapter 39 · THE BEHEADING OF EARL MAGNUS

39.1

THE WORTHY EARL Magnus was as cheerful as if he were invited to a banquet, and spoke neither words of offence nor anger. After these words had passed, he fell on his knees to pray, hiding his face in his hands, and shedding many tears before God. Then, when the holy Earl Magnus was thus doomed to death, Hákon ordered his banner-bearer, Ofeig, to slay the Earl, but he refused, with the utmost wrath. Then forced he Lífólf, his cook, to be the slayer of Magnus, but he began to weep aloud. “Weep not thus,” said Earl Magnus, “for this is an honourable task. Be firm, and you shall have my clothing, according to the custom and laws of the men of old. Be not afraid, for you do this against your will, and he who forces you sins more than you.”

39.2

When he had said this, he took off his tunic and gave it to Lífólf. Then he asked for permission to pray, which was granted to him. He fell upon the earth, and gave himself to God, offering himself as a sacrifice. He prayed not only for his friends, but also for his enemies and murderers, and forgave them, with all his heart, their offences against himself. He confessed his sins to God, and prayed that they might be washed from him in the shedding of his blood. He commended his spirit to God's keeping, and prayed that His angels might come to meet his soul and carry it into the rest of paradise. Some say that he took the sacrament when the mass was sung. Then, when God's friend was led to execution, he said to Lífólf: "Stand before me, and hew me a mighty stroke on the head, for it is not fitting that high-born lords should be put to death like thieves. Be firm, poor man, for I have prayed to God for you, that he may have mercy upon you." After that he signed the sign of the cross, and stooped under the blow, and his spirit passed into heaven.

## Chapter 40 · THE SAINTSHIP OF EARL MAGNUS MADE MANIFEST

40.1

THE PLACE WHERE Earl Magnus was slain was previously covered with moss and stones, but shortly afterwards his merits before God became manifest in this wise, that it became green sward where he was beheaded. Thus God showed that he had suffered for righteousness' sake, and had obtained the beauty and verdure of paradise, which is called the land of the living.

40.2

Earl Hákon did not permit his body to be brought to the church (for burial).

40.3

The day of Earl Magnus's death was two days after Tiburtiusmas (14th April). Then he had been seven winters Earl in the Orkneys along with

Earl Hákon. Seventy-four winters had passed since the death of King Olaf. The Kings of Norway were at this time Sigurd, Eystein, and Olaf. It was one thousand and ninety-one winters after the birth of Christ.

## Chapter 41 · THE EARL'S BODY BROUGHT TO CHURCH

### 41.1

THORA, THE MOTHER of Earl Magnus, had invited both the Earls to a banquet after their meeting, and Earl Hákon went there after the murder of the holy Earl Magnus. Thóra herself served at the banquet, and brought the drink to the Earl and his men who had been present at the murder of her son. And when the drink began to have effect on the Earl, then went Thóra before him and said: “You came alone here, my lord, but I expected you both. Now, I hope you will gladden me in the sight of God and men. Be to me in stead of a son, and I shall be to you in stead of a mother. I stand greatly in need of your mercy now, and (I pray you to) permit me to bring my son to church. Hear this my supplication now, as you wish God to look upon you at the day of doom.”

### 41.2

The Earl became silent, and considered her case, as she prayed so meekly, and with tears, that her son might be brought to church. He looked upon her, and the tears fell, and he said, “Bury your son where it pleases you.”

### 41.3

Then the Earl's body was brought to Hrossey, and buried at Christ's Kirk (in Birsay), which had been built by Earl Thorfinn.

## Chapter 62 · THE MIRACLE-WORKING OF MAGNUS THE MARTYR

### 62.1

SOON AFTER THIS a heavenly light was seen above his burial-place. Then men who were placed in danger began to pray to him, and their prayers were heard. A heavenly odour was frequently perceived above

his burial-place, from which people suffering from illness received health. Then sufferers made pilgrimages thither both from the Orkneys and Hjaltland, and kept vigils at his grave, and were cured of all their sufferings. But people dared not make this known while Earl Hákon was alive.

62.2

It is said of the men who were most guilty in the murder of the holy Earl Magnus that most of them met with a miserable death.

### Chapter 43 · THE MIRACLES WROUGHT BY THE BLESSED FRIEND OF GOD, MAGNUS

43.1

WILLIAM WAS BISHOP of the Orkneys at this time. He was the first bishop there. The bishop's seat was at Christ's Kirk in Birgishérad (Birsay). William was bishop for six winters of the seventh decade. For a long time he disbelieved in the sanctity of Earl Magnus, until his merits became manifest to such a degree that God made his holiness grow the more conspicuous the more it was tried, as is told in the book of his miracles.

### Chapter 44 · THE JOURNEY OF EARL HAKON TO THE SOUTH

44.1

AFTER THE MURDER of Earl Magnus, Hákon, Paul's son, took possession of all the Orkneys, and exacted an oath of fealty from all men, and took submission from those who had served Earl Magnus. He became a great chief, and made heavy exactions from those of Earl Magnus's friends who in his opinion had taken part against him.

44.2

Some winters after this he prepared to leave the country, and went to Rome. Then he also went to Jerusalem, according to the custom of the palmers, and brought away sacred relics, and bathed in the river Jordan. After that he returned to his dominions, and resumed the government of the Orkneys. He became a good ruler, and established

peace throughout his dominions; he also made new laws for the Orkneys, which the landowners liked better than the former ones. Then he became so popular that the Orkneymen desired no other rulers than Hákon and his issue.

## Chapter 45 · GENEALOGICAL

### 45.1

WHEN EARL HÁKON ruled over the Orkneys there lived a noble and wealthy man, by name Moddan, at Dal (Dale), in Caithness. His daughters were Helga and Frákork Thórleif. Helga, Moddan's daughter, was the concubine of Earl Hákon, and their son was Harald, who was called Sléttmáli (smooth-talker), and their daughter was Ingibiorg, who was married to Olaf Bitling (little bit), the King of the Sudreyar. Their second daughter was Margarét. Moddan's daughter, Frákork, was married to a man who was named Liót Níding (miscreant), in Sutherland, and their daughter was Steinvör the Stout, who was married to Thorliót, at Rekavík. Their sons were Olvir Rosta (strife), Magnus Orm, and Moddan Eindridi, and their daughter Audhild. A second daughter of Frákork was Gudrún, married to Thorstein Höld, Fiaransmunn (open-mouth). Their son was Thorbiörn Klerk (clerk).

### 45.2

Hákon, Paul's son, had a son named Paul, who was called Umálgi (speechless); he was a reserved man, but popular. When the brothers grew up they never agreed. Hákon, Paul's son, died on a sick-bed in the Islands, and his death was considered a great loss, for in the later days of his reign there was unbroken peace, and the Islanders suspected that the brothers would not agree well.

## Chapter 46 · THE SLAYING OF THORKEL FÓSTRÍ

### 46.1

AFTER THE DEATH of Earl Hákon, his sons succeeded him; but they soon disagreed, and divided the dominions between them. Then also dissensions arose between the great men, and the vassals of each were

divided into factions. Earl Harald held Caithness from the King of the Scots, and he resided frequently there, but sometimes also in Scotland (Sutherland?), for he had many friends and kinsmen there.

## 46.2

When Earl Harald was staying in Sutherland there came to him a man called Sigurd Slembir, who was said to be the son of the priest Adalbrekt. He came from Scotland, having been staying with King David, who had held him in high esteem. Earl Harald received him extremely well. Sigurd went into the Islands with Earl Harald and Frákork, Moddan's daughter, for her husband, Liót Níding, was dead. She and her sister took a large share in the government with Earl Harald. Sigurd Slembir was a great favourite with all of them. At that time Audhild, the daughter of Thórleif, Moddan's daughter, was his concubine. Afterwards she was married to Hákon Kló (claw). Before that time she had been married to Eirík Stræta; their son was Eirík Slagbrellir.

## 46.3

When Sigurd and Frákork came to the Islands great dissensions arose, and both of the Earls called together as many of their friends as they could get. The most attached to Earl Paul was Sigurd, at Westness, who had married Ingibjorg the Noble, a kinswoman of the Earls', and Thorkel, Sumarlidi's son, who was always with Earl Paul, and was called his foster-father. He was a kinsman of the holy Earl Magnus, and a most popular man. The friends of the Earl thought that no man would less deplore their dissensions than Thorkel, because of the injury done him by their father Hákon. At last Earl Harald and Sigurd Slembir went to Thorkel Fóstri, and slew him. When Earl Paul heard this, he was very much displeased, and gathered men together; but when their mutual friends became aware of this, they went between them and tried to reconcile them; and all took part in making peace. Earl Paul was so wroth that he would not make peace, unless all those who were concerned in the manslaying were banished. But as the islanders thought their dissensions a great calamity, they all tried to

pacify them; and the result was that Sigurd and all those who, in Earl Paul's opinion, were most concerned in this crime, were banished from the Orkneys. Earl Harald paid the manbote (compensation) for the slaughter of Thorkel. The terms of this peace were that their friendship should be confirmed, and that they should spend Christmas and all the chief festivals together.

46.4

Sigurd Slembir left the Orkneys, and went to Scotland, and stayed for a while with Malcolm, King of Scots, and was well entertained. He was thought a great man in all manly exercises. He remained for a time in Scotland, until he went to Jerusalem.

## Chapter 47 · EARL HARALD SLAIN BY SORCERY

47.1

ONCE THE BROTHERS were to be entertained at Orfjara (Orphir), one of Earl Harald's estates, and he was to bear the expense of the entertainment for both of them that Christmas. He was very busy, and made great preparations. The sisters Frákork and Helga were there with the Earl, and sat sewing in a little room. Earl Harald went into the room where the sisters were sitting on a cross-bench, and saw a linen garment, newly made, and white as snow, lying between them. The Earl took it up, and saw that it was embroidered with gold. He asked, "To whom does this splendid thing belong?"

47.2

Frákork replied, "It is intended for your brother Paul."

47.3

"Why do you make such a fine garment for him? You do not take such pains in making my clothing."

47.4

He had just come out of bed, and was dressed in a shirt and linen drawers, and had thrown a mantle over his shoulders. He threw off the mantle, and spread out the dress. His mother took hold of it, and asked him not to envy his brother of his fine clothing. The Earl pulled it

from her, and prepared to put it on. Then Frákork snatched off her head-gear, and tore her hair, and said that his life was at stake if he put it on, and both of the women wept grievously. The Earl put on the garment nevertheless; but as soon as it touched his sides a shiver went through his body, which was soon followed by great pain, so that he had to take to his bed; and he was not long in bed until he died. His friends considered his death a great loss.

47.5

Immediately after his death his brother Paul took possession of his dominions, with the consent of the Bœndr. Earl Paul considered that the splendid underclothing which Earl Harald had put on had been intended for him, and therefore he did not like the sisters to stay in the Orkneys. So they left the Islands with all their attendants, and went first to Caithness, and then to Scotland to the estate which Frákork had there. Her son Erlend was brought up there while he was young. Olvir Rosta, the son of Thorliót, from Rekavík (Rackwick), and Steinny (Steinvor?), Frákork's daughter, were also brought up there. Olvir was a man of great strength, a violent man and a great fighter. Thorbiörn Klerk, the son of Thorstein Höld, was brought up there, and also Margarét, the daughter of Earl Hákon and Helga, Moddan's daughter, and Eirík Slagbrellir. All these were men of great families, and accomplished, and thought they had claims to the Orkneys. The brothers of Frákork were Magnus Orfi (the liberal) and Earl Ottar, in Thórsey (Thurso), who was a noble man.

## Chapter 48 · OF EARL PAUL

48.1

EARL PAUL THEN ruled the Orkneys, and was very popular. He was somewhat taciturn, spoke little at the Things, and gave others a large share in the government with himself. He was a modest man, and gentle to the people, liberal with his money, and spared nothing with his friends. He was not warlike, and kept himself very quiet. At that time there were many noble men descended from Earls in the Orkneys.

Then there lived at Westness, in Hrólfsøy (Rousay), a noble man, by name Sigurd, who had married Ingibjörg the Noble. Her mother Herbjörg was the daughter of Earl Paul, Þorfinn's son. Their sons were Brynjúlf and Hákon Pík (peak). All these were Earl Paul's vassals; so were also the sons of Hávard, Gunni's son — Hákon Kló, Þorstein, and Dúfniáll. Their mother was Berglót, and her mother was Ragnhild, the daughter of Earl Paul. There was a man named Erling, who lived in Caithness. He had four sons, all of them accomplished men. A man named Olaf lived in Gáreksey (Gairsay), and had another estate at Dungalsbæ, in Caithness. Olaf was a great man, and highly honoured by Earl Paul. His wife was named Asleif, a wise woman, accomplished, and of a great family. Their sons — Valthióf, Swein, and Gunni — were all accomplished men. Their sister was named Ingigerd. Sigurd, the Earl's brother-in-law, had married Thóra, the mother of Earl Magnus, and their son was Hákon Karl (man). Both Sigurd and his son were great chiefs. In Rínarsey (North Ronaldsay) there lived a woman, by name Ragna, and her son was named Þorstein, a man of great strength. A farmer named Kugi, a wise and wealthy man, lived at Gefsisness, in Westrey. A farmer named Helgi lived at a hamlet in Westrey. Þorkel Flétta (a braid), a violent and powerful man, lived in Westrey. Þorstein and Haflidi were unpopular men. At Swiney (Swona), in the Pentland Firth, lived a poor man, and his sons were Asbiörn and Margad, sturdy fellows. In Fridarey (Fair Isle) lived a man by name Dagfinn. A man named Þorstein lived at Fluguness, in Hrossey (the Mainland of Orkney), and his sons were Þorstein Krôkauga (crooked eye) and Blán, both of them wild fellows. Játvör, the daughter of Earl Erlend, and her son Borgar, lived at Knarrarstadir; they were rather unpopular. Jón Væng (wing) lived at Uppland, in Háey (Hoy). Rikgard lived at Brekkur, in Straumsey. They were poor men, and relatives of Olaf Hrólfsson. A man named Grímkell lived at Glettuness. All these men will be mentioned in the saga afterwards.

## Chapter 49 · OF KALI, WHO AFTERWARDS BECAME AN EARL

49.1

KOL, WHO WAS a very wise man, resided on his estates at Agdir (in Norway), and did not go to the Orkneys. His son Kali grew up there, and was a most promising man. He was of middle size, well proportioned, and very handsomely shaped; his hair was of a light auburn colour. He was very affable and popular, and highly accomplished. He made the following verses: —

49.2

At the game-board I am skilful;  
 Knowing in no less than nine arts;  
 Runic lore I well remember;  
 Books I like; with tools I'm handy;  
 Expert am I on the snow-shoes,  
 With the bow, and pull an oar well;  
 And, besides, I am an adept  
 At the harp, and making verses.

49.3

Kali was frequently with his kinsman Sölmund, the son of Sigurd Sneis. He was treasurer at Túnsberg, and had estates at Austragdir. He was a great chief, and had a numerous retinue.

## Chapter 50 · OF KALI AND GILLICHRIST

50.1

WHEN KALI WAS fifteen winters old, he went with some merchants to England, taking with him a good (cargo of) merchandise. They went to a trading place called Grímsbœ (Grimsby). There was a great number of people from Norway, as well as from the Orkneys, Scotland, and the Sudreyar. Kali met there a man who was called Gillichris. The latter asked Kali about many things in Norway, and spoke chiefly with him, so that they became companions. Then he told Kali in confidence that his name was Harald, that Magnus Barelegs was his father, and his mother was in the Sudreyar. He further asked him how he would be

received in Norway if he came there. Kali said that he thought King Sigurd would be likely to receive him well, if others did not set him against him. Gillichrist and Kali exchanged presents, and at parting they promised each other mutual friendship wherever they might meet.

## Chapter 51 · OF KALI AND JON

### 51.1

AFTER THAT KALI went from the west in the same ship. They touched at Agdir, and from there they went to Biörgvin (Bergen). Then he made a stanza: —

### 51.2

Unpleasantly we have been wading  
In the mud a weary five weeks.

### 51.3

Dirt we had indeed in plenty,  
While we lay in Grimsby harbour;  
But now on the moor of sea-gulls  
Ride we o'er the crests of billows,  
Gaily as the elk of bowsprits  
Eastward ploughs its way to Bergen.

### 51.4

When they came to the town, there was a great number of people from the north and the south (of Norway), and from foreign lands, who had brought much merchandise. The crew of the ship went to some public places to amuse themselves. Kali was a great dandy, and made a great display, as he was newly arrived from England. He thought a great deal of himself, and many others thought a great deal of him too, because he was of a good family, and highly accomplished. In the inn where he sat drinking there was a man named Jón Pétsson, the son of Serk, from Sogn. He was the king's vassal at the time. His mother was Helga, the daughter of Hárek, from Setr. Jón was a great dandy too. The dame who kept the inn where they were drinking was Unn by name, a woman of

good repute. Jón and Kali soon became companions, and parted great friends. Whereupon Jón went home to his estates, and Kali went to his father, Kol, at Agdir. Kali stayed frequently with his kinsman Sölmund. Thus some years passed, in which Kali made trading trips during the summer, and spent the winters at home or with Sölmund.

## Chapter 52 · KALI GOES INTO DOLLS CAVE

### 52.1

ONE SUMMER KALI went to Thrándheim; he was detained by weather in an island called Dolls, and there was a cave called Dollshellir. It was said that money was hidden there. The merchants went into the cave, and found it very difficult to penetrate into it. They came to a sheet of water stretching across the cave, and no one dared to cross it except Kali, and one of Sölmund's domestics called Hávard. They swam across the lake, having a rope between them. Kali also carried firewood and fire-making gear between his shoulders. They came to the opposite shore, which was rugged and stony; the smell also was there very bad, so that they could hardly make a light. Kali said they should not go any farther, and piled up stones as a monument. Then Kali sang a song:

### 52.2

Here I raise a mighty stone-pile,  
In remembrance of our daring,  
In this Dolls cave, dark and gloomy,  
Where we sought the goblins' treasure.

### 52.3

Yet I know not how the captain  
Of the ocean's gliding snow-skates  
May re-cross the dismal water:  
Long and dreary is the journey.

### 52.4

Then they returned, and came safe to their men, and it is not mentioned that anything else happened during their journey. When they came to Biörgvin, Kali went to the same inn, to Dame Unn. Jón

Pétursson was there, and one of his domestics, by name Brynjúlf. Many other men were also there, although their names are not mentioned here.

## Chapter 53 · OF HAVARD AND BRYNJULF

### 53.1

ONE EVENING, WHEN Jón and Kali had gone to bed, many remained drinking, and talked a great deal. The guests were getting drunk, and at last they began comparing men, and disputing about who were the greatest of the landed men of Norway. Brynjúlf said that Jón Pétursson was the best man, and of the noblest family of all the young men south of Stád. Hávard, the companion of Kali, spoke of Sölmund, and said that he was in nothing inferior to Jón, adding that the men of Vík would esteem him more than Jón. Out of this a great quarrel arose, and as the ale spoke in them, they kept so little within bounds that Hávard jumped up, took a piece of wood, and struck Brynjúlf a blow on the head, so that he fainted. Those present took hold of Brynjúlf, and sent Hávard away to Kali, who again sent him to a priest called Rikgard, in Alvidra. “And tell him from me,” said Kali, “to keep you till I come to the east.” Kali sent a man with him, and they rowed to the south till they came to Grœningiasund. Then Hávard said to his fellow-traveller: “Now, as we are out of their reach, let us rest ourselves, and lie down to sleep.”

### 53.2

When Brynjúlf recovered, he was conducted to Jón, and he told him all that had happened, and also that the man had been sent away. Jón guessed the truth about Hávard’s destination, and ordered ten men, led by Brynjúlf, to take a rowing boat, in which they rowed till they came to Grœningiasund, and by that time it was daylight. They saw a boat on the beach. Brynjúlf said: “Perhaps these men may be able to tell us something of Hávard.” Then they went up and found them when they had just woke up. Brynjúlf and his men attacked them immediately with arms, and Hávard and his companion were both slain. After this

they returned to the town and told the news to Jón, and then it was known to the whole town.

53.3

Kali considered these slaughters a great offence against himself; and when mediators went between him and Jón, the latter said that he would leave to him to say what amends he wished for the offence, without prejudice to the right of the King and the parties to the suit. Kali agreed to this, yet they were no friends from this time. Kali went home after this occurrence, and when he saw his father he told him the news and the result.

53.4

Then Kol said: "I think your judgment was rather strange, in that you should have agreed to any terms of reconciliation before Sölmund knew. I think your position is difficult, and that you can do little else than try to be reconciled. But Sölmund would not have acted like you if your man had been killed."

53.5

Kali replied: "I suppose it is true, father, that I have judged rather hastily in this matter, and you were too far away to advise me. It will often appear that I am not so deeply wise as you. But I thought that Sölmund had not a better chance of gaining honourable amends, though I refused what was offered to me. And I consider it no dishonour for you and Sölmund if he offers to allow you to determine your compensation, though I doubt whether such an offer will be made. But I consider myself under no obligation to Brynjúlf, while I have made no award and no money has been received."

53.6

Father and son had a long talk about this, and did not agree; then they sent men to tell Sölmund the news.

## Chapter 54 · OF JON AND SOLMUND

54.1

AFTER THAT, KOL and Kali had an interview with Sölmund. Kol wished to send men to Jón to try to make peace between them; but Sölmund and Hallvard, Hávard's brother, refused everything but blood-revenge, and said it was not becoming to ask for settlement. Yet Kol's advice was taken, because he promised not to withdraw from the case until Sölmund had received honourable amends; and Kol was to lay all the plans. When the messengers returned, they said they had received a most unfavourable reply to their demands, and that Jón refused positively to make compensation for a man who by his own act had forfeited his personal security. Sölmund said that this had turned out just as he expected — namely, that little honour would be gained by asking Jón for settlement; and then he begged Kol to propose a plan that might be of some avail.

54.2

Kol replied: "Is Hallvard willing to run any risk in order to avenge his brother, even though it may come to little?"

54.3

Hallvard said he would not spare himself in order to take revenge, even if there were danger connected with it.

54.4

"Then," said Kol, "you shall go secretly to Sogn, to a man called Uni, who lives not far from Jón. He is a wise man, but rather poor, for he has been a long time oppressed by Jón; he is a great friend of mine, and considerably advanced in years. You shall take to him from me six marks (of silver) weighed, in order that he may give you advice how to take revenge on Brynjúlf, or some other of Jón's men, whom he considers not less a loss to him. And if this can be brought about, Uni shall send you to my kinsman Kyrpinga Orm, at Studla, and his sons Ogmund and Erling, and there I consider you will be as if you were at home. Tell Uni to sell his farm and come to me."

54.5

Hallvard prepared to go, and we are not told of his journey or night quarters, until he came to Uni one evening. He did not tell his true

name. They inquired of each other for current news; and in the evening, when they were sitting round the fire, the guest asked a great deal about noble men in Sogn and Hordaland. Uni said that none of the landed men were considered more powerful than Jón, on account of his family and his violence; and he further asked whether they had no experience of it in the south. When he had said this, the guest became silent. Then the people arose from the fire, and the two remained.

54.6

Then Uni said: "Did not you say just now that your name was Hallvard?"

54.7

"No," said the guest; "I called myself Saxi this evening."

54.8

Uni said: "Then I am out of all difficulties; but if my name were Brynjúlf, I should think yours was Hallvard; and now let us go to sleep."

54.9

The guest took hold of him and said: "Let us not go yet." Whereupon he delivered the purse, and said: "Kol sends you his greeting and this silver, in order that you may be willing to advise me how to avenge my brother Havard on Brynjúlf." Then he told him Kol's plans.

54.10

Uni said: "Kol deserves well of me, but I cannot know what may be done about the revenge on Brynjúlf; but he is expected here tomorrow to fetch his concubine's clothes."

54.11

Thereafter he went with Hallvard to a stable which stood opposite the door of the house, and concealed him in the manger. This was before the people got up, but he had slept in the house during the night. When Hallvard had been a little while in the stable, he saw a brisk man coming to the house. He called into the house, and told the woman to make herself ready. She took her clothes and brought them out. Then Hallvard thought he knew who the man was, and walked out. Brynjúlf had put down his weapons while he was tying the clothes; and when

Hallvard met him he dealt him a deadly blow, and returned to the stable and hid himself. While the slaughter was being committed the woman had gone into the house to take leave of the inmates, but when she came out she saw what had occurred, and ran in crying and frightened to such a degree that she was nearly fainting, and told the news. Farmer Uni ran out, and said that the man had probably been an assassin. He despatched a man to tell Jón the news, and urged his men with great eagerness to search for the murderer; therefore no one suspected him. Hallvard remained in the stable until the search had slackened. Then he went, with Uni's advice, to Orm and his sons at Studla, and they sent men with him to the east. Kol and Sölmund received him well, and were then well satisfied with their case. After a while the truth came out, and Jón was very much grieved. Thus that year passed.

54.12

Next winter, towards Yuletide, Jón left his home with thirty men, saying that he was going to pay his uncle Olaf a visit. This he did, and was very well received. Jón told his uncle that he was going to Agdir to see Sölmund. Olaf dissuaded him from it, and said that he had held his own though they parted as matters stood then. But Jón said he was not satisfied to let Brynjúlf remain unavenged. Olaf said he thought he would gain very little by trying; yet he had from there thirty men, and thus he went with half a hundred men across the hills, intending to take Sölmund and Kol by surprise. When Jón had just gone from the north, Uni went in haste to Orm and his sons at Studla, and they sent men with him to Kol. He arrived there at Yule, and told them that Jón was going to attack them. Kol despatched scouts immediately to all parts where Jón was expected; and he himself went to see Sölmund, and they and their kinsmen waited with a great number of men about them. They had news of Jón's movements, and started immediately to meet him. They met at a certain wood, and the fight began immediately. Kol's men were much more numerous, and came off victorious. Jón lost many men, and fled into the wood. He was wounded

in the leg, and this wound healed so badly that he was lame ever after, and was called Jón Fót (leg). He came to the north during Lent, and his expedition was considered rather ignominious. The winter thus passed, but the next summer Jón caused two of Kol's kinsmen to be killed, Gunnar and Aslák.

## Chapter 55 · THE RECONCILIATION OF THE ORKNEYMEN

### 55.1

SHORTLY AFTERWARDS KING Sigurd came to the town, and these difficulties were laid before him. Then the King summoned both to appear before him, and they came accompanied by their kinsmen and friends. An attempt was made to reconcile them, and the result was, that the King should judge all their differences, which both parties confirmed by shaking of hands. King Sigurd, assisted by the advice of the wisest men, then made peace between them. One part of the agreement was, that Jón Pétsson should marry Ingirid, Kol's daughter, and their friendship should be confirmed by the connection. The killed were set off against each other. The attack on Kol, and Jón's wound, were set off against the loss of men in the east. Further wounds were matched, and the difference made up. Each should assist the other, both at home and abroad. As a result of this reconciliation, King Sigurd gave Kali, Kol's son, the half of the Orkneys, jointly with Paul, Hákon's son, and made him an Earl at the same time. He also gave him the name of Earl Rögnvald, Brúsi's son, because his mother, Gunnhild, said that Rögnvald was the most accomplished of all the Orkney Earls, and thought the name would bring good fortune. This part of the Orkneys had belonged to Earl Magnus, Kali's mother's brother. After this reconciliation, they who were enemies before parted good friends.

## Chapter 56 · KING SIGURD'S DEATH

### 56.1

THIS WINTER KING Sigurd resided in Osló. During Lent he was taken ill, and died one night after Lady-day. His son Magnus was in the town,

and held a Thing, and was accepted king throughout the land, agreeably to the oaths which the inhabitants had sworn to King Sigurd. He also took possession of all the royal treasures.

56.2

Harald Gilli was at Túnsberg when he heard of the death of King Sigurd. He had meetings with his friends, and sent for Rögnvald and his father, because they had always been friends since they met in England. Rögnvald and his father had also done most to help Harald to prove his paternity to Sigurd. In this they were assisted by many barons; among others Ingimar, Swein's son, and Thióstólf, Ali's son. Harald and his party resolved to hold the Hauga-Thing at Túnsberg, and there Harald was accepted king of one-half of the land. The oaths with which he had given up his patrimony in order to be permitted to prove his paternity by an ordeal were said to have been given under compulsion. Then people flocked to him, and gave in their allegiance, and soon he had many men about him.

56.3

Messages went between him and King Magnus, but it was not until four winters had passed that they were reconciled, on the terms that each of them should have one-half of the kingdom; but King Magnus had the long ships, and the table-service, and all the treasures (of his father), yet he was dissatisfied with his portion, and showed enmity to all the friends of King Harald. King Magnus would not hold valid King Sigurd's gift of the Orkneys and the earldom to Rögnvald, because he was the firmest partisan of King Harald, until all their dealings were concluded. Magnus and Harald were three winters Kings of Norway, and nominally at peace, but the fourth summer they fought at Fyrileif, where King Magnus had nearly 6000, but Harald only 1500 men. These chiefs were with King Harald: his brother Kriströd, Earl Rögnvald, Ingimar from Ask, Thióstólf Ali's son, and Sölmund. King Magnus gained the victory, and Harald fled. Kriströd and Ingimar were killed. Ingimar made the following stanza: —

56.4

Fiends me drove to Fyrileif;  
Not with my will did I fight there.

56.5

Bit by arrows from the elmbow,  
Ne'er to Ask shall I return.

56.6

King Harald fled to his ships in Vík, and went to Denmark to King Eirík Eymuni, who gave him Halland for his maintenance, and eight long ships without rigging. Thióstólf, Ali's son, sold his lands, bought ships and arms, and went in autumn to King Harald, in Denmark. At Yuletide King Harald came to Biörgvin, and lay in Flóruvagár till after Yule. Then they attacked the town, and met with little resistance. King Magnus was seized on board his own ship, and maimed. King Harald then took possession of the whole kingdom, and the next spring he renewed the gift of the Islands and the title of Earl to Rögnvald.

## Chapter 57 · KOL'S SCHEMES

57.1

KOL RESOLVED TO send men to the Orkneys to ask Earl Paul to give up half the Islands which King Harald had given to Rögnvald, and they should be friends and good kinsmen. But if Earl Paul refused, the same men should go to Frákork and Olvir Rosta, and offer them one-half of the land, jointly with Earl Rögnvald, if they were willing to take it from Earl Paul by force of arms. When they came to Earl Paul in the Orkneys, and delivered the message, he replied: "I understand this claim; it has been planned advisedly, and with long forethought; they sought the help of the Kings of Norway to obtain my possessions. Now, I will not repay this perfidy by giving away my possessions to a man who is not nearer to me than Rögnvald is, and refusing them to my brother's son or sister's son. There is no need to talk any more of this, for with the assistance of my friends and kinsmen I shall defend the Orkneys as long as God grants me life."

57.2

Then the messengers saw what would be the result of their message to Earl Paul, and went away across the Pentland Firth to Caithness, and south into the country to Frákork, and delivered their message, to the effect that Kol and Rögnvald offered her and Olvir half the Islands if they were willing to conquer them from Earl Paul.

57.3

Frákork replied: “It is true that Kol is a very clever man, and it was wisely planned to seek assistance here, as we have a great many relatives and connections. I have now married Margaret, Hákon’s daughter, to Moddan, Earl of Atjökla (Athole), who is of the noblest family of all the Scottish chiefs. His father, Malcolm, is the brother (uncle?) of King Malcolm, the father of David, who is now King of Scots. We have many and just claims on the Orkneys. We ourselves have also some power. We are said also to be rather far-seeing, and during hostilities all things do not come on us unawares; yet we will be glad to enter into alliance with Kol and his son for many reasons. Tell them from me that I and Olvir shall bring an army to the Orkneys against Earl Paul about the middle of the next summer. Let Earl Rögnvald meet us then, and come to a decisive battle with Earl Paul; and I will collect forces together during the winter from my kinsmen, friends, and connections in Scotland and the Sudreyar (Hebrides).”

57.4

The messengers returned to Norway, and related how matters stood. Next winter Earl Rögnvald prepared to go west, and the chiefs Sölmund and Jón with him. They went the next summer, and had a fine body of troops, though not numerous, and five or six ships. They arrived at Hjaltland (Shetland) about the middle of the summer, but heard nothing of Frákork. Strong and contrary winds sprung up, and they brought their ships to Alasund, and went a-feasting over the country, for the Bœndr received them well.

57.5

But of Frákork it is to be told that in the spring she went to the Sudreyar, where she and Olvir gathered troops and ships together.

They got twelve ships, all of them small and somewhat badly manned; and about the middle of the summer they directed their course to the Orkneys, intending to meet Earl Rögnvald, according to their agreement. The wind was rather unfavourable. Olvir Rosta was the commander of these troops, and he was to obtain an earldom in the Orkneys if they gained the victory. Frákork was there also with many of her retainers.

## Chapter 58 · THE FIGHT BETWEEN EARL PAUL AND OLVIR ROSTA

58.1

EARL PAUL WAS then at a feast with Sigurd at Westness, in Hrólfsøy (Rousay), and when he heard that Earl Rögnvald had arrived in Hjaltland, and at the same time that an army which was going to attack him was gathering in the Sudreyar, he sent word to Kugi, in Westrey, and Thorkel Flettir, who were wise men, and many others of his chief men he called together. At this meeting Earl Paul sought advice from his friends, but they differed in their opinions. Some wished him to share his possessions with one of the two parties, so as not to have both as enemies. Others advised him to go over to his friends in Ness (Caithness), and see what assistance he could get there.

58.2

Earl Paul replied, "I will not offer them my possessions now, since I refused peremptorily when they asked civilly. Besides, I think it would be unworthy of a chief to flee from my lands without a trial of strength. My counsel is to send men to-night to collect troops throughout all the Islands. Let us then go to meet Earl Rögnvald, and have matters decided between us before the Sudreymen come." Earl Paul's plan was adopted.

58.3

With Earl Paul there was a man by name Swein, called Brióstreip (breast-rope), who was his henchman, and highly esteemed by him. In the summer he was always on viking-raids, but in the winter [he

stayed] with the Earl. Swein was a man of large stature and great strength, swarthy and ill-favoured. He was greatly skilled in ancient lore, and had frequently been engaged in outsittings. His place was in the forecastle of the Earl's ship.

58.4

During the night the following chiefs came to Earl Paul: — Eyvind, Melbrigdi's son, in a ship fully manned; Olaf, Rólf's son, from Gáreksey (Gairsay), had another; Thorkel Flettir the third; Sigurd the fourth; and the Earl himself the fifth. With these five vessels they went to Hrólfsøy (Rousay), and arrived there in the evening about sunset. Troops gathered to him during the night, but more ships were not to be had. The next day they were going to sail to Hjaltland to meet Earl Rögnvald; but in the morning, shortly after sunrise, some men came to Earl Paul, who said they had seen longships coming from the Pentland Firth; whether ten or twelve they did not know. The Earl and his men were convinced that this was Frákork's party, and the Earl ordered his men to row against them as fast as possible. Olaf and Sigurd advised them to go leisurely, saying that their troops might arrive at any moment.

58.5

When they were east of Tannskárune (Tankerness), the longships, twelve together, sailed to the west from Múli. The Earl and his men fastened their ships together; then the Bondi, Erling from Tannskárune, and his sons, came to the Earl and offered him their assistance; and then their ships were so crowded that they thought they could not use more men. The Earl asked Erling and his men to bring stones to them, until they were prevented by the fighting. When they had prepared themselves, Olvir came up and made the attack with a superior force, but his ships were smaller. Olvir (himself) had a large ship, which he placed beside the Earl's ship, and there was the severest fighting. Olaf, Rólf's son, attacked the smallest ships of Olvir, and cleared three of them in a short time. Olvir attacked the Earl's ships so fiercely that all the forecastle men were driven abaft the mast. Then

Olvir urged his men strongly to board, and jumped himself from the quarterdeck to the forepart of the ship, and was the first to board.

58.6

Swein Brióstreip was the foremost of all the Earl's men, and fought bravely. When the Earl saw that Olvir had boarded his ship, he urged his men forward, and jumped himself from the quarterdeck to the forepart of the ship. When Olvir perceived this, he grasped a spear, and hurled it at the Earl, who received it with his shield, but fell down on the deck. Then there was a great shout; but in the same moment Swein Brióstreip seized a huge stone, and threw it at Olvir. It hit him in the chest with such force that he was thrown overboard, and sank; but his men were able to drag him up into one of their ships, and it was not known whether he was dead or alive. Then some cut the cables, and wanted to flee. All Olvir's men were also driven down off the Earl's ship, and began to withdraw. At that moment Olvir recovered, and asked them not to flee; but all pretended not to hear what he said. The Earl pursued the fugitives along the east of Hrossey and Rögnvaldsey, and into the Pentland Firth, where they parted. Then he returned, and five of Olvir's ships remained where they had fought. The Earl took them, and manned them with his troops. The battle took place on Friday, but in the night the Earl had the ships made ready, and many troops and two longships came to him, so that in the morning he had twelve ships all well manned.

58.7

On Saturday he sailed to Hjaltland, and took by surprise those that had charge of Earl Rögnvald's ships. He killed the men, and seized the ships with all their contents. In the morning Earl Rögnvald had news of this, and his men gathered together, and a great many of the Boendr. Then they went down to the beach, and challenged Earl Paul and his men to come on shore and fight. Earl Paul did not put much faith in the Hjaltlanders, and would not go on shore; but he told them to take ships, and then they might fight. Earl Rögnvald saw, however, that they could get no ships in Hjaltland, such as would give them any

chance, and they parted thus as matters stood. Earl Paul and his men went back to the Orkneys, but Earl Rögnvald and his men remained in Hjaltland during the summer. In the autumn they went back to Norway with some merchants, and it was thought their expedition had come to a most ridiculous end.

58.8

When Earl Rögnvald came to the east, he saw his father Kol, who asked him whether he was dissatisfied with his expedition. He replied that the result had brought little honour to himself.

58.9

Kol replied: "I do not think so; I think a great deal has been done, since the Hjaltlanders are your friends, and the journey was better than staying at home."

58.10

Rögnvald replied: "If you praise this journey, then you are either more indifferent about my case than I thought, or you see something in it which I do not perceive. I should wish very much to have your counsels, and that you would go with us yourself."

58.11

Kol replied: "I shall not do both — call everything easy for you, and come nowhere near myself; but I think I shall hold fast to my own plans, so that there is no prejudice to your honour."

58.12

Rögnvald replied: "I will gladly follow your counsels."

58.13

Kol replied: "First, I advise you to send word to King Harald and other friends of yours, and ask them to give you men and ships to go to the west in the spring; but during the winter we ourselves will collect all the forces we can, and then try a second time whether we can gain possession of the Islands, or find our graves there."

58.14

“I have made up my mind,” said Earl Rögnvald, “not to make another journey like that we made just now, and I think that most of us who went are of the same mind.”

## Chapter 59 · EARL RÖGNVALD’S PLANS

### 59.1

EARL PAUL WENT back to the Orkneys, after having taken the ships of Earl Rögnvald. He had gained a great victory, and feasted all his friends and vassals.

### 59.2

It was now resolved to make a beacon in Fridarey (Fair Isle), which should be lighted if enemies were seen coming from Hjaltland. Another beacon was made in Rínarsey (North Ronaldsay), and others in some other islands also, so that they might be seen all over the Islands. Thorstein, the son of Hávard, Gunni’s son, was to have charge of that on Rínarsey; his brother Magnus of the one in Sandey; Kugi of that in Westrey; and Sigurd, at Westness, of the one in Rólfsey. Olaf, Rólf’s son, went to Dungalsbæ, in Caithness, and was to have the emoluments of that place. His son Valthióf lived at that time in Straumsey (Stroma).

### 59.3

Earl Paul gave presents to his men, and all promised him their unfailing friendship. He had many men about him in the autumn, until he heard that Rögnvald and his men had left Hjaltland. Nothing happened in the Islands until Yule. Earl Paul had a grand Yule feast, which he prepared at his estate in Jórfiara (Orphir), and invited many guests. Valthióf, Olaf’s son, from Straumsey (Stroma), was invited. He went with his men in a ten-oared boat, and they perished all of them in the West Firth on Yule Eve. That was thought sad news, as Valthióf was a most accomplished man. His father, Olaf, had a large party in Caithness. There were his sons Swein and Gunni, and the sons of Grím of Swiney, Asbiörn and Margad, brave-looking fellows, who always followed Swein. Three nights before Yule, Swein, Olaf’s son, Asbiörn, and Margad, had put out to sea-fishing, and Asleif and her son, and

Gunni, Olaf's son, had gone a short distance to visit their friends. The night after that Olvir Rosta arrived at Dungalsbæ with the party that had been out with him on a viking-raid during the summer. He surprised Olaf in the house, and set it on fire immediately. There he was burnt with five others, but the rest were permitted to escape. Olvir and his men took all the movable property, and then went away.

59.4

After this Swein was called Asleif's son. He came home on Yule Eve, and went immediately out north, on the Pentland Firth. At midnight they came to Grím, the father of Asbiörn and Margad, in Swefney (Swona); he went into the boat to them, and they brought Swein to Knarrarstadir (Knarstane), in Skálpeid (Scapa). A man, by name Arnkel, lived there. His sons were Hánef and Sigurd. Grím and his sons returned, and Swein gave him a finger-ring of gold. Hánef and Sigurd accompanied Swein to Jórfiara (Orphir), where he was well received; and he was conducted to his kinsman Eyvind Melbrigdi's son. Eyvind conducted him to Earl Paul, who received him well, and asked his news. He told him of his father's death, at which the Earl was much grieved, and said it had in a great measure happened through him. He invited Swein to stay with him, and he accepted the invitation with thanks.

## Chapter 60 · SWEIN SLAYS SWEIN

60.1

THEN THEY WENT to evensong. There was a large homestead there (at Orphir); it stood on the hill-side, and there was a height behind the houses. From the top of the hill Aurridafiörd may be seen on the other side; in it lies Damisey. In this island there was a castle; the keeper of it was a man by name Blán, the son of Thorstein, at Flydruness. In Jórfiara there was a large drinking-hall; the door was near the east gable on the southern wall, and a magnificent church was in front of the door; and one had to go down to the church from the hall. On entering the hall one saw a large flat stone on the left hand; farther in

there were many large ale vessels; but opposite the outer door was the stofa.

## 60.2

When the guests came from evensong, they were placed in their seats. The Earl had Swein, Asleif's son, next to him. On the other side, next to the Earl, was Swein Brióstreip, and then Jón his kinsman. When the tables were removed, there came in men with the tidings of Valthióf's drowning. This the Earl considered sad news. He said that no one should tell it to Swein while the Yule feast lasted, adding that he had cares enow already. In the evening, when they had finished drinking, the Earl went to bed, and so did most of his guests. Swein Brióstreip went out and sat out all night, as was his wont. In the night (at midnight?) the guests arose and heard mass, and after high mass they sat down to the table. Eyvind Melbrigdi's son, shared the management of the feast with the Earl, and did not sit down to the table. Table-boys and candle-boys were standing before the Earl's table, but Eyvind handed drinking-cups to each of the Sweins. Swein Brióstreip thought Eyvind poured more into his cup than Swein, Asleif's son's, and that he took the cup away from the latter before he had emptied it, so he called Swein, Asleif's son, a sluggard at his drink. There had long been a coldness between Swein Brióstreip and Olaf, Hrólf's son, and also between him and Swein, Asleif's son, since he grew up. When they had been drinking for a while, the guests went to nones' service. When they came in again, memorial toasts were proposed, and they drank out of horns. Then Swein Brióstreip wished to exchange horns with his namesake, saying his was a small one. Eyvind, however, put a big horn into Swein Asleif's son's hand, and this he offered to his namesake. Then Swein Brióstreip became angry, and was overheard by the Earl and some of the men muttering to himself, "Swein will be the death of Swein, and Swein shall be the death of Swein." But nothing was said about it. The drinking went on until evensong; and when the Earl went out, Swein, Asleif's son, walked before him; but Swein Brióstreip remained behind drinking. When they came out to the ale-

room, Eyvind followed them, and craved a word alone with Swein, Asleif's son.

60.3

He said, "Did you not hear what your namesake said when you offered him the horn?"

60.4

"No," he replied.

60.5

Then Eyvind repeated his words, and said that it was surely the devil that had spoken through his mouth in the night. "He intends to kill you," he added, "but you should forestall him, and slay him."

60.6

Eyvind put an axe into his hand, and told him to stand in the shadow beside the flat stone; he should strike him in front if Jón preceded him; but from behind if Jón followed him.

60.7

The Earl went to the church, and no one took heed of Eyvind and Swein; but when Swein Brióstreip and Jón walked out shortly after, the latter had a sword in his hand, as was his habit, though the others were unarmed. Jón walked in front. Some light came through the outer door, but outside the sky was cloudy. When Swein Brióstreip came into the doorway, Swein, Asleif's son, struck him on the forehead, so that he stumbled, but did not fall; and when he regained his footing, he saw a man in the door, and thought it was he who had wounded him. Then he drew his sword, and struck at his head, splitting it down to the shoulders. This, however, was Jón, his kinsman, and they fell there both. Eyvind came up at the same moment, and led Swein, Asleif's son, into the stofa, opposite the door, and he was dragged out through a window. There Magnus, Eyvind's son, had a horse ready for him, and accompanied him away behind the house, and into Aurrida Firth. There he took a boat, and brought Swein to the castle in Damisey; and the next morning Blán accompanied him to Bishop William, in Egilsey. When they arrived there the Bishop was at mass,

and after the mass Swein was conducted to him secretly. Swein told the Bishop the news — the death of his father and brother Valthióf, and the slaughter of Swein and Jón; then he besought the Bishop's assistance. The Bishop thanked him for the slaughter of Swein Brióstreip, and said it was a good riddance. He kept Swein, Asleif's son, during the Yule-tide, and after that he sent him to a man called Höldbodi, Hundi's son, in Tyrvist (Tiree), in the Sudreyar (Hebrides). Höldbodi was a great chief, and received Swein very well, and there he spent the winter highly esteemed of all the people.

## Chapter 61 · OF EARL PAUL

### 61.1

A SHORT TIME after the slaughters had been committed in Jórfiara, the men ran from the church, and carried Swein into the house, for he was not yet dead, but insensible, and he died during the night. The Earl commanded every one to take his seat, as he wished to know for certain who had committed the manslaughters. Then Swein, Asleif's son, was missed, and it was thought clear that he had done the deed.

### 61.2

Then Eyvind came and said that it was plainly seen that Swein Brióstreip must have killed Jón.

### 61.3

The Earl said that no one should touch a hair of Swein Asleif's son's head, as this had not been done without provocation. "But if he avoids meeting with me," he said, "he will harm himself by so doing."

### 61.4

It was thought most probable that Swein had gone to Hákon Karl in Papuli, the brother of Earl Magnus the holy. He was a great chief, a quiet man and moderate. The Earl did not hear of Swein that winter, and then he outlawed him. In the spring the Earl visited many of the northern islands, to collect his land-dues. He made great friends of the chiefs, and bestowed presents with both hands. The Earl visited

Straumsey (Stroma), and gave Thorkel Flettir the farm which Valthióf had, till such time as he should know where Swein was.

61.5

Thorkel said: “Here the saying does not prove true, that ‘the King has many ears.’ Although you are an Earl, I think it strange that you have not heard of Swein, for I knew immediately that Bishop William had sent him to Höldbodi, Hundi’s son, in the Sudreyar, and there he has been all winter.”

61.6

The Earl replied: “What shall I do with a Bishop who has acted thus?”

61.7

Thorkel replied: “The Bishop should not be blamed for this in critical times like these; and you will need all your friends if Rögnvald and his men come from the east.”

61.8

The Earl said that was true.

61.9

From Straumsey he went to Rínarsey, and received an entertainment from Ragna and her son Thorstein. Ragna was a wise woman. They (she and her son) had another farm in Papey. The Earl spent three nights there, as he was prevented by weather from going to Kugi, in Westrey. The Earl and Ragna spoke of many things.

61.10

She said to him: “There was no great loss in Swein Brióstreip, although he was a brave warrior, for he brought on you the hatred of many. I should therefore advise you, in presence of the difficulties that face you, to make as many friends as possible, and be slow to resent offences. I could wish that you would not attach blame to Bishop William and other kinsmen of Swein, Asleif’s son, but rather take the Bishop into favour, and send word to the Sudreyar after Swein to pardon him and restore him his possessions, in order that he may be to you such as his father was. It has long been the custom of the noblest

men to do a great deal for their friends, and thus to secure support and popularity.”

61.11

The Earl replied: “You are a wise woman, Ragna, but you have not yet been made Earl of the Orkneys, and you shall not rule the land here. Is it come to this, that I must give Swein money in order to be reconciled to him, thinking that it would be to my advantage?” Then he became wroth, and continued: “Let God decide between me and my kinsman Rögnvald, and may He let it happen to each of us according to his deeds. If I have offended against Rögnvald, I now make offer of reparation; but if he will invade my dominions, I will think him my greatest friend who assists me to defend them. I have never seen Rögnvald; and, so far from having ever offended him with my knowledge, it is known that I had no part in what my kinsmen did.”

61.12

Many replied that to try to deprive him of his possessions by force of arms would be a most unprovoked assault; and no one spoke against this.

61.13

When the spring advanced, Earl Paul had beacons kept up in Fridarey (Fair Isle) and Rínarsey (North Ronaldsay), and almost all the Islands, so that each could be seen from the other. A man named Dagfinn, Hlödver’s son, an active fellow who had a farm in Fridarey, was to keep that beacon, and light it if an army were seen coming from Hjaltland.

61.14

Earl Rögnvald spent the winter at home at Agdir (in Norway), where he and his father had farms, and sent messages to his kinsmen and friends. Some of them he visited himself, and asked them to assist him with troops and ships to go to the west, and most of them were willing to help him in his need.

61.15

During the month of Góí, Kol sent away two transport vessels; one west to England to buy provisions and arms. Sölmund took the other south

to Denmark, to buy such things as Kol told him, because he had all the management of their equipment. It was intended that these vessels should return about Easter, and they had arranged to start in the week after Easter. Kol and Rögnvald had one war-ship each, and Sölmund a third; they had also a transport ship with provisions. When they came to Biörgvin, King Harald was there, and he gave Rögnvald a war-ship fully manned. Jón Fót (leg) had a war-ship also. Aslák, the son of Erlend, from Hernur, and the daughter's son of Steigar Thórir, had the sixth; he had also a barge with provisions. Thus they had six large ships, five boats, and three transports. When they were waiting for fair wind at Hernur, a ship came from the west, and they asked for news from the Orkneys, and also what preparations Earl Paul would have if Earl Rögnvald came to the west.

## Chapter 62 · KOL'S COUNSELS

62b.1

WHILE THEY WERE lying at Hernur, Earl Rögnvald called together a meeting of his men, and spoke of Earl Paul's preparations, and also of the great enmity the Orkneymen showed against himself, since they were going to prevent him taking possession of his patrimonial inheritance, which had been justly given him by the Kings of Norway. He made a long and eloquent speech, the conclusion of which was that he intended to go to the Orkneys and gain them or die there. His speech was approved of by all, and every one promised him faithful support.

62b.2

Then Kol arose and said: "We have heard from the Orkneys that all the islanders will rise with Earl Paul against you to keep you out of your inheritance. They are slow to lay aside the enmity which they have conceived against you, kinsman. Now it is my counsel to seek for help where it is likely to be had effectually, and to pray that he may permit you to enjoy these possessions, to whom they rightly belong — namely, the Holy Saint Magnus, your mother's brother. It is my wish that you

should make a vow to him, that he may grant you your patrimony and his inheritance. You should promise one thing — that if you obtain those dominions you will build a stone minster at Kirkiuvag (Kirkwall) in the Orkneys, more magnificent than any other in these lands, dedicating it to your kinsman, Earl Magnus the Holy, endowing it with money, so that it may be fitly established, and that his relics and the Bishop's see may be brought there.”

62b.3

Every one thought this good advice, and the vow was made and confirmed. Then they stood out to sea, and had a fair wind. They landed in Hjaltland, and the inhabitants there, as well as the Norwegians, were glad to see each other. The Hjaltlanders were able to tell them much from the Orkneys, and there they stayed for some time.

## Chapter 63 · OF KOL AND UNI

63.1

UNI, WHO HAS been mentioned before, and who was an accomplice in the slaughter of Brynjúlf, was now advanced in years.

63.2

Once Kol said to him: “What plan would you propose, Uni, in order to get the beacon in Fridarey discontinued, or how would you manage to prevent it from being lighted a second time? I put this question to you, because I know you are more ready-witted than most others here present, although here are men of more distinction.”

63.3

Uni replied: “I am not a man of invention, and I do not wish the expedition to be made according to my plans; I would rather choose to come afterwards, for then I should follow my own devices.”

63.4

Shortly after, Kol had many small boats made ready, and directed their course to the Orkneys. No chiefs took part in this expedition except Kol. When they had gone so far that they thought they could be seen from Fridarey, Kol had the sails spread on all the boats, but ordered his

men to row backwards, in order that their speed might be as slow as possible, although the wind was right astern. The sails were at first hauled to the middle of the masts only, but afterwards higher, as if they were coming nearer to the island.

63.5

Kol said: "These manœuvres will be seen from Fridarey as if the boats were approaching nearer. They will then perhaps light the beacon, but they will go themselves to Earl Paul to tell him the news."

63.6

So when the beacon in Fridarey was seen, Thorstein, Ragna's son, lighted the beacon in Rínarsey; then the beacons were lighted one after another in all the Islands, and all the Bœendr went to the Earl, and there was a great gathering of men.

63.7

When Kol saw the beacon burning, he ordered his men to turn back, saying that this would now cause dissensions among their enemies. This done, Kol went back to Hjaltland, and said to Uni that he should now carry out his scheme.

63.8

Uni took with him three Hjaltlanders, and they took a six-oared boat, some provisions, and fishing tackle. They went to Fridarey. Uni said he was a Norwegian, but had been married in Hjaltland, and had sons there. He further said that he had been robbed by Earl Rögnvald's men, and spoke very ill of them. He took a house there, but his sons went out fishing, and he stayed at home himself and took care of the fish they caught. He entered into conversation with the men of the island, and became familiar with them, and was well liked.

## Chapter 64 · OF THE ORKNEYMEN

64.1

WHEN DAGFINN HAD lighted the beacon, he went to Paul, as has been mentioned before. All the Earl's leading men came to him also. A watch was kept for Rögnvald's movements, and it was thought strange that

he nowhere appeared. Still the troops were kept together for three days. Then the Islanders began to murmur, saying that it was great foolishness to light beacons when fishermen were seen in their boats.

64.2

Thorstein, Ragna's son, was blamed for having lighted the beacon in Rínarsey. He replied that he could do nothing but light his beacon when he saw the blaze in Fridarey, and said that this had all happened through Dagfinn.

64.3

Dagfinn replied: "People come more frequently to harm through you when you cannot blame me for it."

64.4

Thorstein told him to be silent, and leapt up with an axe and dealt him a heavy blow. Then each man seized his weapons, and there was a fray. This was in Hrossey, not far from Kirkiuvag. Sigurd from Westness, and his son Hákon Kló, and Brynjúlf, took part with Hlödver, Dagfinn's father, but Thorstein was aided by his kinsmen. Then the Earl was informed of what was going on, and it was a long time until he could part them.

64.5

Kugi of Westrey made a long speech, and said: "Do not disgrace the Earl by fighting among yourselves. Ere long you will need all your men; let us take care then not to be disabled or at enmity among ourselves. This has probably happened according to the designs of our enemies, and has been a device of theirs to destroy the beacons in this way. Now they may be expected every day, and let us make our plans accordingly."

64.6

Dagfinn said: "No one has had any evil intention in this, but we have acted with more thoughtlessness than we ought to have done."

64.7

Kugi guessed the whole truth, and spoke many wise words about it. At last they both agreed that the Earl should judge between them; and it

was resolved to disperse the gathering, and the people went home.

64.8

A man by name Eirik was now appointed to take charge of the beacon in Fridarey. When Uni had stopped there a short time, he came to Eirik, and said: "Would you like me to take care of the beacon; I have nothing else to do, and can give it my undivided attention." Eirik accepted his offer, and when no one was near Uni poured water over it, and made it so wet that it could not be lighted.

## Chapter 65 · THE BEACONS OF THE ORKNEYS DESTROYED

65.1

EARL RÖGNVALD AND his men said they would wait until the tidal currents were met by an east wind, for then it is hardly possible to go from Westrey to Hrossey, but with east wind one can sail from Hjaltland to Westrey. For this Rögnvald and his men waited, and came one Friday evening to Höfn, in Westrey, to Helgi, who dwelt there.

65.2

No beacons could be lighted, for when the sails were seen from Fridarey, Eirik prepared to go to Earl Paul, and sent a man to Uni to light the beacon, but when he came there Uni was away. When the man tried to light the beacon himself, it was so wet that it would not burn. When Eirik heard this, he knew what was the matter, and went to Earl Paul and told him.

65.3

When Earl Rögnvald had arrived in Westrey, the islanders ran together. Helgi and Kugi put themselves at their head, and their first plan was to try to make peace with the Earl; and their dealings ended in such a way that the Westreymen submitted to Earl Rögnvald, and swore him oaths of fealty.

## Chapter 66 · RÖGNVALD RULES THE ORKNEYS

66.1

ON SUNDAY EARL Rögnvald had mass celebrated there in the village. As they were standing outside the church, they saw sixteen men approaching unarmed, and with their hair close cut. The Earl's men thought their dress singular, and spoke among themselves of who they might be. Then the Earl made a ditty:

66.2

Sixteen have I seen together,  
With a small tuft on their foreheads;  
Surely these are women coming,  
All without their golden trinkets.

66.3

Now may we of this bear witness.

66.4

In the west here all the maidens  
Wear their hair short — that isle Elon  
Lies out in the stormy ocean.

66.5

After Sunday, Earl Rögnvald's men visited the neighbouring districts, and all the people gave in their submission to the Earl. One night in Westrey the Earl's men became aware that the islanders were holding a secret meeting to devise some treachery against Earl Rögnvald. When the Earl heard of it, he rose and went to the place of meeting. When he came there, his men had beaten many of the islanders, and had taken Farmer Kugi and put him in fetters, saying that he was the author of all these proceedings. Kugi pled his cause eloquently, and many put in a word for him, and protested his innocence with him. Then the Earl sang:

66.6

I can see the crooked irons  
Fastened round the legs of Kugi;  
Stray thou canst not in thy fetters,  
Old man! fond of making night trips;  
Now you must not hold night meetings,

And must keep the peace established;  
 Kugi! all your tricks are hinder'd,  
 And your oaths you must keep sacred.

66.7

The Earl pardoned them all, and they renewed their compact.

## Chapter 67 · OF EARL ROGNVALD AND PAUL

67.1

AFTER EARL RÖGNVALD'S arrival in the Orkneys, and when many had submitted to him, Earl Paul held a meeting in Hrossey with his men for consultation. The Earl asked their opinion of what was to be done in these difficulties. There were considerable differences of opinion. Some advised Earl Paul to share his dominions with Earl Rögnvald. But most of the more powerful men and Bændr wished to buy Rögnvald away with money, and offered their means for that purpose. Others were for fighting, as they said that this had been the successful way before.

67.2

Earl Rögnvald had spies at the meeting, and when they came to him, the Earl asked a certain skald, who had been there, for news. He sang:

—

67.3

Of our foes I gain'd this knowledge  
 That o'er secrets they are brooding.

67.4

From the meeting of the Bændr  
 Has the great chief heard the tidings  
 That among the powerful feeders  
 Of the wolves, the wish prevails that  
 All your ships should leave the islands  
 And that Paul should rule the land here.

67.5

Then Earl Rögnvald sent men to see the Bishop, and asked for his intervention. He also sent for Thorstein, Ragna's son, and Thorstein, Hávard's son, in Sandey, and requested them to try to make peace between him and his kinsman. The Bishop procured a fortnight's truce, in order that they might endeavour to establish a more lasting peace. Then the islands were allocated that should maintain each of them in the meantime. Earl Rögnvald went to Hrossey (Mainland), and Earl Paul to Hrólfsøy (Rousay).

67.6

At this time it happened that the kinsmen Swein, Asleif's son, Jón Væng of Uppland in Háey, and Rikgard of Brekkur in Stiórnsey (Stronsay), attacked Thorkel Flettir on the estate which had belonged to Valthióf, and burnt him in the house, with nine others. After that they went to Earl Rögnvald, and told him that they would go to Earl Paul with the whole body of their kinsmen, if he would not receive them; but he did not turn them away.

67.7

As soon as Hafliði, Thorkel's son, heard of his father's burning, he went to Earl Paul, who received him well.

67.8

After this Jón and his men bound themselves to serve Earl Rögnvald, who had now many followers in the Islands, and had become popular. Earl Rögnvald gave leave to Jón, Sölmund, and Aslák, and many others of his partizans, to go home, but they said they preferred to wait until matters should be definitely settled. Earl Rögnvald replied: "If it is the will of God that I should gain possession of the Orkneys, I think He and the Holy Earl Magnus, my kinsman, will give me strength to hold them, even if you go home to your estates."

67.9

Then they went home to Norway.

## Chapter 68 · SWEIN TAKES EARL PAUL CAPTIVE

68.1

EARLY IN THE spring, Swein, Asleif's son, left the Sudreyar (Hebrides), and went to Scotland to see his friends. He stayed a long time at Atjökla (Athole) with Earl Maddad and Margaret, Hákon's daughter, and had many secret consultations with them. Swein heard that there were disturbances in the Orkneys, and became desirous of going there to see his kinsmen. He went first to Thórsey (Thurso), in Caithness, accompanied by a nobleman by name Liótólf. Swein had stayed with him a long time in the spring. They came to Earl Ottar, at Thórsey, the brother of Frákork. Liótólf tried to make them compose the matters that had been done by Frákork's orders, and Earl Ottar made compensation for his part. He promised his friendship to Swein, and he promised to Ottar, in return, to help Erlend, the son of Harald Sléttmáli (smooth-talker), to obtain his patrimony in the Orkneys when he should wish to claim it.

## 68.2

Swein changed ships there, and took a barge manned by thirty men. He crossed the Pentland Firth with a north-westerly wind, and so along the west side of Hrossey, on to Efjusund, and along the sound to Hrólfsøy (Rousay). At one end of the island there is a large headland and a vast heap of stones beneath it. Otters often resorted to this stone-heap. As they were rowing along the sound, Swein said, "There are men on the headland, let us land and ask them for news; let us change our dress, untie our hammocks, and twenty of us lie down there, and ten keep on rowing; let us go leisurely." When they came near the headland the men in the island called to them to row to Westness, and bring Earl Paul what was in their vessel, thinking they were speaking to merchants. Earl Paul had spent the night at a feast with Sigurd, at Westness. He had been early up in the morning, and twenty men had gone south on the island to catch otters, which were in the stone-heap beneath the headland. They were going home to get a morning draught. The men in the barge rowed near the land; they asked the men on shore about all the news, and were asked what news they brought, and whence they came. Swein's men also asked where the

Earl was, and the others said he was on the stone-heap there. This was heard by Swein and those that lay hid with him in the skin-bags. Swein told them to row to land, where they could not be seen from the headland. Then he told his men to get their weapons, and slay the Earl's men wherever they found them, and so they did. Swein's party killed nineteen men, and lost six. They seized Earl Paul with violence, and brought him on board their ship, and stood out to sea, returning by the same way, by the west side of Hrólfsøy, and through the channel between Háey and Grimsey, and then by the east of Svelgr, thence to Breidafjörð (the Moray Firth), until they came to Ekkjalsbakki. There he left his ship with twenty men, and continued his journey until he came to Earl Maddad and Margaret, Earl Paul's sister, at Atjökklar (Athole). There they were well received. Earl Maddad placed Earl Paul in his high seat, and when they were seated, Margaret entered with a long train of ladies, and advanced to her brother. Then men were procured to amuse them; but Earl Paul was moody, and it was no wonder, for he had many cares.

68.3

It is not recorded what passed between Earl Paul and Swein while they were on the journey together. Earl Maddad, Margaret, and Swein, had a consultation together; but in the evening, when the drinking was finished, Swein's followers were conducted to a sleeping-room by themselves, and the key turned upon them. This was done every evening while they were there.

## Chapter 69 · OF SWEIN, ASLEIF'S SON'S, RETURN TO THE ORKNEYS

69.1

ONE DAY MARGARET announced that Swein, Asleif's son, should go to the Orkneys to see Earl Rögnvald, and ask him whom he preferred to share in the dominion of the Orkneys with him — Earl Paul, or Harald, the son of (her husband) Maddad, who was then three winters old.

69.2

When Earl Paul heard this, he said: “So far as my mind is concerned, I will say that I have left my dominions in such a way as has never been heard of before, I think; and I shall never return to the Orkneys any more. I see that this must be God’s vengeance for the theft which I and my kinsmen committed. But if God thinks the dominion mine, then will I give it to Harald, if he may enjoy it; but I wish some money given to me, so that I may establish myself in some monastery, and you can take care that I do not escape. And you, Swein, shall go out to the Orkneys, and say that I have been blinded, or still more mutilated, because my friends will fetch me if I am an unmaimed man. In that case I may not be able to refuse to return to my dominions with them, for I suspect that they will consider our parting a greater loss than it is.”

69.3

What more the Earl said has not been placed on record.

69.4

Then Swein, Asleif’s son, went to the Orkneys, and Earl Paul remained behind in Scotland.

69.5

This is how Swein related these matters. But some men tell the story in a way by no means so creditable (to those concerned) — namely, that Margaret induced Swein, Asleif’s son, to blind her brother Earl Paul, then threw him into a dungeon, and subsequently induced another man to put him to death. We do not know which of these two statements is the more correct; but it is well known that Earl Paul came never again to the Orkneys, and that he had no dominions in Scotland.

## Chapter 70 · OF EARL ROGNVALD AND SWEIN, ASLEIF’S SON

70.1

IT HAPPENED AT Westness, when the Earl did not come home, that Sigurd sent men to search for him. When they came to the stone-heap they saw the slain, and then they thought the Earl had been killed. They went home and told the news. Sigurd went immediately to

examine the bodies, and they recognised nineteen as the Earl's men; but six they did not know. Then Sigurd sent men to Egilsey, to the Bishop, to tell him the news. He went immediately to Sigurd. When they were talking about what had happened, Sigurd hinted that it had been done at the instigation of Earl Rögnvald; but the Bishop replied that it would be proved that Earl Rögnvald had not acted treacherously towards his kinsman Earl Paul. "It is my opinion," he said, "that some others have committed this crime."

## 70.2

Borgar, the son of Játvör, Erlend's daughter, who lived at Geitaberg, had seen the barge coming from the south, and returning. When this was heard, it was believed to have been done at the instigation of Frákork and Olvir.

## 70.3

When the news spread in the Islands that Earl Paul had disappeared, and no one knew what had become of him, the Islanders had a consultation, and most of them went to Earl Rögnvald, and swore fealty to him; but Sigurd, of Westness, and his sons, Brynjúlf and Hákon Kló, said they would not swear oaths of fealty to any man while they did not know anything of Earl Paul, or whether he might be expected to return or not. There were others also who refused to swear oaths to Earl Rögnvald. Others again fixed an hour or a day when they would become Earl Rögnvald's men, if Earl Paul had not then been heard of. But when Earl Rögnvald saw that he had to do with many powerful men, he did not refuse peremptorily anything which the people asked; and, as the time passed, he had frequent meetings with the inhabitants, and at each of them some submitted to him.

## 70.4

One day it happened in Kirkiuvag (Kirkwall) when Earl Rögnvald was holding a Thing meeting with the Bændr, that nine armed men were seen walking from Skálpeid (Scapa) to the meeting. When they came near, Swein, Asleif's son, was recognised, and all were curious to know what news he had to tell. He had come in a ship to Skálpeid, and left it

there, while he and his men walked to Kirkiuvag. When Swein came to the meeting, his kinsmen and friends turned to him, and asked him for news, but he did not say much. Swein sent for the Bishop, who welcomed him heartily, because they had long been friends. They went aside to talk, and Swein told the Bishop the whole truth about what he had done, and asked for his advice in these difficult circumstances.

70.5

The Bishop said: “Those are weighty tidings you have brought, Swein, and we shall probably not be by ourselves sufficient in this matter. I wish you to wait here for me; but I shall plead your cause before the people and Earl Rögnvald.”

70.6

Then the Bishop went to the meeting, and asked for silence. When silence was obtained, the Bishop pleaded Swein’s cause, explaining for what reason he had left the Orkneys, and what penalties Earl Paul had inflicted on him for the slaying of Swein Brióstreip, a most wicked man. The Bishop concluded by asking Earl Rögnvald and all the people to grant security to Swein.

70.7

Earl Rögnvald replied: “For my part, I promise Swein three nights’ security; but I think I can see from your countenance, Sir Bishop, that you and Swein know some great news which you have not yet made known. I wish you to take Swein into your keeping, and to be responsible for him, and I will speak to him to-morrow.”

70.8

“I will,” said the Bishop; “and he will be very glad to speak to you as soon as possible; for he wishes to become your man, if you are willing to receive him.”

70.9

The Earl replied: “I do not think my friends are too many in these lands, yet I shall have some farther talk before I consent to this.”

70.10

Then these four — Earl Rögnvald, his father Kol, the Bishop, and Swein, Asleif's son — had a private interview. Swein repeated everything, good and bad, that had happened between him and Earl Paul, and they came to the conclusion to send away the bulk of the people at the meeting. The Earl arose next morning and gave the people permission to go home; but when the multitude had gone away, he called together all those that remained, and made them all renew their promise of security to Swein, while he told the news.

70.11

In the morning, Magnus Karl, the brother of the Holy Earl Magnus, was persuaded to tell Sigurd of Westness and his sons of Earl Paul's abduction, that he was not to be expected back to his dominions, and that he had been maimed.

70.12

Sigurd said: "Great news do I think this, about the carrying away of the Earl; yet to me the saddest of all is that he should have been maimed, for he would not be anywhere where I would not go to him." Afterwards he told his friends that Hákon would not have left him unharmed, if he had had a sufficient force with him when he told him these tidings, so greatly was he moved by them.

70.13

When the news became generally known, all the Orkney men submitted to Earl Rögnvald, and he became the sole ruler of Earl Paul's dominions.

70.14

Not long after this the foundations of St. Magnus' Church were marked out, and craftsmen procured, so that more was done during that year than in the ensuing four or five. Kol took great interest in the erection of the building, and had the principal oversight of the whole; but as it proceeded, it became very expensive to the Earl, and his means were nearly exhausted. Then he consulted his father, and he advised him to pass a law declaring that the Earls should be considered to have inherited all the odal possessions from the owners, but that they were

to be redeemable by the heirs. This was considered a great hardship. Then Earl Rögnvald called a Thing meeting, and proposed to the Bœndr that they should purchase the odal possessions, so that it would not be necessary to redeem them afterwards, and an agreement was made with which all parties were satisfied. It was to this effect, that they should pay the Earl one mark (eight oz. of silver) for each plough's land all over the Islands. From that time there was no want of money to build the church; and it was made a magnificent structure.

## Chapter 71 · BISHOP JÓN ARRIVES FROM SCOTLAND

### 71.1

WHEN EARL RÖGNVALD had ruled the Orkneys two winters he had a Yule-feast at his estate called Knarrarstadir. The sixth day of Yule a ship was seen crossing the Pentland Firth from the south. It was a fine day, and the Earl was outside the house, with many men, looking at the ship. There was also a man named Hrólf, the Earl's court priest. When the strangers landed, they left the ship, and the Earl's men calculated their number to be fifteen or sixteen. In front of them walked a man in a blue cloak, with his hair tucked up under the cap; the lower part of the chin was shaved, but the lips unshaved, and the long beard was hanging down (from them). They thought this man somewhat strange, but Hrólf said it was Bishop Jón from Atjökla (Athole), in Scotland. Then the Earl went to meet them, and gave the Bishop a gracious welcome. He placed him in his high seat, but served at the table himself like a waiter.

### 71.2

Early next morning the Bishop held a service, and went to Egilsey to see Bishop William. This was the tenth day of Yule. Then both the Bishops went with a noble suite to visit Earl Rögnvald, and told him their business, explaining the agreement between Swein, Asleif's son, and Earl Maddad — namely, that their son Harald should bear the title of Earl, and have half the Orkneys jointly with Earl Rögnvald, but Earl Rögnvald should have the government in his hands, even when Harald

grew up; and if a difference arose between them, Earl Rögnvald should have his own way.

71.3

Swein was present, and confirmed the Bishop's statement. It was resolved to hold a meeting during Lent in Caithness, and there they agreed upon the terms above mentioned, and their agreement was confirmed by the oaths of the best men of the Orkneys and Scotland. Then Harald, Maddad's son, went to the Orkneys with Earl Rögnvald, and was invested with the title of Earl.

71.4

Harald was accompanied to the islands by Thorbiörn Klerk, the son of Thorstein Höld, and Gudrún, the daughter of Frákork. He was a wise and a great man. He was foster-father to Harald at that time, and had great influence with him. Thorbiörn married in the Orkneys Ingirid, Olaf's daughter, sister to Swein, Asleif's son. He was sometimes in the Orkneys, and sometimes in Scotland. He was a most valiant man, but overbearing in most things.

71.5

Swein, Asleif's son, took possession of all the estates that belonged to his father Olaf and his brother Valthióf; he became a great chief, and had always many men with him. He was a wise man, and far-seeing in many things; but overbearing and rash. No two men in the west were considered at that time greater than the brothers-in-law Swein and Thorbiörn, and there was a warm friendship between them.

## Chapter 72 · THE BURNING OF FRÁKORK

72.1

ON ONE OCCASION Swein, Asleif's son, asked Earl Rögnvald to give him troops and ships to take vengeance on Olvir and Frákork for the burning of his father Olaf.

72.2

The Earl said: "Do you not think, Swein, that Olvir and that old hag Frákork, who is good for nothing, will scarcely be able to do us any

harm now?"

72.3

Swein replied: "They will always be mischievous while they live; and I expected something else when I did great things for you, than that you would refuse me this."

72.4

The Earl replied: "What will you be satisfied with?"

72.5

Swein said: "Two ships well equipped."

72.6

The Earl said he should have what he wished.

72.7

Then he made preparations for going. When he was ready he sailed south to Borgarfjord, and had a northwest wind to Dúfeyrar, which is a trading-place in Scotland. From there he passed Moray to Ekkialsbakki, and from there he went to Earl Maddad at Atjökla (Athole). He gave Swein guides who knew the way across mountains and forests wherever Swein wished to go; and he went through the interior of the country, over mountains and through woods, away from all habitations, and came down in Hjólmundal, near the middle of Sutherland. Olvir and Frákork had had spies wherever they thought they might expect enemies from the Orkneys, but this way they did not expect any. They did not, therefore, perceive the enemy till Swein and his men were in a certain slope behind the house. Olvir Rosta met them there with sixty men, and the fight began immediately. There was little resistance on the part of Olvir's men, and they retreated towards the houses, because they could not reach the wood. A great many were killed, and Olvir ran to Hjólmundal's river, and then up on the mountains. After that he went to Scotland's Firth (on the west coast), and from there to the Sudreyar (Hebrides), and he is not mentioned further in this Saga.

72.8

When Olvir escaped, Swein and his men approached the houses, and plundered everything. Then they burnt the houses, with all the inmates, and there Frákork perished. Swein and his men committed many ravages in Sutherland before they went to their ships. After that they were out on raids during the summer, and ravaged in Scotland.

72.9

In the autumn Swein came to Earl Rögnvald in the Orkneys, and was well received. Then he crossed over to Ness (Caithness), and spent the winter in Dungalsbæ. At this time Swein received a message from Höldbodi, in the Sudreyar, that he should come and help him, because Höld from Bretland had been there, driven him from his estates, and taken much booty. The messenger was named Hródbjart (Robert), of English descent. When Swein received the message, he quickly left for the Orkneys, and called on Earl Rögnvald, and requested him to give him troops and ships. The Earl asked Swein what he was going to do then. He said that he had received a message from a man whom he ought least of all to refuse, and who had proved his best friend in his greatest need, and when most others were his enemies.

72.10

The Earl said: "It is well if you part good friends, but most of those Sudreyarmen are treacherous. You must, however, act a manly part, and I will give you two ships fully manned."

72.11

Swein was well pleased with this, and went to the Sudreyar, but did not find Höldbodi till he came to the Isle of Man, because the latter had fled thither. When Swein came to the Isle of Man, Höldbodi was very glad to see him. The British Höld had plundered and killed men, to a large extent in the Isle of Man as well as in the Sudreyar. He had killed a nobleman named Andrew, who left a widow by name Ingirid, and a son by name Sigurd. Ingirid was wealthy, and had large estates. Höldbodi advised Swein to woo her; and when he proposed marriage, she made it a condition of her acceptance that he should avenge her late husband Andrew.

72.12

Swein replied: “I may inflict some loss on the British, but we cannot know how we may succeed in manslaying.”

72.13

Then Swein and Höldbodi went out on an expedition with five ships. They plundered in Bretland, landing at a place called Jarlsness, and committing great ravages. One morning they went into a certain village, and met with a little resistance. The inhabitants fled from the village, and Swein and his men plundered everything, and burnt six homesteads before dinner. An Icelandic, named Eirík was with Swein, and sang the following:

72.14

Half-a-dozen homesteads burning,  
Half-a-dozen households plundered:  
This was Swein’s work of a morning —  
This his vengeance; coals he lent them.

72.15

After this they went to their ships. They were out reiving all the summer, and obtained much booty, but Höld fled into an island called Lund, where there was a strong place. Swein besieged it for some time, to no purpose. In the autumn they went back to the Isle of Man.

## Chapter 73 · OF SWEIN AND HOLDBÖDI’S RAIDS

73.1

THIS WINTER SWEIN married Ingirid, and remained there, greatly honoured. In the spring he gathered men together, and went to see Höldbodi, and asked for his assistance, but he excused himself, saying that many of his men were occupied, and some on trading trips; so Swein got none there. But the truth was, that he had secretly made peace with Höld, and confirmed their alliance by exchanging presents. Swein went out, nevertheless, with three ships, but made little booty in the earlier part of the summer. Later they went south, under Ireland, and seized a barge belonging to some monks in Syllingar, and

plundered it. He made inroads in Ireland in many places, obtained a large booty, and returned to the Isle of Man in autumn.

## 73.2

When Swein had been a short time at home, he heard a report to the effect that Höldbodi was not faithful to him, but Swein shrank from believing it. One night in the spring Swein's watchmen came to him and said that enemies were approaching them. Swein and his men seized their arms, and ran out, and saw a great number of men carrying fire to the homestead. Then Swein and his men ran to a hill, and defended themselves from it. They had a horn which they sounded. The neighbourhood was thickly inhabited, and men came flocking to help Swein, so that the assailants at last gave way. Swein and his men pursued them, and killed many in the flight, but many of both sides were wounded before they parted. The chief of the attacking band was Höldbodi. He escaped in the flight, and did not stop till he came to Lundey (Lundy Isle). Höld received him well, and they remained together. Swein went home, and kept a large number of his men about him, maintaining a strict watch, because he distrusted the Sudreyarmen. Late in the winter he sold his lands, and went early in the spring to Liódhús (Lewis). During this expedition he had committed many ravages.

## Chapter 74 · OF EARL ROGNVALD AND SWEIN

## 74.1

WHILE SWEIN WAS in the Sudreyar, Earl Rögnvald went over to Caithness, and was entertained at Vík (Wick) by a man named Harald. His son was named Swein, an active fellow. While the Earl was there, Thorbiörn Klerk came up from Scotland, and said that his father, Thorstein Höld, had been killed by a certain Earl. People talked of how frequently Earl Rögnvald and Thorbiörn spoke together, because the Earl scarcely took leisure to discharge his duties for that reason. Thorbiörn went with the Earl out to the Islands (Orkneys), and Swein, Harald's son, became the Earl's tableboy Thorbiörn had been in

Scotland for some time. He had slain two men who had been with Swein, Asleif's son, at the burning of Frákork.

74.2

When Swein came from the Sudreyar, he went home to his farm in Gáreksey (Gairsay), and not to Earl Rögnvald, as he used to do when he came from his expeditions. So when the Earl heard that Swein had come home from the Sudreyar in the summer, he asked Thorbiörn for what reason he thought Swein did not come to him.

74.3

Thorbiörn replied: "I suppose Swein is offended with me because I had those men slain who were with him at the burning of Frákork."

74.4

The Earl said: "I do not like you to be enemies."

74.5

Then Earl Rögnvald went to Gáreksey, and tried to reconcile them, which was easy, because they both wished the Earl to judge between them. Then he made peace between them, and it lasted for a long time after.

## Chapter 75 · EARL ROGNVALD'S PLEASANTRIES

75.1

AT THIS TIME there came a certain Icelandic ship to the Orkneys, in which was a man by name Hall, the son of Thórarinn Breidmagi (broad waist). He went to Rínarsey (North Ronaldsay), to stay with Thorstein and Ragna. He became tired of staying there, and asked Thorstein to bring him to Earl Rögnvald. They went to see him, but the Earl would not receive Hall. When they came home, Ragna asked how they had succeeded, and Hall replied by a ditty:

75.2

It was to thy own son, Ragna,  
(Let truth be known among the people)  
I gave the noble task of asking  
My reception 'mong the courtiers;

But the generous ring-giver,  
 Who enjoys the highest honour,  
 Has declined my clownish service,  
 Having plenty of the bravest.

75.3

Shortly afterwards Ragna went to see Earl Rögnvald on this errand herself. She was so dressed that she had a red head-gear of horse's hair; and when the Earl saw her he sang:

75.4

Never did I know before this  
 How the ladies of the cross-bench  
 Deck their heads with finest kerchiefs.

75.5

If I use the proper language,  
 Seems to me that this gold-wearer  
 Hides the tresses of her hind-head  
 With a chestnut filly's tail-locks,  
 And her head-dress shows her temper.

75.6

Ragna said: "Now the saying comes true, 'that few are so wise that they see everything as it is,' for this [hair] is of a horse, and not of a mare."

75.7

Then she took a silken kerchief and wrapped it round her head, continuing, nevertheless, her business with the Earl. He gave her a rather cold answer at first, but became more pleasant as they spoke longer, and she obtained what she wanted — namely, to procure for Hall a place at the (Earl's) court. He remained a long time with Earl Rögnvald. They made jointly the "Old Metrekey," with five verses for each different metre. Afterwards that was thought too much, and now two verses only are made for each different metre.

## Chapter 76 · OF EARL ROGNVALD AND SWEIN, ASLEIF'S SON

76.1

SWEIN, ASLEIF'S SON, is said to have heard that Höldbodi had arrived in the Sudreyar. Then he asked Earl Rögnvald to give him troops to avenge himself. The Earl gave him five ships, and Thorbiörn Klerk was the commander of one of them; Hafliði, the son of Thorkel Flettir, of another; Dúfniál, the son of Hávard, Gunni's son, the third; Rikgard (Richard), Thorleif's son, the fourth; and Swein, Asleif's son, the fifth. When Höldbodi heard of Swein, he fled from the Sudreyar. Swein and his men killed many people in the Sudreyar, and ravaged and burnt far and wide. They obtained great booty, but could not catch Höldbodi, and he never came to the Sudreyar after that. Swein wished to remain in the Sudreyar during the winter, but Thorbiörn and the others wished to go home, and went in the autumn to Caithness, and arrived at Dungalsbæ. When they were going to divide their booty, Swein said they should all share equally, but that he himself should have a chief's share besides, saying that he had been the chief, and that the Earl had sent the others to his assistance. Besides, he added further that he alone had the quarrel with the Sudreyarmen, while the others had none. Thorbiörn, however, said he did not deserve less than Swein, and had not been less a leader than he. They also wished that all the ships' commanders should have equal shares; but they had to submit to Swein, because his men were by far the most numerous there on the Ness (in Caithness).

76.2

Thorbiörn went out to the Orkneys and told Earl Rögnvald how matters had gone between him and Swein, and that they were very much displeased to have been deprived by him of their just proportion of the spoil.

76.3

The Earl said it would not be only once that Swein had turned out not to be an equitable man, yet he would in the end receive retribution for his injustice; but, he added: "You shall not quarrel about this. I shall give you as much money of my own as you have lost through him, and

it is my will that you do not claim it of him. It will be a good thing if this does not lead to greater difficulties with him.”

76.4

Thorbiörn replied: “May God reward you, my lord, for the honour you do us, and we shall not quarrel with Swein about this; but I shall never be his friend any more, and I shall do him some despite in return.” And after that Thorbiörn divorced himself from Ingirid, Swein’s sister, and sent her to him over to Ness (Caithness). Swein received her well, but considered Thorbiörn’s conduct a great insult to himself. There was then fierce enmity between them. Then the saying proved true that monsters are best matched together.

76.5

When Swein was in the Sudreyar, he had placed Margad, Grím’s son, over his affairs at Dungalsbæ, and transferred to him the office (of deputy or factor) which he held from Earl Rögnvald, but Margad was resentful and overbearing, and became unpopular on account of his violence. Those who were the first objects of his oppression ran to Hróald (at Wick), and remained there. From this enmity arose between the two. Shortly after Margad went south to Vík (Wick) on business with nineteen men, and before he left he attacked Hróald, and killed him and several others. Then he went to Dungalsbæ to see Swein. The latter gathered men together, and went to Lambaborg, where he fortified himself. It was a strong place, and there he remained, with sixty men, and brought thither provisions and other necessities. The borg (castle) was situated on a sea-girt rock, and on the landward side there was a well-built stone wall. The crags ran a long way along the sea on either side. Swein and his men committed many violent robberies in Caithness, and brought everything into the stronghold, and became greatly hated.

## Chapter 77 · OF SWEIN, ASLEIF’S SON’S MOVEMENTS

77.1

THIS NEWS CAME to the ears of Earl Rögnvald, and Swein, Hróald's son, and he asked the Earl to help him to obtain redress in this cause; and many supported Swein's request. At last Earl Rögnvald crossed over to Ness (Caithness), and the following chiefs with him: — Thorbiörn; Haflidi, Thorkel's son; and Dúfníál, Hávard's son. These counselled the most severe measures against Swein. They went to Dungalsbæ, but Swein was not there. They heard that he was in Lambaborg, and then the Earl went thither. When they came to the borg, Swein asked who their leader was, and he was told that it was Earl Rögnvald. Swein asked him what he wanted. The Earl said he wished him to deliver Margad up to them. Swein asked whether he was to receive quarter. The Earl said he would not promise. Then Swein said: "I have not the heart to deliver Margad into the power of Swein, Hróald's son, or of my other enemies who are with you, but I should wish very much to be at peace with you, my lord."

77.2

Then Thorbiörn Klerk said: "Hear what the traitor says, that he would willingly be at peace with his lord after he has plundered his land, and betaken himself to the highways like a thief. You make a bad return to the Earl for all the honour he has done you, and so you will do to all you can."

77.3

Swein replied: "You need not say much in this case, Thorbiörn, for no respect will be paid to your words. But it is my foreboding that you will repay him worse for all the honour he has done to you, before you part, for nobody will gain good fortune from any dealings with you."

77.4

Then Earl Rögnvald said that men should not rail at each other.

77.5

Then they besieged the borg, and cut off all communication, and a long time passed, as they could not make an assault. And when the provisions were exhausted, Swein called his men together, and

consulted with them. But they all said, as with one mouth, that they wished to follow his guidance as long as they were able.

77.6

Then Swein said: "I think it most disgraceful to starve here, and afterwards to surrender to our enemies. It has turned out, as was likely, that our skill and good fortune should fail against Earl Rögnvald. We have tried to obtain peace and security for life, but neither was to be had for my companion Margad. Though I know that the others will be able to obtain quarter, yet I have not the heart to deliver him under the axe. Still, it is not right that so many here should suffer for his difficulties, although I am unwilling to part from him for a time."

77.7

Then he tied together ropes which they had, and during the night they let Swein and Margad down from the borg into the sea. They swam along the cliffs till they came to the end of them, then they got on shore and went to Sutherland, thence to Moray, and then to Dúfeyrar. There they met with some Orkneymen in a trading vessel. Hallvard and Thorkel were the commanders, and they were ten altogether. Swein and Margad went on board with them, when they were twelve together, and then they sailed south off Scotland, until they came to Máeyar (the Isle of May). There was a monastery, the head of which was an abbot, by name Baldwin. Swein and his men were detained there seven nights by stress of weather. They said they had been sent by Earl Rögnvald to the King of Scots. The monks suspected their tale, and thinking they were pirates, sent to the mainland for men. When Swein and his comrades became aware of this, they went hastily on board their ship, after having plundered much treasure from the monastery. They went in along Myrkvifiörd (the Firth of Forth), and found David, the King of Scots, in Edinburgh. He received Swein well, and requested him to stay with him. He told the King explicitly the reason of his visit, how matters had gone between him and Earl Rögnvald before they parted, and also that they had plundered in Máeyar. Swein and Margad stayed for a while with the

King of Scots, and were well treated. King David sent men to those who had been robbed by Swein, and told them to estimate their loss themselves, and then of his own money he made good to every one his loss.

77.8

King David proposed to Swein to bring his wife from the Orkneys, and to bestow upon him such honours in Scotland as he might be well satisfied with. Swein declared all his wishes to the King. He said it was his wish that Margad should remain with him, and that the King should send word to Earl Rögnvald to be reconciled to him; but he said he would himself leave his case entirely to the decision of Rögnvald, adding that he was always well pleased when there was friendship between them, but ill at ease when they were at enmity.

77.9

King David replied: "I suppose this Earl is a good man, and you value nothing except what comes from him, since you prefer the risk of surrendering yourself to his good faith, and refuse my offers."

77.10

Swein said he would never give up his friendship, yet he asked the King to grant him this, and the King said it should be as he wished.

77.11

King David sent men to the Orkneys with presents, and a message requesting that the Earl would make peace with Swein. Then Swein went north to the Islands, and Margad remained behind with the King. King David's messengers went to Earl Rögnvald, who received them well, and also the presents, promising peace to Swein. Then he was fully reconciled to Swein, who now returned to his estates.

## Chapter 78 · EARL VALTHIÓF'S DEATH

78.1

WHEN SWEIN AND Margad had left Lambaborg, those that were in the fort resolved to surrender it to Earl Rögnvald. He asked them what they knew last of Swein and Margad, and they told the truth.

78.2

When the Earl heard it, he said: “To tell the truth, Swein has no equal among those that are now with us, and such feats are both brave and hardy; but I will not abuse my power over you, although you were involved in these troubles with Swein. Every one of you shall go home in peace as far as I am concerned.”

78.3

The Earl went home to the Orkneys, and sent Thorbiörn Klerk in a ship with forty men south to Breidafjord (the Moray Firth), to search for Swein; but he heard nothing of him.

78.4

Thorbiörn then said to his men: “Our journey is a strange one; we are all this time wandering after Swein, but I have heard that Earl Valthióf, who slew my father, is not far off, with but a few men; and if you will attack him with me, I will promise you that I shall not act as Swein did — namely, to deprive you of your share if we get any booty, for you shall have all we get, except what you wish to give me, because I think glory is better than booty.”

78.5

Then they went to the place where Earl Valthióf was at a banquet, and surprised them in the house, and set it on fire immediately. Valthióf and his men ran to the door, and asked who was the raiser of the fire. Thorbiörn told his name. Valthióf offered compensation for Thorstein’s slaying, but Thorbiörn said it was useless to ask for peace. They defended themselves bravely for a time; but when the fire pressed them they ran out; after that their defence was short, because the fire had overcome them. Earl Valthióf fell, and thirty men with him. Thorbiörn and his men got a great deal of booty, and he kept all his promises to them faithfully. Then they went to the Orkneys to Earl Rögnvald, who was well satisfied with what they had done. Then there was peace and quiet in the Islands.

78.6

At that time a young man lived in the Islands, by name Kolbein Hruga (heap), a very overbearing man; he built a fine stone castle, which was a strong defence. Kolbein's wife was Herbiörg, the sister of Hákon Barn (child), but their mother was the daughter of Herborg, Paul's daughter. Their children were Kolbein Karl, Bjarni Skáld, Sumarlídi, Aslák, and Frída; they were all well mannered.

## Chapter 79 · OF EINDRIDI UNGI (THE YOUNG)

79.1

AT THAT TIME the sons of Harald Gilli ruled over Norway. Eystein was the oldest of them, but Ingi was a legitimate son, and he was most honoured by the Lendermen, because he let them have their way in all things as they liked. At this time the following Lendermen (Barons) assisted him in the government: — Ogmund and Erling, the son of Kyrpinga Orm. They advised King Ingi to send word to Earl Rögnvald, and give him an honourable invitation, saying truly that he had been a great friend of his father, and desired him to become as intimate with the Earl as he could, so that he might be a dearer friend of his than of his brother, whatever might happen between them. The Earl was related to the brothers, and a great friend of theirs; and when he received this message, he quickly prepared to go, because he felt a desire to go to Norway to see his friends and kinsmen. Earl Harald asked to be permitted to go with him, out of curiosity and to amuse himself; he was then nineteen winters old.

79.2

When the Earls were ready, they started from the west with some merchants, having a noble retinue, and arrived in Norway early in the spring. They found King Ingi in Biörgvin (Bergen), and he received them very well. Earl Rögnvald saw many of his friends and kinsmen, and spent a great deal of the summer there. Eindridi Ungi (the young) arrived from Mikligard (Constantinople) that summer; he had been long in service there, and was able to tell many things from there; and

it was thought good entertainment to inquire from him about things in that part of the world. The Earl conversed frequently with him.

79.3

Once when they were talking, Eindridi said: "It seems strange to me that you do not think of going out to Jórslaheim (Jerusalem), and that you should be satisfied with being told of the things that are there; it would best suit such men as you are to be there on account of your great accomplishments, and you will be honoured above all others wherever you come among noble men."

79.4

When Eindridi had said this, many spoke in favour of it, and exhorted the Earl to become the leader of such an expedition. Erling made a long speech in support of the proposal, and said he would join the party himself, if the Earl would consent to be their chief. And as many men of note seemed eager for the journey, he promised to go. And when he and Erling were settling matters between them, many noble men joined the party. These Lendermen (Barons) were among them: Eindridi Ungi, who was to be their guide, Jón Pétsson, Aslák Erlendsson, Guttorm Möl, and Kol from Halland. It was resolved that none of them should have a larger ship than with thirty benches, except the Earl, and no one should have an ornamented vessel but he. This was done in order that no one should envy another because he had finer men or a better ship than he. Jón Fót (leg) was to build a ship for the Earl, and to have it as finely fitted out as possible. Earl Rögnvald went home in the autumn, and intended to stay at home two winters. King Ingi gave the Earl two long ships — small, but very beautiful, and specially built for rowing; they were, therefore, of all the ships the swiftest. Earl Rögnvald gave Harald one of them, called Fífa; the other was called Hjálp. In these ships the Earls went to sea, holding westward. Earl Rögnvald had received large presents from his friends. It was Tuesday evening when the Earls put out to sea, and they had a fair wind during the night. On Wednesday there was a great storm, and in the evening they saw land. It was very dark, and they saw signs of

breakers surrounding them on all sides. Up to this time they had kept together. There was nothing to be done except to run the vessels on shore, and this they did. The beach before them was stony and narrow, enclosed behind by crags. All the men were saved, but they lost a large quantity of their stores. Some of the things were thrown up by the sea during the night. As usual, Earl Rögnvald bore himself as the bravest of all the men there. He was so merry that he played with his fingers, and spoke nearly all his sayings in rhyme. He took a golden ring from his hand, and sang this ditty:

79.5

Thus I hang the hammer-beaten  
Hand-ring from my rounded fingers;  
Thus I put my fingers through it:  
So the nymph of crashing waters  
Threw me, joyful, in a rock-rift  
There to play me with my fingers.

79.6

When they had carried their things up from the sea, they went farther inland to search for habitations, because they thought they knew they had landed in Hjaltland. They soon found farms, and distributed themselves among them. The people were glad to see the Earl, and when he was asked about his voyage, he sang:

79.7

Both my ships on beach went crashing;  
When the surges swept my men off,  
Sore afflicted by the billows  
Were the friends of Hjalp and Fífa.

79.8

Certainly this misadventure  
Of the danger-seeking rovers  
Will not soon be quite forgotten  
By those who got such a wetting.

79.9

The mistress of the house brought a fur cloak to the Earl, who, stretching his hands forward to receive it, and laughing, sang this ditty:

79.10

Here I shake a shrunken fur coat;  
Surely 'tis not ornamental.

79.11

All our clothes are in the ship-field,  
And it is too wide to seek them.

79.12

Lately, all the young sea-horses  
Left we dressed in splendid garments,  
As we drove the steeds of mast-heads  
To the crags, across the surges.

79.13

Large fires were made, and there they warmed themselves. A female servant entered shivering all over, and her words were unintelligible on account of her shiver. The Earl said he understood her:

79.14

Asa! you seem quite exhausted.

79.15

Atatata! 'tis the water.

79.16

Hutututu! where shall I sit?

79.17

By the fire— 'tis rather chilly.

79.18

The Earl sent twelve of his men to Einar in Gullberuvík, but he said he would not receive them unless the Earl came himself. When Earl Rögnvald heard this, he sang:

79.19

Einar said he would give food to  
None of all the lads of Rögnvald,  
He himself alone excepted —  
(Empty words I now am talking),  
For I know that he, the friendly,  
Never failed to keep his promise.

79.20

Go we in then where the fires are  
Burning brightly all the evening.

79.21

The Earl stayed a long time in Hjaltland, and in the autumn he went south to the Orkneys, and resided in his dominions. That autumn two Hjaltlanders came to him. One was named Armód, a poet; the other was Oddi the little, the son of Glúm: he made verses well. The Earl received them both as his men. The Earl had a grand Yule feast, to which he invited guests, and gave his men presents. He handed a spear, inlaid with gold, to the poet Armód, shook it at him, and told him to make a song on the spur of the moment:

79.22

Princely gifts the battle-fanner  
With no niggard hand distributes:  
Scaldic honours are not measured  
By the gifts bestowed on others.

79.23

The defender of his country,  
And the best of all commanders,  
With his own hand brings to Armód  
This blood-candle, golden pointed.

79.24

One day during Yule the guests were looking at the tapestry. The Earl said to Oddi the little: “Make a song about the workman’s handicraft on the tapestry, and have it made by the time that I have finished my

stanza, and use none of the same words that are in mine.” The Earl sang:

79.25

The old one on the hangings standing,  
Has a sheath-rod on his shoulder,  
But, in spite of all his anger,  
He will not get one step farther.

79.26

Oddi sang:

79.27

For a stroke himself prepares the  
Warrior in stooping posture,  
Where the tapestry is parted;  
Yet his danger will be greatest.

79.28

Time it is for ships' commanders  
Peace to make ere harm does happen.

79.29

During Yule-tide, the Earl entertained Bishop William and many of his chiefs. Then he made known his intention to go to Jórsalaheim (Jerusalem), and requested the Bishop to go with him, because he was a good Parisian scholar, and the Earl wished him to be their interpreter. The Bishop agreed to the Earl's request, and promised to go. The following chiefs went with Earl Rögnvald: — Magnus, the son of Hávard, Gunni's son; Swein, Hróald's son; and the following men of lesser note: — Thorgeir Skotakoll, Oddi the little, Thorberg Svarti, Armód the scald, Thorkel Krókauga, Grímkell of Flettuness, and Bjarni his son. When the two winters appointed for their preparations were passed, Earl Rögnvald went early in the spring from the Orkneys east to Norway, to see how far the Lendermen (Barons) had progressed with their preparations; and when he came to Biörgvin, he found there Erling, Jón, his brother-in-law, and Aslák, but Guttorm arrived shortly after. To Biörgvin came also the ship which Jón Fót had caused to be

built for the Earl. It was a most exquisite piece of workmanship, and all ornamented. The whole of the carved work on the prow, the vanes, and many other parts of the ship, were gilt. Altogether, it was a most splendid ship. Eindridi came frequently to town during the summer, and said he should be ready in a week. The Earl's men murmured greatly at having to wait so long, and some proposed not to wait for him, saying that such voyages as this had been made without Eindridi. A short time after Eindridi came to town and said he was ready. Then the Earl commanded his men to set sail when they thought there was favourable wind; and when the day came when they thought they might expect a favourable wind, they left the town, and set sail. The breeze was faint, and the Earl's ship moved slowly, because it required strong wind. The other chiefs lowered their sails, and would not leave the Earl. When they were outside the Islands, the breeze increased to such a degree that in the smaller vessels they had to take in sail, but the Earl's ship now went at a great speed. They saw two large ships coming after them, and soon they passed them. One of these two ships was highly finished. It was a dragon; both its head and stem were richly gilded; it was white on the bows, and painted everywhere above the sea where it was thought it would look well. The Earl's men said that was very likely Eindridi's, adding: "He has not kept well the agreement that no one should have an ornamented ship except you, sire."

79.30

The Earl replied: "Eindridi's pride is great, and he may be excused for not liking to be on the same level with us, as we are so much his inferiors; but it is difficult to see whether his good fortune runs before him or goes along with him. But let us not direct our movements according to his hotheadedness."

79.31

Eindridi soon passed them in the larger vessel, but the Earl kept all his ships together, and had a successful voyage. They arrived all safe in the Orkneys in the autumn.

## Chapter 80 · OF EARL ROGNVALD AND THE ORKNEYMEN

80.1

IT WAS RESOLVED that they should spend the winter there. Some lived at their own expense, others were quartered with the Bœndr, and many were with the Earl. There was a great turmoil in the Islands; the Orkney-men and the East-men quarrelled frequently about bargains, and women, and other things. The Earl had a very difficult task to keep peace among them, for both parties considered that he deserved well of them and they of him.

80.2

DRAGON SHIP OF THE VIKING PERIOD

(from Holmberg's Nordbon i Hednatiden.)

80.3

Of Eindridi it is to be told that when they came to Hjaltland (Shetland) his fine ship was totally wrecked, and he lost a great quantity of goods, but the smaller ship was saved. He spent the winter in Hjaltland, and sent men to Norway to have another ship built for the voyage to the East.

80.4

One of Eindridi's crew was called Arni Spítulegg (stick-leg). He went to the Orkneys during the winter with nine men. Arni was a very violent man, daring and turbulent. He and his comrades lived at their own expense during the winter. He bought malt and meat of a tenant of Swein, Asleif's son, and when he demanded payment Arni delayed to pay. When he demanded it a second time, he was overwhelmed with abuse; and before they parted Arni struck him with the back of his axe, saying, "Go and tell your champion, Swein, whom you are always praising, to obtain redress for you; you will need no more." The man went and told Swein, requesting him to obtain redress. He gave him a cold answer, and said he would promise nothing. One day in the spring Swein went to collect his rents. They were four together in a ten-oared boat. They had to pass the island in which Arni was staying, and Swein said he would land there. It was ebbing tide. Swein went on

shore alone, carrying an axe with a short handle, and no other weapon. He told his men to keep the boat from getting aground. Arni Spítulegg and his comrades were lying in an outhouse not far from the sea. Swein walked up, and found them indoors. They greeted him. He acknowledged their greeting, and spoke to Arni, saying that he should settle the farmer's account. Arni replied that there was plenty of time for that. Swein asked him to do it for his intercession, but still Arni refused. Then Swein said he would not ask any further, and at the same time he drove the axe into Arni's skull, so that the iron was buried in it, and he lost hold of the handle. Swein ran out, and Arni's companions after him, to the beach. As they ran fast along the muddy shore, one of them, who was the swiftest, came to close quarters with him. There were large roots of seaweed lying in the mud. Swein seized one of them, and thrust it into the face of the man who had come up with him, and he grasped at his eyes to clear the mud away, but Swein escaped to his boat, and went home to Gáreksey. Shortly after he went on his own business over to Caithness, and sent word to Earl Rögnvald to settle the matter about Arni Spítulegg's slaying. And when the Earl received the message, he summoned together those who were entitled to compensation for Arni, and settled the matter to their satisfaction, he himself paying the compensation money. Many other acts of violence perpetrated by the Eastmen and the Orkney men during the winter the Earl made good out of his own [funds].

## 80.5

Early in the spring he called a Thing meeting in Hrossey (Mainland), to which came all the chiefs residing in his dominions. He then made it known to them that he intended to leave the Orkneys and to go to Jórsalaheim (Jerusalem), saying that he would leave the government in the hands of his kinsman Harald, and praying all his friends to obey him, and help him faithfully in whatever he required while he was obliged to be away himself. Earl Harald was then nearly twenty, tall and strong, but ugly; yet he was a wise man, and the people thought he would be a good chief.

80.6

In the summer Earl Rögnvald prepared to leave the Orkneys; but the summer was far advanced before he was ready, because he had to wait a long time for Eindridi until his ship came from Norway. When they were ready, they left the Orkneys in fifteen large ships. The following were commanders of ships: — Earl Rögnvald; Erling Skakki; Bishop William; Aslák, Erlend's son; Guttorm; Magnus, Hávard's son; Swein, Hróald's son; Eindridi Ungi; and the others who were with him are not named. From the Orkneys they sailed to Scotland, and then to England, and when they sailed to Nordymbraland (Northumberland), off the mouth of Hvera (the Wear), Armód sang:

80.7

High the crests were of the billows  
As we passed the mouth of Hvera;  
Masts were bending, and the low land  
Met the waves in long sand reaches;  
Blind our eyes were with the salt spray  
While the youths at home remaining,  
From the Thing-field fare on horseback.

80.8

Then they sailed till they were south off England, and so on to Valland. There is no account of their voyage until they came to a seaport called Verbon (Nerbon). There they learned that the Earl who had governed the city, and whose name was Geirbiörn, had lately died; but left a young and beautiful daughter, by name Ermingerd. She had charge of her patrimony, under the guardianship of her noblest kinsmen. They advised the Queen to invite Earl Rögnvald to a splendid banquet, saying that her fame would spread far if she gave a fitting reception to noblemen arrived from such a distance. The Queen left it to them; and when this had been resolved upon, men were sent to the Earl to tell him that the Queen invited him to a banquet, with as many men as he himself wished to accompany him. The Earl received her invitation gratefully, selecting the best of his men to go with him. And when they

came to the banquet there was good cheer, and nothing was spared by which the Earl might consider himself specially honoured. One day, while the Earl sat at the feast, the Queen entered the hall, attended by many ladies. She had in her hand a golden cup, and was arrayed in the finest robes. She wore her hair loose, according to the custom of maidens, and a golden diadem round her forehead. She poured out for the Earl, and the maidens played for them. The Earl took her hand along with the cup, and placed her beside him. They conversed during the day. The Earl sang:

80.9

Lady fair! thy form surpasses  
All the loveliness of maidens,  
Though arrayed in costly garments,  
And adorned with precious jewels:  
Silken curls in radiant splendour  
Fall upon the beauteous shoulders  
Of the goddess of the gold-rings.  
The greedy eagle's claws I redden'd.

80.10

The Earl stayed there a long time, and was well entertained. The inhabitants of the city solicited him to take up his residence there, saying that they were in favour of giving the Queen to him in marriage. The Earl said he wished to complete his intended journey, but that he would come there on his return, and then they might do what they thought fit. Then the Earl left with his retinue, and sailed round Thrasness. They had a fair wind, and sat and drank, and made themselves merry. The Earl sang this song:

80.11

Long in the Prince's memory  
Ermingerda's soft words shall linger;  
It is her desire that we shall  
Ride the waters out to Jordan;  
But the riders of sea-horses,

From the southern climes returning,  
 Soon shall plough their way to Verbon  
 O'er the whale-pond in the autumn.  
 Then Armód sang:  
 Ne'er shall I see Ermingerda  
 More, from this time, if it be not  
 That my fate shall be propitious;  
 Many now are grieving for her.  
 Happy were I if I could but  
 Be beside her just for one day;  
 That, indeed, would be good fortune,  
 Once again to see her fair face.  
 Then Oddi sang:  
 Truth to tell, we two are scarcely  
 Worthy of fair Ermingerda;  
 For this wise and lovely Princess  
 May be called the Queen of Maidens:  
 This the title that beseemeth  
 Best the splendour of her beauty.  
 While she lives beneath the sun-ray,  
 May her lot be ever happy.

## 80.12

They went on till they came west to Galicialand, five nights before  
 Yule-tide, and intended to spend it there. They asked the inhabitants  
 whether they were willing to sell them provisions; but food is scarce in  
 that country, and they thought it a great hardship to have to feed such  
 a numerous host. It so happened that the country was under the rule of  
 a foreigner, who resided in the castle, and oppressed the inhabitants  
 greatly. He made war on them if they did not do everything he wished,  
 and menaced them with violence and oppression. When the Earl asked  
 the inhabitants to sell him victuals, they consented to do so until Lent,  
 but made certain proposals on their part — to wit, that Earl Rögnvald  
 should attack their enemies, and should have all the money which he

might obtain from them. The Earl communicated this to his men, and asked them what they would be inclined to do. Most of them were willing to attack the castle, thinking that it was a very likely place to obtain booty. Therefore Earl Rögnvald and his men agreed to the terms of the inhabitants.

80.13

When the Yule-tide was close at hand the Earl called his men together, and said: "We have been resting for a while, and have not disturbed the men of the castle, and the inhabitants are getting tired of supplying us. I suppose they will think our promise will come to nothing; and it is not manly in us not to try to do what we promised. Now, I wish to hear your advice as to how we are to take the castle, as I know you here are men of great discretion; therefore I ask every one here present to state what plan he thinks most likely to succeed."

80.14

Erling replied to the Earl, and said: "I will not be silent since you command us to speak, although I am not a man of sage counsels; and those ought rather to be asked who have seen more and are more experienced in such undertakings, as Eindridi Ungi. But I suppose we must do here as the saying is, 'Shoot at the bird before we catch it.' I may try to give some advice, whatever may be its value. If you and the other ship-commanders do not think it a bad plan, we shall to-day go all of us to the wood, and carry three bundles of faggots each to the castle, because it appears to me that the lime would not stand well if much heat were applied to it. Let us do this for the next three days, and see what happens."

80.15

They did as Erling advised, and when they had finished their work Yule was close at hand. The Bishop would not permit the inhabitants of the castle to be attacked during the Yule-tide.

80.16

The chief inhabiting the castle was named Gudifrey. He was a wise man, and somewhat advanced in years. He was a good scholar, had travelled

much, and knew many languages. He was a covetous man, and overbearing.

80.17

When he saw what the strangers were doing, he called his men together, and said: "The plan adopted by the Northmen seems to me a wise one, and likely to do us great harm. We shall see, when fire is applied to the stone wall round the castle, that it is not strong. Moreover, the Northmen are valiant, and men of great strength, and we may expect a fierce attack from them if they get an opportunity. Now, I wish to hear your advice about the difficult position in which we are placed."

80.18

But all his men asked him to do what he thought best.

80.19

Then he said: "My first plan is to tie ropes together, and you shall let me down over the castle wall. I will dress myself in rags, and go to the camp of the Northmen, and see what I can ascertain."

80.20

They did as he told them, and he came to Earl Rögnvald pretending to be a beggar, and speaking Valska, as they understood a little of it. He walked throughout the camp and begged food. He perceived that there was much jealousy among the Northmen, and that they were divided into two factions. Eindridi Ungi was the leader of one, and the Earl of the other.

80.21

Gudifrey went to Eindridi and spoke to him. He said that the chief of the castle had sent him there, wishing to form an alliance with him. "He expects that you will give him quarter if the castle is taken; and he is more willing to let you have his treasure, if you will do this in return, than those who wish to have him a dead man."

80.22

Such things they spoke, and many others, but it was concealed from the Earl, as at first they observed profound secrecy. When Gudifrey had

been some time with the Earl's men, he returned to his castle. But they did not remove their property from it, because they did not know whether the attack would be successful, and they could not put faith in the inhabitants.

## Chapter 81 · EARL ROGNVALD TAKES A CASTLE

81.1

THE TENTH DAY of Yule-tide was a fine day, and Earl Rögnvald arose and commanded his men to arm themselves, and summoned them with trumpets to the attack of the castle. They dragged the wood close to it, and heaped up large piles round the walls. Then the Earl gave orders where each should make the attack. He himself with the Orkney men had the attack from the south, Erling and Aslák from the west, Jón and Guttorm from the east, and Eindridi Ungi from the north. When they were ready for the attack, they set fire to the wood, and the Earl sang:

81.2

Maids in lace and snow-white linen  
Bring us here the white wine sparkling.

81.3

Fair to see was Ermingerda,  
When we met her in our travels.

81.4

Fare we now to try the castle  
With our flaming oaken firebrands;  
Quickly leaping from the scabbard  
Gleams the sharp-edged smiter. Forward!

81.5

Now they began to attack the castle vigorously, both with weapons and with fire. They shot missiles into it, for that was the only way of attack. The besieged did not stand firm on the walls, because they had to guard themselves against the missiles. They poured down burning pitch and brimstone, which, however, did very little harm to the Earl's

men. What Erling had foretold came to pass; the lime could not stand the fire, and the wall fell down, leaving large breaches open.

81.6

A man named Sigmund Ongul (fish-hook), the Earl's stepson, was one of the keenest in the attack, and frequently went in front of the Earl, although he was then hardly a full-grown man. When the attack had lasted for a while, all the besieged were driven from the wall. The wind blew from the south, and drove all the smoke towards Eindridi, and when the fire began to spread rapidly the Earl had water poured on it to cool the burnt stones, and then there was a short pause in the attack. The Earl sang a song:

81.7

Now I mind me of the Yule-tide  
Which I spent with friends and brave men  
On the east of Agdir's mountains,  
With the valiant warrior Sölmund;  
Now, again, another Yule-tide  
Am I in the same way busy  
At the south side of this castle,  
Adding to the din of weapons.

81.8

Further he sang:

81.9

Glad I was when that fair lady  
Listened to my love-tale's telling;  
Hopelessly was I led captive  
By a Valland maid in autumn.

81.10

Still I love the noble lady,  
And I spread the feast for eagles.

81.11

Stone and lime, well bound together,  
Now before me fall asunder.

81.12

Then Sigmund Ongul sang:

81.13

When, in spring-time, o'er the waters  
Ye go homeward to the Orkneys,  
Tell the lady whom I most love —  
Lady of the splendid garments —  
That, beneath the castle ramparts,  
There was none who stepped more boldly  
'Mong the young men than her lover.

81.14

Then the Earl and Sigmund prepared to force their way into the castle, and meeting with little resistance, they entered it, and many were killed; but those that surrendered to the Earl received quarter. They obtained a great deal of property, but did not find the chief, and almost no treasure. There was a great discussion about the escape of Gudifrey, and how he had effected it; and they soon suspected Eindridi Ungi that he had given him the means of escaping, and that he had followed the smoke, and thus gained the forest.

81.15

After this Earl Rögnvald and his men stayed a short time in Galicialand, and directed their course along the west of Spain. They plundered far and wide in heathen Spainland, and obtained great booty. They went into a certain village, but the villagers ran together and offered fight. They made a stout resistance, but fled at last, when many of them had been killed. The Earl sang:

81.16

When in Spainland I went fighting,  
Quickly we o'erthrew the foemen,  
For, when tired of our hard hewing,  
Home they ran to see their sweethearts:  
All the land was strewed with corpses.

81.17

Our deeds in song shall now be famous;  
And my hope is, to be worthy  
Of the lovely Ermingerda.

81.18

Then they sailed along the west of Spain, and were overtaken by a gale.  
There they lay at anchor three days, and great waves broke over them,  
so that the vessels nearly foundered. Then the Earl sang:

81.19

Here I'm storm-tossed, but undaunted,  
While the cables hold together,  
And the tackle of the vessel  
Breaks not, as she breasts the billows;  
I am promised to the fair one  
Whom we left out in the North-land;  
Now again there comes a fair wind;  
Speed we on into the channel.

81.20

Then they set sail, and ran into Njörfasund with a fair wind, and Oddi sang:

81.21

When the faithful friend of heroes,  
In the guest-hall sweet mead quaffing,  
Sat beside the fair ring-giver,  
That was a week to be remembered.

81.22

Now the splendid steeds of billows  
Bear the noble-minded Rögnvald  
And his warriors, wearing bucklers,  
Quickly through the Sound of Njörfi.

81.23

When they were tacking into the Sound, the Earl sang:

81.24

By an east wind, breathing softly,  
As from lips of Valland lady,  
Are our ships now wafted onward,  
As we push the yards out farther;  
Though we had to tie the canvas  
Tighter than we had expected  
To the middle of the sailyard,  
South off Spain — we bear away now.

81.25

They sailed through Njörfasund, and then the gale began to abate; and when they had cleared the Sound, Eindridi Ungi parted from the Earl with six ships, and sailed across the sea to Marselia (Marseilles), but Earl Rögnvald and his men remained at the Sound. It was said that Eindridi now himself proved that he had allowed Gudifrey to escape. The Earl's men sailed out to sea, and stood southwards to Serkland. Then Earl Rögnvald sang:

81.26

Now our good ship, land forsaking,  
Laves her breast in limpid waters.

81.27

Long ere he who sings these verses,  
Sees again the northern islands;  
With the sharp prow I the yielding  
Earth-surrounding sea am carving,  
Far off Spain-land, sweeping southward.

81.28

More is not said of the Earl's progress till they came south off Serkland, and lay near Sardinia, not knowing where the land was. It was very calm, and a thick fog spread over the water, so that they could hardly see anything from the ships, and they sailed therefore slowly. One morning the mist disappeared, and the crew arose and looked around and saw two islets. When they looked for them the second time, there was but one islet. This they told to the Earl. Then he said: "This cannot

have been islets which you have seen; it must be ships such as they have in this part of the world, and which they call Drómundar. From a distance they look as big as holms. But where the other Drómund lay, a puff of wind has probably swept over the water, and she has sailed away; but they are likely some rovers.”

81.29

Then he summoned the Bishop and all the ship-commanders, and said: “I ask of you my Lord Bishop, and Erling my kinsman, whether you see any chance or device by which we may overcome those in the Drómund.”

81.30

The Bishop replied: “I think you will find it difficult to attack the Drómund in your long-ships, for you will hardly be able to reach their bulwarks with a boarding-pike, and they have probably brimstone and boiling pitch to pour under your feet and over your heads. You may see, Earl Rögnvald, wise as you are, that it would be the greatest rashness to place yourself and your men in such jeopardy.”

81.31

Then Erling said: “My Lord Bishop, it may be that you are right in thinking that we shall not obtain the victory by rowing at them; yet I cannot help thinking that if we try to push close to the Drómund, their missiles will fall beyond our ships lying close alongside; but if this be not the case, we can push away quickly, for they will not be able to chase us in the Drómund.”

81.32

The Earl said: “That is bravely spoken, and very much to my own mind. I will now make it known to the ships’ commanders and all the men, that every one may arm and prepare himself, each in his own place, as well as he can. Then let us attack them, and if they are Christian merchants, we can make peace with them; but if they are heathens, which I think they are, by the favour of Almighty God we shall be able to overcome them, but of the booty we obtain we shall give every fiftieth penny to the poor.”

81.33

Then they unfastened their arms, prepared the bulwarks of their ships for battle, and made themselves ready in other ways as their circumstances permitted. The Earl assigned to each vessel its place in the attack; then they pulled vigorously onwards.

## Chapter 82 · RÖGNVALD CONQUERS THE DRÓMUND

82.1

WHEN THE MEN in the Drómund saw the ships pulling towards them, to attack them, they spread fine clothing and costly stuffs out on the bulwarks, and made a great shouting, which the Earl's men took as a challenge. Earl Rögnvald brought his ship close under the stem of the Drómund, on the starboard side. Erling did the same on the larboard side. Jón and Aslák brought theirs under her bows, and the others amidships on either side, all sticking as close to her as possible. But when they came close under the Drómund, she was so high in the side that the Northmen were unable to use their weapons, and the others poured blazing brimstone and burning pitch over them; but most of it fell outside the ships, as Erling had foreseen, and they had no need to shield themselves from it. However, when the attack did not succeed, the Bishop moved away his ship and two others, and they told off their bowmen to go in them. After having got to a convenient distance for shooting, they shot their arrows into the Drómund, and this was the most effective mode of attack. The men in the Drómund protected themselves with their shields, and paid little heed to what those were doing who were in the ships close under the Drómund.

82.2

Earl Rögnvald then ordered his men to take their axes, and cut the planks of the Drómund, where the iron fastenings were fewest; and when the men in the other ships saw what the Earl's men were doing, they did the same. Now, where Erling had stationed himself, there was a large anchor hanging from the Drómund, which had its fluke hooked over the gunwale, but the shank hung down towards Erling's ship. One

of his forecastle men was named Andun Raudi (red); he was lifted up on the anchor-stock, and then he pulled up others. Standing there as close as they could, they hacked away at the planks with all their might; and this was far higher than the others could reach. When they had made an opening large enough to admit them, they prepared to board the Drómund. The Earl and his men entered on the lower deck, and Erling and his men on the upper; and when they both got in, there began to be severe fighting. Those in the Drómund were Saracens, whom we call Mahometan infidels. There were also many black men, who withstood them most fiercely. Erling received a severe wound in the neck, near the shoulder, when he jumped on board; it healed so badly that he carried his head to a side ever after, and therefore he was called crick-neck (Skakki).

## 82.3

When Earl Rögnvald and Erling joined each other, the Saracens were driven to the forepart of the ship; and the Earl's men boarded one after another until they were more numerous, and then they pressed the enemy hard. In the Drómund they saw one man far superior to the others in appearance and stature, and they were persuaded that he must be their chief. Earl Rögnvald ordered his men not to wound him, if they could seize him in any other way. Then they surrounded him, and pressed him with their shields, and thus caught him. He and a few others with him were sent to the Bishop's ship. All the rest they killed, and obtained great booty and many precious things. When they had finished the hardest part of their work, they sat down and rested, and the Earl sang:

## 82.4

At the spreading of the banner,  
Erling, mighty tree of battle,  
Went to victory and honour  
Foremost when we fought the Drómund;  
Then we felled the black-skinned fighters;  
Everywhere the blood ran streaming,

And the keen-edged swords were reddened  
As we hewed among the heathen.

82.5

We have had our fill of slaughter,  
Round us lie the heaps of corpses;  
Gory swords have been red-painting  
At the Drómund all this morning;  
Soon the news will spread to northward  
Of this furious sword-tempest;  
It will soon be known at Verbon,  
How we dealt death-blows this morning.

82.6

There was much talk about what had been done; every one told what he had seen. Then they talked of who had been the first to board, but were not all of one opinion. Some said it would not be creditable to them if they did not all relate this great exploit in the same way. At last they all agreed to let Earl Rögnvald decide, and every one should afterwards tell the story in the same way as he did. Then the Earl sang:

82.7

Audun Raudi was the man who  
First, with energy and valour,  
Scaled the black sides of the Drómund;  
Soon the brave one seized his booty.

82.8

By the help of God's good favour  
Have we overcome the heathen;  
Steeped our swords are all in red blood;  
Round us lie the sable corpses.

82.9

When they had cleared the Drómund, they set it on fire. When the big man whom they had taken prisoner saw this, he changed colour and became pale, and could not keep himself still. But though they tried to make him speak, he did not say a word, neither did he make any kind of

sign; he was immovable to fair promises and menaces alike. But when the Drómund began to blaze up, they saw a glowing stream, as it were, run into the sea. At this the captive man was greatly moved. They concluded that they had not made a careful search for the money, and now the metal, whether gold or silver, had melted in the fire.

82.10

Then Earl Rögnvald and his men sailed south, under Serkland, and lay off a certain town of Serkland, and had seven nights' truce with the men of the town, and sold them silver and other valuables. No one would buy the big man; and then the Earl gave him leave to go away with four men. He came back on the morning after, with his men, and told them that he was a nobleman of Serkland, and that he had been ransomed from there with the Drómund and all its contents. "It grieved me most," he said, "that you should burn it, and thus destroy so much treasure, without any one's having the benefit of it. Now you are in my power, but it counts for your benefit with me that you spared my life, and did me such honour as you could. But I would gladly never see you again, and now may you live hale and well." Then he rode away into the country.

82.11

Earl Rögnvald sailed to Crete, and anchored in a strong gale. When Armod kept watch during the night, he sang:

82.12

Lie we now, where stormy billows  
Break above the sturdy bulwarks;  
My lot is to keep the watch well,  
On this wave-surmounting seahorse;  
While the lads are snugly sleeping,  
I, to Crete, look o'er my shoulder.

82.13

They lay off Crete until they had fair wind to Jórsalir (Jerusalem), and arrived early on a Friday morning at Akursborg (Acre). They went on

shore with great pomp and splendour, such as seldom had been seen there. Thorbiörn Svarti sang:

82.14

Oft have I, with comrades hardy,  
Been in battle, in the Orkneys,  
When the feeder of the people  
Led his forces to the combat.

82.15

Now our trusty Earl we follow,  
As we carry up our bucklers  
Gaily to the gates of Acre  
On this joyful Friday morning.

82.16

They stayed in Akursborg for a while, and a disease broke out among their men, of which many died. Thorbiörn Svarti died there. Oddi Litli sang:

82.17

Bravely bore the Baron's vessels  
Thorbiörn Svarti, scald and comrade,  
As he trod the sea-king's highway,  
Round by Thrasness, south to Acre.

82.18

There I saw them heap the grave-mould  
Of the High Church o'er the King's friend.

82.19

Earth and stones now lies he under  
In that southern land of sunshine.

82.20

Earl Rögnvald and his men left Akursborg, and visited all the holiest places of Jorsalaland. They went all to Jordan and bathed. Earl Rögnvald and Sigmund Ongul swam across the river, and went to some shrubs and tied large knots. The Earl sang:

82.21

Long the way is I have travelled  
To this heath, enclosed by deserts,  
And the wise maid will remember,  
Too, my crossing over Jordan.

82.22

Seems to me, that those who tarry  
At their homesteads, will not find it  
A short journey here to travel.

82.23

Warm the blood falls on the wide plain.

82.24

Then Sigmund sang:

82.25

This day I have tied a strong knot  
For the churlish clown that's sitting  
By the home-hearth; 'tis no falsehood  
That we play him now a fine trick.

82.26

The Earl sang:

82.27

On this feast-day of St. Lawrence,  
Tie we knots for this fine fellow.

82.28

Tired I came to this nice corner,  
Where the shrubs grow close together.

82.29

And when they were going from Jorsalaland Earl Rögnvald sang:

82.30

From the scald's neck hangs the cross now,  
In his hand a palm he carries.

82.31

Now should cease unkindly feelings:  
From the heights my men rush downwards.

82.32

During the summer Earl Rögnvald and his men left Jorsalaland, and were going to Mikligard. In the autumn they came to a town called Imbolum, and stayed there a long time. When two persons met where the street was crowded, and one of them thought it necessary to go to one side, he cried out to the other, "Midway, midway!" One evening the Earl's men, among whom was Erling Skakki, walked from the town, and on the bridge leading to the ship, some inhabitants of the town met them, and cried out, "Midway, midway!" Erling was very drunk, and pretended not to hear it; and when they met, he jumped from the bridge into the mud; his men ran to his assistance, and dragged him out, and had to undress him completely. Next morning, when the Earl saw him, and was told what had happened, he smiled and sang:

82.33

Bad the luck my friend has met with;  
In the mud he tumbled, splashing;  
As he would not cry out "Midway!"

82.34

Loudly, like the foreign people.

82.35

I suppose the prince's brother,  
When upset, looked rather rueful.

82.36

Black the mud that on the ground is  
In Imbol, as Erling knoweth.

82.37

Some time after, it happened that they came from the town very drunk, and Jón Fót was missed by his men, and no one else was missing. They sent immediately to the other ships to search for him, but he was not found. They could not search for him on shore during the night; but in the morning, when it was daylight, they found him murdered

under the wall of the town; but it was never known who had slain him. They buried him honourably at a holy church, and then they went away, and came north to Ægisness, and there they waited some nights for a fair wind to sail to Mikligard. They made their ships look splendidly, and sailed with great pomp, as they knew Sigurd Jorsalafari had done. While they were crossing the sea northward the Earl sang this song:

82.38

Let us ride the sea-king's horses,  
Leave the plough in field untouched.

82.39

As we drive the wet prows onward  
All the way to Mikligard.

82.40

There we'll take the royal bounty,  
Paid for wielding well our weapons,  
While we fill the wolf's red palate,  
And on battlefields win honour.

## Chapter 83 · OF EARL RÖGNVALD

83.1

RÖGNVALD AND HIS men came to Mikligard, and were well received by the Emperor and the Væringiar. At this time Menelaus, whom we call Manuli, was the Emperor of Mikligard. He gave them a great deal of money, and offered them pay if they would stay there permanently. They spent there a great part of the winter. Eindridi Ungi was there when they came, and was highly honoured by the Emperor. He had little to do with the Earl and his men, but rather spoke slightly of them to others. Rögnvald commenced his journey from Mikligard during the winter, and went first to Dýraksborg in Bólgaraland. From there they sailed west to Púll. Earl Rögnvald, Erling, Bishop William, and most others of their noblest men left their ships there, procured horses, and rode first to Rómaborg (Rome), and then from Róm until

they came to Denmark. From there they went to Norway, where the people were glad to see them. This journey became very famous, and all those who had made it were considered greater men afterwards than before.

## 83.2

Ogmund Dreng, Erling Skakki's brother, had died while they were away; while both were alive, he was considered the greater of the two. After the death of King Ingi, Magnus, the son of Erling and Kristín, the daughter of Sigurd Jorsalafari, was made King, but the government of Norway was in the hands of Erling alone. Valdimar, King of the Danes, gave him the title of Earl, and he became a great chief. Eindridi came from the south some winters after Earl Rögnvald, and went to King Eystein, because he would not have anything to do with Erling. But after King Eystein's death Eindridi and Sigurd, the son of Hávard Höld of Rey, raised a party, and made Hákon Herdabreid, the son of King Sigurd, son of Harald Gilli, their king. They slew Gregorius Dag's son and King Ingi. Eindridi and Hákon fought with Erling, under Sekkr, where Hákon was killed; but Eindridi fled. Earl Erling had Eindridi Ungi killed some time after in Vik.

## 83.3

Earl Rögnvald spent the summer in Hördaland, in Norway, and heard many tidings from the Orkneys. There were great disturbances there, and most of the chiefs were divided into two factions, few remaining neutral. Earl Harald was at the head of one of these factions, and Earl Erlend and Swein, Asleif's son, of the other. When the Earl heard this, he sang:

## 83.4

Though the most part of my nobles  
Have forgot the oaths they sware me  
(Such the wickedness of men is),  
Yet will their designs be thwarted.

## 83.5

Traitors plotting in my absence,  
Will not by it grow more loyal;  
Slow but sure shall be my motto  
While a beard on chin I carry.

83.6

The Earl had no ships, but he asked his kinsmen and friends to build some long-ships for him during the winter. They gave a favourable answer, and consented to everything he proposed, and built the ships.

## Chapter 84 · EARL RÖGNVALD GOES TO THE ORKNEYS

84.1

IN THE SUMMER the Earl made himself ready to go west to his dominions in the Orkneys, but it was late before he was ready, because many things kept him back. He went to the west in a merchant-vessel belonging to Thórhall, Asgrím's son, an Icelander of a noble family, who had a farm south in Biskupstungur. The Earl had a numerous train of noblemen on board the vessel. When they came to Scotland the winter was far advanced, and they lay at Torfnæs. The Earl arrived in his dominions shortly before Yule.

## Chapter 85 · KING EYSTEIN TAKES EARL HARALD PRISONER

85.1

NOW WE HAVE to tell what happened in the Orkneys while Earl Rögnvald was away. The same summer that the Earl went on his journey, King Eystein, son of Harald Gilli, arrived from Norway with a numerous army, which he had landed at Rínarsey. He heard that Earl Harald had gone over to Caithness in a ship of twenty benches, with eighty men, and lay then at Thórsá. When King Eystein heard of him, he manned three boats, and crossed the Pentland Firth, going westward, and on to Thórsá. When he arrived there the Earl and his men did not know anything of them until the King's men boarded the ship, and took the Earl prisoner. He was brought before the King, and the result was that the Earl ransomed himself with three marks of

gold, and surrendered his dominions to King Eystein, so that he should hold them from him in the future. Then he became King Eystein's man, and confirmed their compact with oaths. From there King Eystein went to Scotland, and ravaged there during the summer. During this expedition he plundered in many parts of England, considering that he was taking revenge for King Harald, Sigurd's son.

## Chapter 86 · OF KING EYSTEIN

86.1

THEN KING EYSTEIN returned to his kingdom, and his expedition was variously thought of. Earl Harald remained in his dominions in the Orkneys, and most of the inhabitants were satisfied with his rule. At this time his father, Earl Maddad, was dead; but his mother, Margarét, had gone to the Orkneys. She was a handsome woman, but a virago. At this time David, the King of Scots, died, and his son Malcolm was made king. He was quite a child when he succeeded his father.

## Chapter 87 · OF EARL HARALD

87.1

ERLEND, THE SON of Harald Sléttmáli, spent most of his time in Thórsá. Sometimes he was in the Sudreyar, or on war expeditions, after the death of Earl Ottar. He was a very promising man, and accomplished in most things, liberal in money, gentle, open to advice, and greatly loved by his men. He had a large following.

87.2

There was a man named Anakol, who had fostered Erlend, and to his counsels he chiefly listened. He was of a noble family, and hardy. He was Earl Erlend's right-hand man.

87.3

When Earl Rögnvald had left his dominions to go to Jórsalaheim, Erlend went to Malcolm, the King of Scots, and requested him to give him an Earl's title, and Caithness for his support, as his father Earl Erlend had. And because Erlend had many friends, and Malcolm was a

child in years, it was brought about that he bestowed the title of Earl on Erlend, and gave him the half of Caithness jointly with his kinsman Harald. Then Erlend went to Caithness to see his friends.

87.4

After that he gathered troops together, went out to the Orkneys, and sought to be accepted by the inhabitants. When Earl Harald, Maddad's son, heard this, he gathered troops together, and had many men. Some parties went between the kinsmen and tried to make peace between them. Erlend asked for half of the Islands jointly with Earl Harald, but Earl Harald refused to give them up. Truce was, however, made between them for that year; and it was resolved that Erlend should go to the east and see the King of Norway, and ask for that half which belonged to Earl Rögnvald, which Earl Harald said he would surrender. Then Erlend went east to Norway, but Anakol and some of his party remained behind.

87.5

Gunni, Olaf's son, the brother of Swein, Asleif's son, had children by Margarét, Earl Harald's mother, but Earl Harald had banished him, and therefore enmity arose between him and Swein. The latter sent his brother Gunni south to Liódhús (Lewis) to his friend Liótólf, with whom he had been staying himself. Fugl, the son of Liótólf, was with Earl Harald, and there was therefore coldness between him and Swein. When Earl Erlend went east to Norway, Earl Harald went over to Caithness, and resided at Vík (Wick) during the winter. Swein, Asleif's son, was then at Thrasvík (Freswick), in Caithness, and took care of the estate which his stepsons had there, for his former wife was Ragnhild, Ingimund's daughter, though they lived but a short time together. Their son was Olaf. After that he married Ingirid, Thorkel's daughter. Their son was Andreas.

87.6

On Wednesday in Passion week Swein went with some others to Lambaborg. They saw a transport vessel coming from the north across the Pentland Firth, and Swein concluded that they were Earl Harald's

men whom he had sent to collect his revenues (scat) in Hjaltland. Swein ordered his men to take a boat and attack the barge, which they did. They seized all its cargo, and put Earl Harald's men on shore, and they went to Vík (Wick) and told him. Earl Harald did not say much to this, yet he said: "Swein and I shall have our turns." He distributed his men to be entertained during Easter. The Caithnessmen called this — that the Earl was in guest-quarters.

## Chapter 88 · OF SWEIN, ASLEIF'S SON

### 88.1

IMMEDIATELY AFTER EASTER week, Swein, Asleif's son, went with a barge and a boat rowed by oars to the Orkneys; and when they came to Skálpeid (Scapa), they took there a ship from Fugl, Liótólf's son. He was coming from his father at Liódhús (Lewis), and was going to Earl Harald. During the same trip they took twelve ounces of gold from Sigurd Klaufi, a housecarl of Earl Harald's. This money had been left at the homestead, but the owners were in Kirkiuvag (Kirkwall). Then Swein went over to Ness (Caithness), and up through Scotland. He found Malcolm, King of Scots, who was then nine winters old, in Aparadion (Aberdeen). Swein spent a month there, and was well entertained. The King of Scots insisted upon his enjoying all those emoluments of Caithness which he had before he became Earl Harald's enemy.

## Chapter 89 · OF SWEIN AND ANAKOL

### 89.1

AFTER THIS SWEIN prepared to go away, and the King of Scots and he parted very good friends. Then Swein went to his ships, and sailed from the south to the Orkneys. Anakol was at Dýrness when Swein sailed from the south, and they saw them sailing east off Múli. They sent Gauti, a bondi of Skeggbjarnarstadir, to Swein, and Anakol requested him to come to terms with Fugl about the seizure of the ship, because Anakol and Fugl were related to each other. When Gauti found

Swein, and told him Anakol's message, he sent a messenger back to Anakol, asking him to go to Sandey, that they might meet there, because he (Swein) had to be there himself. They had a peaceful meeting there, and came to terms; and the result was that Swein should make the award as he liked himself. After that Anakol formed an alliance with Swein, and bound himself to make peace between Swein and Earl Erlend, when he came from the east — for they were bitter enemies on account of the burning of Frákork. Swein and Anakol went to Stríónsey, and lay off Hofsness some nights. At this time Thorfinn Bessason lived at Stríónsey. His wife was Ingigerd, Swein's sister, who had been deserted by Thorbiörn Klerk.

## Chapter 90 · THE RECONCILIATION OF EARL ERLEND AND SWEIN

### 90.1

WHEN SWEIN AND Anakol were lying off Hofsness, Earl Erlend arrived there from Norway. Anakol and Thorfinn endeavoured to reconcile him to Swein, but he gave an unfavourable answer, saying that Swein had always been opposed to his kinsmen, and had not kept the agreement between him and Earl Ottar, that he should help him to the dominion. Then Swein offered the Earl his support, and they were negotiating the whole day; yet the Earl would not be reconciled until Anakol and Thorfinn declared that they would follow Swein from Orkney if the Earl would not make peace with him. Earl Erlend then told the message from King Eystein, that he should have that part of the Orkneys which had formerly been held by Earl Harald.

### 90.2

When they had made peace, Swein gave the advice that they should go to Earl Harald before he heard this from others, and ask him to surrender the dominion. Swein's advice was acted upon. They found Earl Harald on board his ship, off Kjárekstadir.

### 90.3

It was in the evening of Michaelsmas that Harald and his men saw long-ships approaching, and suspecting them to be enemies, they ran from the ships into the castle. There was a man named Arni, Rafn's son, who ran from Earl Harald's ship to Kirkiuvag. He was so frightened that he forgot that he had his shield at his shoulder until it stuck fast in the door. Earl Erlend and Swein ran from their ships, and pursued Earl Harald to the castle, and attacked them both with arms and fire. The assailed defended themselves bravely, until night parted them. Many were wounded on both sides, and Harald and his men would soon have been exhausted if the attack had lasted longer. The next morning the Bœndr and their mutual friends arrived, and tried to make peace between them. Earl Erlend and Swein were very reluctant to make peace. In the end, however, they agreed, on condition that Harald should swear to let Earl Erlend have his part of the Islands, and never demand it from him. These oaths were made in the presence of the best men in the Islands.

90.4

After that Earl Harald went over to Ness (Caithness), and to his friends in Scotland, accompanied by only a few men from the Orkneys.

90.5

Earl Erlend and Swein called together a Thing-meeting with the Bœndr in Kirkiuvag, and they arrived from all the Islands. Earl Erlend pleaded his cause, saying that King Eystein had given him that part of the Orkneys of which Earl Harald had charge, and he requested the Bœndr to receive him, showing them King Eystein's letters, which proved his words. Swein, and many others of his friends and kinsmen, spoke in favour of the Earl; and at last the Bœndr promised obedience to Earl Erlend. Then he took possession of all the islands, and became ruler over them. It was an agreement between Earl Erlend and the Bœndr that he should not hinder Earl Rögnvald from taking possession of that part of the islands which belonged to him, if it should be granted him to come back; but if Earl Rögnvald should demand more than one-half of the islands, they should help Earl

Erlend to resist his claims. Swein, Asleif's son, was frequently with Earl Erlend, and asked him to be on his guard, and not to trust Earl Harald or the Scots. The most part of the winter they were on board their ships, and had scouts on the look-out. Towards Yule-tide the weather began to grow boisterous, and Swein went home to his estate in Gáreksey, and asked the Earl not to relax his vigilance though they parted, and the Earl did so. He remained on board his ships, and had nowhere a Yule feast prepared for him in the Islands.

## Chapter 91 · EARL HARALD COMES UNPERCEIVED TO THE ORKNEYS

### 91.1

THE ELEVENTH DAY of Yule-tide, it happened in Gáreksey that Swein was sitting at his drink with his men. Rubbing his nose, he said: "I think Earl Harald is now on his way to the Islands."

### 91.2

His men replied that this was unlikely, on account of the strong gales prevailing at that time.

### 91.3

He replied: "I know such is your opinion, and I shall not therefore send intelligence to the Earl now, merely on the strength of my presentiment; yet I suspect it is necessary." Then the subject was dropped, and they went on drinking as before.

### 91.4

Earl Harald commenced his voyage to the Orkneys during Yule-tide. He had four ships, and a hundred men. Two nights he lay under Gáreksey (Grimsey?). They landed in Hafnarvag, in Hrossey, and the thirteenth day of Yule-tide they walked to Fiörd (Firth). They spent the Yule-holiday at Orkahaug. There two of their men were seized with madness, which retarded their journey. It was near day when they came to Fiörd (Firth). There they learned that Earl Erlend was on board his ship, but that he had been drinking during that day at a house on shore. There Harald and his men killed two men — one was

named Ketill, the name of the other is not mentioned — and made four prisoners: Arnfinn, Anakol's brother, another man called Liótólf, and two others. Harald and Thorbiörn Klerk returned to Thórsá; the brothers Benedict and Eirík went to Lambaborg, taking Arnfinn with them.

## 91.5

As soon as Earl Erlend became aware of the enemy, he sent men during the night to Gáreksey to tell Swein. He pushed out his boats immediately, and went to see Earl Erlend, according to the message, and they stayed on board the ships a great part of the winter. Benedict and his brother sent word that Arnfinn would not be liberated unless Earl Erlend sent them back their ship which had been seized off Kjárekstadir. The Earl was willing to give up the ship, but Anakol dissuaded him from it, saying that Arnfinn would get away without this sacrifice.

## 91.6

On the Wednesday before Lent, Anakol and Thorstein, Ragna's son, went over by night to Ness (Caithness) in a boat with twenty men. They hauled the boat ashore under a cliff in a hidden creek. Then they went up and hid themselves in some copsewood a short distance from Thrasvík (Freswick). They had fitted up the boat in such a way that the men seemed to be each in his place. Some men had come past the boat in the morning, and had not suspected anything.

## 91.7

Anakol and his men saw some men rowing from the borg and landing at the river-mouth. Then they saw a man riding from the borg, and another walking, whom they recognised to be Eirík. Then they divided themselves into two parties. Ten went along the river down to the sea, to prevent them from getting to the boat; other ten went to the hamlet. Eirík came a short time before them to the hamlet, and walked towards the drinking-hall. Then he heard armed men moving about, and ran into the hall, and out through another door, and down to his boat; but there he came upon men who seized him, and brought him

out to the Islands to Earl Erlend. Then messengers were sent to Earl Harald to tell him that Eirík would not be liberated until Arnfinn and his companions came safe to Erlend. And the wishes of both were complied with.

## Chapter 92 · THE RECONCILIATION OF THE EARLS HARALD AND ERLEND

### 92.1

IN THE SPRING Earl Harald prepared to go from Caithness north to Hjaltland. His intention was to take the life of Erlend Ungi, who had wooed his mother Margarét, although the Earl (Harald) had refused him. Then Erlend gathered men together, and carried her off from the Orkneys, and took her north to Hjaltland, took up his residence in Moseyarborg, and made great preparations (for defence). When the Earl (Harald) came to Hjaltland, he besieged the borg, and cut off all communication; but it was difficult to take it by assault, and men went between them and tried to reconcile them. Erlend asked the Earl to give him the woman in marriage, and in return he offered to assist the Earl, saying it was of greater consequence for him to recover his dominions than this, and it would be advisable for him to make as many friends as he could. Many spoke in favour of Erlend's proposal; and the result was that they made peace, and Erlend married Margarét. Then he became an ally of Earl Harald, and during the summer they both went east to Norway.

### 92.2

When these tidings came to Orkney, Earl Erlend and his men laid their plans. Swein counselled to go on a harrying raid to obtain booty. This they did, and went south to Breidafiord, and made inroads on the east of Scotland. They went south to Beruvík (Berwick-on-Tweed). There was a man named Knút the wealthy, who was a merchant, and always resided in Beruvík. Swein and Erlend seized a large and fine vessel belonging to Knút. On board was a valuable cargo, and Knút's wife. Then they sailed south to Bl[‘y]hólmar. Knút was at Beruvík when he

heard of the plunder. He induced the Beruvík men for a hundred marks of silver to try to recover the goods. Of those who went in pursuit most were merchants. They went in fourteen ships to search for them. When Earl Erlend and Swein were lying under Bl[‘y]hólmar, Swein said in the night that they should sleep without awnings, saying that he expected that the Beruvík men might come upon them during the night in great numbers. A gale was blowing, and no heed was paid to Swein’s words, and they slept under the awnings, except in Swein’s ship, where there was no awning abaft the mast. Swein was sitting on a chest in a fur coat, saying that he wished to be ready during the night.

92.3

One of Swein’s crew was called Einar Skeif. He said that Swein’s bravery was much talked of, that he was called a bolder man than others, but now he dared not have awnings on board his ship. Watchmen were on shore in the island. Swein, hearing that they did not agree about what they saw, went up to them and asked what they were disputing about? They said they were not sure what it was that they saw. Swein had keener sight than any of his men, and when he looked he saw fourteen ships approaching them from the north. Then he went on board his ship again, and told his men to wake up and take down the awnings, and then a great outcry arose, every one asking Swein what they should do. He told them to be silent, and said that his advice was to moor the ships between the island and the mainland, adding: “We shall see whether they do not pass by us, and if they do we shall part; but if they attack us, we shall row against them as vigorously as possible, and let us make a stout resistance if we meet.”

92.4

Others spoke against this plan, saying the only way was to sail from them, and so they did.

92.5

Swein said: “If you wish to sail away, then stand out to sea.” Swein was not so soon ready as the others, but Anakol waited for him. Swein’s ship was, however, a swifter sailer, and he took in sail and waited for

Anakol, not wishing him to be left behind in a single ship. When they stood off, with all sail set, Einar Skeif said: “Swein, does our ship stand still?”

92.6

Swein replied: “I do not think so; but I advise you not to question my courage any more, since through your fright you cannot tell whether the ship moves or stands still, yet it is one of the swiftest sailers.”

92.7

They put in under Mosey, and Swein sent men to Eidinaborg to tell the King of Scots of his plunder; but before they came to the town they met twelve men on horseback who had saddle-bags filled with silver, and when they met they inquired after Swein, Asleif’s son. The others told where he was, and asked what they wanted with him. The Scots said they had been told that Swein was taken prisoner, and the King of Scots had sent them to ransom him. Thus they told their errand.

92.8

The King did not make much of Knút’s loss, but sent a costly shield to Swein, and other presents besides.

92.9

Earl Erlend and Swein arrived rather late in the Orkneys in the autumn. This summer Earl Harald went east to Norway. At the same time, Earl Rögnvald and Erling Skakki came to Norway from Mikligard, and he arrived at his dominions in the Orkneys shortly before Yule.

## Chapter 93 · PEACE BETWEEN EARL RÖGNVALD AND EARL ERLEND

93.1

THEN THERE WENT men immediately between Earl Erlend and Earl Rögnvald, and tried to make peace between them, the Boendr pleading the agreement they had come to with Earl Erlend, that he should not prevent Earl Rögnvald from taking possession of his part of the Islands. A conference took place between the Earls at Kirkiuvag (Kirkwall), and at that conference they confirmed their peace with oaths. It was two

nights before Yule when they made peace, and the terms were, that they should each have one-half of the Islands, and both should defend them against Earl Harald or any other if he claimed them. Earl Rögnvald had no ships till his own came from the east in the summer. This winter all was quiet, but in the spring the Earls prepared their plans in case Earl Harald should come from the east. Earl Erlend went to Hjaltland to intercept him if he should come there. Earl Rögnvald went over to Thórsá, because Earl Harald was expected to go there if he came from the east, as he had there many friends and kinsmen. Earl Erlend and Swein were in Hjaltland during the summer, and kept back all ships, so that none went to Norway.

## 93.2

In summer Earl Harald left Norway with seven ships, and landed in the Orkneys. Three of the ships, however, were driven by stress of weather to Hjaltland, and these were seized by Swein and Earl Erlend. When Earl Harald came to the Orkneys he heard of the agreement of Earl Rögnvald and Earl Erlend, that each of them should have one-half of the Islands; and then he saw that no territory was intended for him. He resolved to go over to Ness (Caithness) to Earl Rögnvald before Earl Erlend and Swein came from the east. They were in Hjaltland, when they heard that Earl Harald had arrived in the Orkneys with five long-ships, and prepared to go thither immediately. In Dynröst they had strong currents and severe gales, and there they parted. Swein was driven back to Fridarey (Fair Isle), with twelve ships, and they thought the Earl had perished. From Fridarey they went to Sandey, where they found Earl Erlend with three ships. It was a joyful meeting for them. Then they went to Hrossey (Mainland), and inquired about Earl Harald's movements.

## Chapter 94 · PEACE IS TALKED OF

## 94.1

NOW IT IS to be told that Earl Harald came to Thórsá with six ships. Earl Rögnvald was in Sutherland, at the wedding of his daughter

Ingirid, whom he married to Eirík Slagbrellir. He heard immediately that Earl Harald had arrived at Thórsá, and rode from Beruvík to Thórsá, attended by many men. Eirík was related to Earl Harald; and with many others he tried to make peace between them, saying that it was absurd for them to be at enmity, because of their relationship, their up-bringing, and their long alliance. At last matters came so far that a meeting was appointed, and truce made. They should meet in a certain castle at Thórsá, and talk together alone; but an equal number of their men should be outside the castle. They talked a long time, and agreed very well. They had not seen each other since Rögnvald returned. Late in the day information was given to Earl Rögnvald that Earl Harald's men were coming there armed. Earl Harald said that no harm would be done. Then they heard heavy blows outside, and ran out. Thorbiörn Klerk had arrived there with a large party, and attacked Rögnvald's men immediately. The Earls called to them that they should not fight. Then the inhabitants of the town came running to the spot to separate them. Thirteen of Earl Rögnvald's men were killed, and he himself was wounded in the face.

## Chapter 95 · SWEIN'S PLANS

### 95.1

AFTER THIS THEIR friends made an effort to establish peace between them, and the result was that they made peace, which they confirmed by oaths. They renewed their alliance, pledging their faith and shaking hands; and it was resolved that they should go that very night out to the Orkneys to attack Earl Erlend. They went out on the Pentland Firth with ten ships, taking the course to Rínarsey. They landed in Vidivag, and went on shore. Erlend and his men lay on board their ships in Bardvik, and from there they saw a crowd on Rögnvaldsey, and sent out spies. When they heard of the reconciliation of the Earls, it was also said that Earl Erlend would not be permitted to plunder on shore, or to obtain provisions in any other way; and their intention was to prevent them from getting any food in the island. Earl Erlend

held a meeting and consulted his men, and they agreed to leave it to Swein to say what should be done. Swein replied that they should sail that very night over to Caithness, saying that they had no strength to contend with both the Earls there in the Islands. He gave out that they intended to go to the Sudreyar (Hebrides), and winter there.

## 95.2

It was Michaelmas-eve when they sailed out on the Firth, but when they came over to Ness (Caithness), they ran up into the country, and drove down a great number of cattle, which they brought on board their ships. There were strong currents and bad weather, so that the Firth was frequently impassable; but when favourable weather came, Swein sent a man in a boat from Ness, to give information that Earl Erlend had made a great strand-hewing in Caithness, and was ready to sail to the Sudreyar when there was a favourable wind. When this came to the ears of Earl Rögnvald, he called his men together and made a speech to them, telling them to be on their guard, to be wary, and sleep every night on board their ships; "For now," he said, "Swein may be expected every hour in the Islands; the more certainly the more he talks of going away."

## 95.3

Early in the winter Earl Erlend and Swein left Thórsá, and took their course by the west of Scotland. They had six large long-ships, all well manned. They had to row, and when they had gone some distance from Caithness, Earl Rögnvald's spies went out to the Islands, and told him the news. Then the Earls moved their ships to Skálpeid (Scapa), and Earl Rögnvald wished them to stay a while on board.

## 95.4

When Swein and Erlend came west off Staur, the former said that they should not distress themselves by rowing any farther, and asked his men to put the ships about and set the sails. This action on the part of Swein was thought foolish, yet his men did as he desired them. When they had been sailing for a while the ships began to speed, because there was a fine breeze, and nothing is said of their voyage until they

came to Vagaland, in Orkney. There they heard that the Earls were lying at Skálpeid, off Knarrarstadir, with thirteen ships. There were Erlend Ungi, Eirík Slagbrellir, and many other men of note. Thorbiörn Klerk had gone out to Papuley, to Hákon Karl, his brother-in-law. It was four nights before Simon's-mas when Swein, Asleif's son, decided to attack the Earls during the night, but it was thought rather hazardous, as their followers were so much more numerous. Yet Swein insisted on having his own way; and so he did, because the Earl wished to follow his advice.

## Chapter 96 · BATTLE BETWEEN THE THREE EARLS

### 96.1

DURING THE NIGHT there fell a shower of sleet, and Earl Rögnvald left his ship with six men, intending to go to his residence at Jórfiara (Orphir), because he expected no danger. During the shower they came to Knarrarstadir. An Icelander, by name Bótólf Begla, an excellent skald, lived there. He pressed Earl Rögnvald with many invitations to stay there during the night. Earl Rögnvald and his men entered the house; their clothes were pulled off them, and they went to sleep; but Bótólf was to keep watch. This same night Earl Erlend and Swein attacked Earl Harald and his men, and took them by surprise, and they knew of nothing till they heard the battle-cry. They flew to arms, and defended themselves bravely. Many were killed, and the attack ended in this way — that Earl Harald leaped on shore when there were only five men left in his ship. Bjarni, brother of Erlend Ungi, a noble man, fell there, and a hundred men with him; and a great number were wounded. All the Earl's men jumped from the ships to reach the shore, and fled. Few of Earl Erlend's men were killed, and they took fourteen ships belonging to the Earls, with all the valuables they contained. When the most part of their work was done, they heard that Earl Rögnvald had left his ship the evening before, and walked first to Knarrarstadir, and thither they went. Bondi Bótólf was outside the door when they came, and greeted them well. They asked whether Earl

Rögnvald was there. Bótólf said he had been there during the night. They became very violent, and demanded where the Earl was then, saying that he no doubt knew where he was. He pointed with his hand behind the farm-yard, and sang:

96.2

This way went the Prince a-fowling;  
Skilful are his men with arrows.

96.3

Now is many a heathcock meeting  
Death beside the verdant hillocks,  
Where the elmbow of the hunter,  
Keenly bent, as if by magic,  
Makes the moorfowl quickly perish.

96.4

The Prince's sword the land defendeth.

96.5

The Earl's men ran away from the homestead, and he who could run fastest considered himself luckiest, as he would be the first to catch Earl Rögnvald. Bótólf went into the house, awoke the Earl, and told him what had happened during the night, and also what the Earl's men were doing. Rögnvald and his men started up instantly, and put on their clothes; then they went away to the Earl's residence at Jórfiara; and when they came there they found Earl Harald in hiding. The Earls [Harald and Rögnvald] went immediately over to Ness each in a separate boat; one had two men, the other three. All their men went over to Ness, wherever they could get a boat.

96.6

Earl Erlend and Swein took the ships belonging to the Earl, and a great quantity of other property. Swein took for his share all Earl Rögnvald's treasures that were in his ship, and sent them to him over to Ness. Swein advised Earl Erlend to move his ships out to Vagaland (Walls), and to lie in the Firth, where they could see ships coming from Ness, as he thought it would be convenient to run out upon them if there was

opportunity. But Earl Erlend yielded to the persuasions of his men that they should go north to Daminsey (Damsey), and in a large castle there they drank all day, but fastened the ships together every night, and slept on board. Thus time passed on till the Yule-feast.

## Chapter 97 · EARL ERLEND'S DEATH

97.1

FIVE NIGHTS BEFORE Christmas, Swein, Asleif's son, went east to Sandvik, to his kinswoman Sigríd, because he had to make peace between her and her neighbour by name Björn. Before he went away he told Earl Erlend to sleep on board by night, and not to be less on his guard that he himself was absent. Swein spent one night with his kinswoman Sigríd. A tenant and dear friend of Sigríd's, by name Gisl, asked Swein to stay with him, as he had been brewing ale, and wished to entertain him. When they came to Gisl they were told that Earl Erlend had not gone on board that night; and as soon as Swein heard it, he sent Margad, Grim's son, and two other men to the Earl, and asked him to pay heed to his advice, although he had not done so the preceding night, and then he added: "I suspect that I shall not have long to provide for this Earl."

97.2

Margad and his companions found Earl Erlend, and told him Swein's words. The Earl's men said: "He is a strange man; sometimes he is afraid of nothing, at other times he is so frightened that he does not know where to look for shelter to himself or others." They said they would sleep quietly on shore, and not go on board. The Earl said they should do as Swein advised them, and he went on board with four-and-twenty men; the others slept at a house. Margad went to another creek, not far away. This very night the Earls Rögnvald and Harald surprised Earl Erlend, and neither the watchmen who kept guard on the island nor those on board the ship perceived them until they were climbing on board. A man named Orm and another Ufi were in the forepart of the Earl's ship. Ufi jumped up and tried to rouse the Earl, but could not, for

he was dead-drunk. Then he took him in his arms, and jumped overboard with him into a boat alongside the ship, and Orm jumped overboard on the other side, and escaped on shore. There Earl Erlend was slain, and most of those on board. Margad and his men were awakened during the night by the battle-cry, and took to their oars, and rowed round the headland. It was clear moonlight, and they saw when the Earls went away; and they felt sure that fate had decided between them. They rowed away first to Rennadal (Rendale), and sent men to Swein, Asleif's son, to tell him what they had seen. Earl Harald wished to give Earl Erlend's men peace, but Earl Rögnvald wished to wait, in order to know whether the Earl's body would be found or not. The body was found two nights before Yule. A spear was seen standing in a heap of seaweed; and that spear was fast in Earl Erlend's body. Then it was brought to church, and peace was given to the Earl's men, as well as to four of Swein's men who had been taken.

## 97.3

A man named Jón Voeng was a sister's son of that Jón Voeng who was mentioned before. He had been with Hákon Karl, and had a child by his sister; then he ran away, and was with Anakol on piratical expeditions; but now he was with Erlend, yet he was not in the battle. All Erlend's men went to Kirkiuvag, and took refuge in St. Magnus's church. The Earls went there, and a meeting for peace-making was held in the church. The Earls would not pardon Jón until he promised to marry the woman. All the men swore oaths of fealty to the Earls, and Jón Voeng became Earl Harald's steward.

## Chapter 98 · SWEIN SLAYS ERLEND

## 98.1

AFTER EARL ERLEND'S death Swein, Asleif's son, went to Rennadal (Rendale), and there he saw Margad, who was able to give him all the tidings of what happened in Daminsey. Then Swein went to Hrólfsøy (Rousay), and arrived there at high-water. He and his men brought all the tackle of the ships on shore, and placed it in safety. They divided

themselves among the farms, and kept watch on the movements of the Earls and other chiefs. Swein, Asleif's son, mounted the hill with five men, and went down to the sea on the other side; they hid themselves at the homestead in the darkness, and heard a great talking. There were Thorfinn, his son Ogmund, and their brother-in-law Erlend. He boasted of having given Earl Erlend the death-blow, and all of them were declaring they had done right well. When Swein heard this, he and his companions went in upon them. Swein was quickest, and immediately dealt Erlend a death-blow. They took Thorfinn prisoner, and brought him away; but Ogmund was wounded. Swein went to Thingavöll, to his father's brother Helgi; and there they spent the first days of Yule in hiding. Earl Rögnvald went to Daminsey, but Earl Harald was at Kirkiuvag during Yule-tide. Earl Rögnvald sent men to Thingavöll, to Helgi, and asked him to tell his kinsman Swein, if he knew anything of his whereabouts, that Earl Rögnvald invited him to spend the Yule with him, and he would try to make peace between him and Earl Harald. When Swein received this message, he went to Earl Rögnvald, and remained with him during the rest of the Yule-tide, and was well treated.

## Chapter 99 · OF EARL HARALD AND SWEIN, ASLEIF'S SON

### 99.1

AFTER CHRISTMAS A meeting was appointed to make peace between the Earls and Swein, when they should finally settle all matters about which reconciliation had been made. When they met, Earl Rögnvald took great pains to make peace between them. Others, however, who were not Swein's friends or kinsmen, spoke against him, saying that he would always be causing disturbances if he were not expelled from the Islands. At last, however, they agreed upon this — that Swein should pay a mark of gold to each of the Earls, and should keep one-half of his estates and a good long-ship.

### 99.2

When Swein heard the award, he replied: “Our agreement will be good only in case I am not oppressed.”

99.3

Earl Rögnvald would not accept the payment from Swein, saying that he would in no way oppress him, as he considered his faithfulness and friendship worth more than money.

99.4

After the peace-meeting, Earl Harald went to Gáreksey, and used Swein’s corn and other property rather wastefully. When Swein heard this he complained of his loss to Earl Rögnvald, and said, that “this was a breach of their agreement, and that he would go home to look after his property.”

99.5

Earl Rögnvald said: “Stay with me, Swein: I shall send a message to Earl Harald, for he will be more than a match for you to deal with, strong and brave as you are.”

99.6

Swein was not to be dissuaded, and went with ten men in a boat to Gáreksey, and arrived there late in the evening. They went behind the houses, and Swein wished to set fire to the hall, and burn down the homestead, and the Earl within it. A man named Swein, Blákári’s son, the most notable of Swein’s companions, dissuaded him from doing so, saying that the Earl was not perhaps in the homestead; and if he was there, he would neither permit Swein’s wife nor his daughter to go out, and it was never to be thought of to burn them. Then they went up to the door, and into the entry. Those who were inside the hall jumped up and closed the door, and then Swein and his men became aware that the Earl was not in the house. Those who were within soon ceased resisting, surrendered their weapons to Swein, and went out unarmed. Swein gave quarter to all Earl Harald’s men. He poured out all his beer, and took away his wife and daughter. He asked his wife Ingirid where Earl Harald was, but she would not tell him. He then said: “Say nothing then, but point to where he is.” She would not do

that either, because she was related to the Earl. Swein gave up some of the arms, when they came on board the ships. But the effect of this was that their agreement of peace was at an end.

99,7

Earl Harald had gone out to a certain island to hunt hares. Swein went to Hellisey. It rises abruptly from the sea, and there is a large cave in the cliffs, the mouth of which is flooded at high-water. When the Earl's men got their weapons from Swein, they went to Earl Harald and informed him of these doings of Swein's. The Earl had his ship set afloat, and ordered his men to row after him. He said: "This time our meeting with Swein shall be decisive." Then they rowed in pursuit of him, and soon they saw and recognised each other.

99,8

When Swein saw that they gained on him, he said: "We must devise some scheme, because I do not care to meet the Earl with so great odds against me as I suspect there are. Let us go to the cave and see how we fare."

99,9

When Swein came to the cave it was ebb tide. They hauled up the boat into the cave, which ran into the cliff, and the water rose before the mouth of the cave. During the day Earl Harald and his men searched for Swein throughout the island, and did not find him, neither did they see any boat leave the island. They wondered very much at this, as they thought it unlikely that Swein's boat had gone down. They rowed round the island in search of the boat, but did not find it. Then they concluded that he must have gone to some of the other islands, and they went where they thought it most likely. It so happened that, when the Earl rowed away, the tide was back from the mouth of the cave. Swein had overheard the talk between the Earl and his men. He left his own boat in the cave, and took a small boat which the monks had, and went to Sandey. There they landed, and pushed off the small boat, which drifted about till it was wrecked. They came to a homestead called Völuness, where a man lived by name Bárð, who was

Swein's kinsman. They made themselves known to him secretly, and Swein said he wished to stay there. Bárd said he might do as he liked, but that he dared not keep him here unless in hiding. They went in, and sat by themselves in a part of the house separated from the other inmates by a partition-wall. There was a secret door to it, filled up with loose stones. That evening Jón Voeng, Earl Harald's steward, arrived there with six men, and Bárd received them well. Large fires were made, at which they warmed themselves. Jón was excited, and spoke of the dealings of Swein and the Earls. He blamed Swein very much, said he was a truce-breaker, and faithful to no one. He had lately made peace with Earl Harald, and yet he went to attack him and burn him in the house, adding that there would never be peace in the land till Swein was banished from it. Bárd and Jón's companions put in some words in Swein's defence. Then Jón began to blame Earl Erlend, saying there was no loss in his death, as he was a violent man, and nobody could live in safety for him. When Swein heard this, he could not restrain himself, but seized his weapons, and ran to the secret door. He pushed the stones down, thus making a great noise. Swein's design was to leap before the hall-door. Jón was sitting in his shirt and linen breeches, and when he heard Swein coming he tied on his shoes and sprang out from the fire and away from the house. The night was pitch dark, and it was hard frost. During the night he came to another farm. His feet were very much frost-bitten, and some of his toes fell off. Through the intercession of Bárd, Swein gave peace to Jón's companions. He remained there during the night, but in the morning he and his men went away in a boat belonging to Bárd, which he gave to him. They went south to Bardsvík, and stayed in a certain cave. Sometimes Swein took his meals at a house during the day, but slept during the night down by his boat, and thus he guarded himself against his enemies.

## Chapter 100 · OF ROGNVALD AND SWEIN

ONE MORNING EARLY Swein and his men saw a large long-ship coming from Hrólfsøy (Hrossey?) to Rögnvaldsey, and Swein recognised it immediately as Earl Rögnvald's ship, which he used to command himself. They put in at Rögnvaldsey, where Swein's boat was lying, and five of them went on shore. Swein and his men were on a certain headland, and threw stones at the Earl's men. When those on board saw this, they drew forth their arms; and when that was seen by Swein, they ran down to the beach, and pushed their boat afloat, and jumped into it. The long-ship stuck fast on the beach. When they rowed past it, Swein was standing up with a spear in his hand. When Earl Rögnvald perceived it, he took a shield and held it before him, but Swein did not throw the spear. When the Earl saw that they would get away from them, he ordered a truce-shield to be held aloft, and asked Swein to go on shore. When Swein saw this, he told his men to put to land, saying that it was his greatest satisfaction to be at peace with Earl Rögnvald.

## Chapter 101 · OF EARL HARALD AND SWEIN

### 101.1

THEN EARL RÖGNVALD and Swein went on shore, and had a long conversation by themselves, and agreed very well. While they were talking, they saw Earl Harald sailing from Caithness to Vagaland (Walls), and when the ship approached the island, Swein asked what was to be done. The Earl said Swein should go over to Ness immediately. This was during Lent. They left Rögnvaldsey at the same time. The Earl went to Hrossey, but Swein went west to Straumsey (Stroma). Earl Harald saw the boat, and thought he recognised it as Swein's, and went immediately into the Firth in pursuit. When Swein saw the pursuit, they left the boat, and hid themselves. When Earl Harald came to Straumsey (Stroma) he saw the boat, and suspected that the men were somewhere near, and would not therefore go on shore. A man named Amundi, the son of Hnefi, who was Earl Harald's friend, and father's brother to Swein, Asleif's son's stepchildren, went

between them, and succeeded so far that they agreed to keep the agreement of peace which they had made the previous winter. A gale arose, and they were both obliged to remain there during the night, and Amundi put Earl Harald and Swein in the same bed, and many of their men slept in the same house.

## 101.2

After this Swein went over to Ness (Caithness), and Earl Harald to the Orkneys. Swein heard that the Earl had said that their agreement to be at peace had been rather loose. He paid little heed to this, however, and went south to Dalir, and spent the Easter there with his friend Sumarlidi; but Earl Harald went north to Hjaltland, and was there a long time during the spring.

## 101.3

After Easter Swein went from the south, and met on his way two of Jón Væng's brothers — one was called Bunu-Pétr, the other Blán. Swein and his men seized them, and took from them all their goods, and brought them to land. A gallows was erected for them, and when everything was ready Swein said they should be allowed to run up the country, adding that they were greater shame to their brother Jón alive than dead. They were a long time out on the hills, and when they came to some habitations they were very much frost-bitten.

## 101.4

From thence Swein went to Liódhús, in the Sudreyar, and stayed there some time. When Jón Væng heard that Swein had taken his brothers prisoners, and not knowing what he had done with them, he went to Eyin Helga (Enhallow), and took Olaf, the son of Swein, Asleif's son, and Kolbein Hruga's foster-son, and brought him to Westrey. They met Earl Rögnvald at Hreppisnes, and when he saw Olaf, he said: "Why are you here, Olaf?"

## 101.5

He said: "It is the work of Jón Væng."

## 101.6

The Earl looked to Jón, and said: "Why did you bring Olaf here?"

101.7

He replied: "Swein took my brothers, and I don't know but he may have killed them."

101.8

The Earl said: "Take him back again as quickly as you can, and do not dare to do him any harm, whatever may have become of your brothers, for if you do, you will not be safe in the Islands from either Swein or Kolbein."

## Chapter 102 · OF EARL RÖGNVALD

102.1

AFTER EASTER SWEIN commenced a journey to the Sudreyar, taking with him sixty men. He went to the Orkneys, and landed first in Hrólfsøy (Rousay). There they took a man, by name Hákon Karl, who had been with Earl Harald when Earl Erlend was slain. Hákon ransomed himself with three marks of gold, and thus saved himself from Swein. In Hrólfsøy Swein found the ship which the Earls had taken from him, and two of the planks were cut, which had been done by Earl Rögnvald's order, because Swein had refused to buy it or to accept it as a gift from the Earls. Swein went from there to Hrossey, and met Earl Rögnvald at Birgishérad (Birsay). The Earl received him well, and Swein spent the spring with him. Earl Rögnvald said that he had ordered the planks of the ship to be cut, because he did not wish him to row about rashly among the Islands when he came from the Sudreyar. Earl Harald came from Hjaltland in the spring during the Whitsuntide, and when he came to the Orkneys Earl Rögnvald sent men to him to say that he wished the compact of peace between him and Swein to be renewed, and a peace meeting was appointed in St. Magnus's church on Friday during the holy week. Earl Rögnvald carried a broad axe to the meeting, and Swein went with him. Then the peace compact which had been made in the winter was confirmed.

## Chapter 103 · OF SWEIN, ASLEIF'S SON

103.1

THEN EARL RÖGNVALD gave Earl Harald the ship which had belonged to Swein, but all other things which had been awarded him from Swein he returned to him. Earl Rögnvald and Swein were standing at the church-door while the sail, which had been lying in St. Magnus's church, was carried out, and Swein looked rather gloomy. The following Saturday, after noontide service, Earl Harald's men came to Swein, Asleif's son, and said the Earl wished him to come to speak with him. Swein consulted Earl Rögnvald, but he did not say much in favour of his going, and added that one did not know whom to trust. Swein went, nevertheless, with five men. The Earl was sitting on a cross bench in a small room, and Thorbiörn Klerk beside him. A few other men were with the Earl, and they sat for a while and drank. Then Thorbiörn left the room, and Swein's companions said to him that they distrusted the Earl's conduct very much. Thorbiörn returned shortly after, and presented Swein with a scarlet tunic and a cloak, saying that he did not know whether he would call it a gift, because these things had been taken from Swein in the winter. Swein accepted the gifts. Earl Harald restored to him the long-ship which had belonged to him, and the half of his property and estates. He asked him to stay with him, and said their friendship should never be dissolved. Swein accepted all this gladly, and went immediately the same night and told Earl Rögnvald how matters had turned out between him and Earl Harald. Earl Rögnvald said he was much pleased with this, and told Swein to take care that they did not become enemies again.

## Chapter 104 · OF THE EARLS

104.1

A SHORT TIME after, the three chiefs — Swein, Thorbiörn, and Eirik — went out on a plundering expedition. They went first to the Sudreyar, and all along the west to the Syllingar, where they gained a great

victory in Maríuhöfn on Columba's-mas (9th June), and took much booty. Then they returned to the Orkneys.

## 104.2

When the Earls Harald and Rögnvald had made peace with Swein, Asleif's son, they were always together, and Earl Rögnvald governed, but they agreed very well. When they came home from the Syllingar, Thorbiörn Klerk went to Earl Harald, and became his counsellor. Swein went home to Gáreksey, and resided there during the winter with many men, living upon his booty, and other stores which he possessed there in the Islands. He was most attached to Earl Rögnvald. Every summer he was out on marauding expeditions. It was said that Thorbiörn did not improve the harmony between Earl Harald and Earl Rögnvald.

## 104.3

Thórarinn Killinef was one of Earl Rögnvald's men, a great friend of his, and was always with the Earl. A man named Thorkel was one of Thorbiörn Klerk's followers, and a friend of his. Thórarinn and Thorkel quarrelled over their drink at Kirkiuvag, and Thorkel wounded Thórarinn, and then escaped to Thorbiörn. Thórarinn's companions pursued Thorkel, but Thorbiörn and his men defended themselves in a loft. The Earls were informed of this, and they went to part them. Thorbiörn refused to leave the decision of this case to Earl Rögnvald, as it was his men that were concerned in the pursuit. When Thórarinn had recovered from his wounds, he slew Thorkel as he was going to church. He ran into the church, but Thorbiörn and his men pursued him. Earl Rögnvald was told what was happening, and he went there with his men, and asked Thorbiörn whether he was going to break the church open. Thorbiörn said the church ought not to shelter him who was within. Earl Rögnvald said there should be no violation of the church at this time, and Thorbiörn was pushed away from it. No agreement was come to about this case.

## 104.4

Thorbiörn went over to Caithness, and was there for a while. Then many things happened to estrange them, for Thorbiörn was often guilty of violence to women, and of manslaying. He went secretly out to the Orkneys in a boat with thirty men, and landed at Skálpeid, and walked to Kirkiuvag with three men. In the evening he went alone into an inn where Thórarinn was drinking, and struck him a death-blow immediately. Then he ran out into the darkness and far away. For this the Earl made him an outlaw in every part of his dominions. Thorbiörn went over to Ness, and remained in hiding with his brother-in-law, Hösvir, who was called the strong. He had married Thorbiörn's sister, Ragnhild, and their son was Stefán Rádgjafi (counsellor), Thorbiörn's follower. Shortly afterwards Thorbiörn went to Malcolm, King of Scots, and remained there a while, in high favour with the King. There was a man called Gillaodran with the King of Scots. He was of a great family, but a violent man. He had incurred the displeasure of the King of Scots for violent acts and manslaughters which he had committed in his kingdom. He fled to the Orkneys, and the Earls received him. Then he went to Caithness, and acted as a steward for the Earls. There was a noble Bondi in Caithness, by name Helgi, a friend of Earl Rögnvald's. Gillaodran quarrelled with him about the stewardship, and Gillaodran attacked and killed him. After the slaughter he went west to Scotland's Fiord, and was received by a chief named Sumarlidi Höld, who had possessions in Dalir, on Scotland's Fiord. His wife was Ragnhild, the daughter of Olaf Bitling (little bit), King of the Sudreyar. Their sons were King Dufgall, Rögnvald, and Engull. They were called the Dalverja family.

## 104.5

Earl Rögnvald sent for Swein, Asleif's son, before he went out on his expedition. When they met, Earl Rögnvald asked him to have an eye on Gillaodran if he had an opportunity. Swein said he did not know how far he might succeed.

## Chapter 105 · SWEIN SLAYS SUMARLIDI

105.1

THEN SWEIN WENT on a marauding expedition, having five long-ships. When he came west to Scotland's Fiord, he heard that Sumarlidi Höld had gone on board a ship, and was about to set out on an expedition. He had seven ships, and Gillaodran commanded one. He had gone into the firths to bring up some troops that had not arrived. When Swein heard of Sumarlidi, he gave him battle, and it was a fierce fight. Sumarlidi Höld was killed in that fight, and many men with him. When Swein became aware that Gillaodran was not there, he went in search of him, and slew him in Myrkvifjörð, and fifty men with him. Then he went on his expedition, and returned home in the autumn, as his custom was. He went to see Earl Rögnvald soon after his return, and he was much pleased with these deeds.

## Chapter 106 · OF EARL RÖGNVALD AND EARL HARALD

106.1

EVERY SUMMER THE Earls were wont to go over to Caithness, and up into the forests to hunt the red-deer or the reindeer. Thorbiörn Klerk was with the King of Scots, and sometimes he went to Caithness and stayed in hiding with his friends. He had three friends in Caithness whom he trusted most. One was his brother-in-law, Hösvir; the second, Liótólf, who lived in Thórsdal; and the third was Hallvard, Dúfa's son, in Kálfadal (Calder), at a certain promontory off Thórsdal. All these were his intimate friends.

## Chapter 107 · THE SLAYING OF EARL RÖGNVALD

107.1

WHEN EARL RÖGNVALD had been an Earl two-and-twenty winters from the time that Earl Paul was taken prisoner, the Earls went over to Caithness during the latter part of the summer as usual, and when they came to Thórsá they heard a rumour to the effect that Thorbiörn was there in hiding with not a few men, and that he intended to attack

them if he had an opportunity. Then the Earls called men together, and went with a hundred men, twenty of whom were on horseback and the rest on foot. In the evening they went up into the valley, and took up their quarters for the night. When they were sitting by the fire in the evening, Earl Rögnvald sneezed very much. Earl Harald said: “That was a loud sneeze, kinsman.” In the morning they went along the valley.

## 107.2

During the day Earl Rögnvald rode always ahead of his men, and a man with him called Asólf, and another by name Jómar, his kinsman. They rode five together along Kálfadal; and when they came to the farm, farmer Höskuld was on the top of a corn-stack piling up the corn, which his servants brought to him. Earl Harald was some distance behind. When Höskuld recognised Earl Rögnvald, he saluted him by name, and asked for news, speaking very loud, so that he could be heard far away. This was a short distance from the sitting-room of the house. The homestead stood on an eminence, and one had to go through narrow and very steep passages up to it. Thorbiörn was at this farm, and was sitting indoors drinking. The passages led to the end of the house close to the gable, which had a door filled loosely with stones. Thorbiörn and his men, hearing the words of Höskuld when he saluted Earl Rögnvald, seized their weapons, pushed the stones from the concealed door, and ran out. Thorbiörn ran round the gable, and on to the wall of the passage. The Earl was then close to the door. Thorbiörn struck at him, and Asólf warded off the blow with his hand, and it was cut off; and then the sword touched the Earl’s chin, inflicting a great wound.

## 107.3

On receiving the blow Asólf said: “Let them serve the Earl better who have to thank him for greater gifts.” He was then eighteen winters old, and had lately entered the Earl’s service.

## 107.4

Earl Rögnvald was going to jump off his horse, and his foot stuck fast in the stirrup. At that moment Stefán arrived and stabbed him with a

spear; and Thorbiörn wounded him again; but Jómar stabbed Thorbiörn in the thigh, the spear entering the bowels. Then Thorbiörn and his men ran behind the homestead, and down a steep bank, into a wet morass. Then Earl Harald and his men arrived and met Thorbiörn. They recognised each other, and the Earl's men, when they knew his intentions, advised to pursue him; but Earl Harald dissuaded them from it, saying that he wished to wait for Earl Rögnvald's opinion, "Because," said he, "I am very intimately connected with Thorbiörn, as you know, both through relationship and other ties."

## 107.5

Those who were with Earl Rögnvald stood sorrowing over his dead body, and some time passed before Earl Harald heard the news. Thorbiörn and his men had got out on the bog, and across the moss-hag running along it. But through the urgency of the Earl's followers, he and his men ran down to the bog, and they met at the moss-hag — the two parties standing one on either side. Thorbiörn's party defended themselves from the bank, and his followers ran to his assistance from the neighbouring homesteads, until they were fifty in number. They defended themselves bravely, for they had a strong position. The moss-hag was both deep and broad, and the bog was soft; so they could only hurl spears at each other. Thorbiörn told his men to throw none back; and when the Earl's party had exhausted their missiles they spoke to each other, and Thorbiörn called to Earl Harald, saying, "Kinsman! I wish to ask you to give me quarter, and I am willing to leave the decision of this case entirely in your hands. I will reserve nothing which may contribute to your honour. I also think, kinsman, you must remember that there have been quarrels in which you would not have made such a difference between Earl Rögnvald and me that you would have killed me for having done this deed, when he had you under his thumb, and left you no more power than if you had been his page; but I gave you the best gifts, and endeavoured to further your honour in every way I could. The deed which I have committed is indeed a great crime, and weighs heavily upon me, but the whole of his

dominions revert to you. You may also know that Earl Rögnvald intended for me the same fate which he met at my hands. And I suspect, kinsman, that if it had so happened that I were dead, and Earl Rögnvald alive, you would not have quarrelled with him; and yet you wish to take away my life.”

107.6

Thorbiörn urged his case with many fair words, and many pleaded for him, and begged that quarter might be given him. And at last, when so many pleaded, the Earl began to listen to them.

107.7

Then Magnus, the son of Gunni, Hávard's son, a chief and a kinsman of the Earl's, and the noblest born of Earl Harald's followers, took speech as follows:— “We are not able to counsel you, Earl, after these great deeds, but I shall tell you what will be said if quarter is given to Thorbiörn when he has done such a deed, and even dared to say to your face, almost in so many words, that he has done this wickedness in your interest, or for your honour; and it will be an everlasting shame and dishonour to you and to all the Earl's kinsmen if he is not avenged. I think Earl Rögnvald's friends will believe it to be the truth that for a long time you have been planning his death, and that it is your plan which has now been accomplished. Do you think he will acquit you from complicity in his guilt when he has to defend himself; since no one says a word for you when he tells you to your face that he has committed this crime in your interest? And how can you better confirm this suspicion than by now granting him peace? I have resolved, for my part, never to give him quarter, if any doughty men are willing to follow me, whether you like it or not.”

107.8

His brother Thorstein, and Hákon, and Swein, Hróald's son, spoke to the same effect. Then they left the Earl and went along by the moss-hag, trying to find a place where they might cross.

107.9

When Thorbiörn saw Magnus and his followers walking along the moss-hag, he said: “Now, I suppose, they must have disagreed in their counsels; the Earl has wished to give me peace, and Magnus has spoken against it.”

107.10

While they were thus talking, Thorbiörn and his men went farther away from the moss-hag.

107.11

Harald’s party stood on the brink, and when he saw that no quarter would be given, he leapt across in full armour, though it was nine ells broad. His followers leapt after him, but none of them were able to leap so far; and most of them caught the bank and crawled up out of the mud.

107.12

Thorbiörn’s men urged him to advance against Magnus and his men, and decide the matter with them; but he said: “I think the best plan is, that each of you do what he thinks likely to be best, but I shall go to Earl Harald.”

107.13

Most of his men dissuaded him from this, and begged him rather to flee to the woods and save himself. He did not, however, accept that advice. Then his followers left him, and tried to save themselves in various ways, and at last there were eight men only with Thorbiörn. When he saw that Earl Harald had crossed the ditch, he went to him and fell on his knees, saying that he brought his head to him. Many of the Earl’s men asked that peace might be given him; and the Earl said: “Save yourself, Thorbiörn; I have not the heart to kill you.”

107.14

While they were talking, they moved down the valley along Kalfadalsá, and Magnus’s party pursued them. When the Earl saw it, he said: “Save yourself, Thorbiörn, I will not fight for you against my men.” Then Thorbiörn and his men left the Earl’s party, and went to some deserted shielings called Asgrím’s ærgin. Magnus’s party pursued them, and set

the buildings on fire immediately. Thorbiörn and his men defended themselves bravely; and when the buildings began to fall down with the burning, they went out and were attacked by the other party with their weapons, as soon as they could reach them. They were already very much exhausted by the fire, and fell there all nine. When Thorbiörn's wounds were examined, it was found that the intestines protruded through the wound inflicted by Jómar. Earl Harald led his men down the valley, but those who were with Magnus went to Fors (Forss), wrapped up Earl Rögnvald's body, and brought it down to Thórsá.

## Chapter 108 · THE REMOVAL OF EARL RÖGNVALD'S BODY

108.1

EARL RÖGNVALD KALI died five nights after the summer Marymas. Earl Harald brought the body with a splendid following to the Orkneys, and it was buried at the Magnus Kirk; and there it rested until God manifested Rögnvald's merits by many and great miracles. Then Bishop Bjarni had his holy remains exhumed with the permission of the Pope. Where the blood of the Earl fell on the stones when he died, it may be seen to this day as fresh as if it had just come from the wounds.

108.2

Earl Rögnvald's death was much lamented, because he was very popular in the Islands and in many other parts. He had been helpful to many, was liberal with his money, gentle, and a true friend, highly accomplished, and a good scald. He left a daughter, Ingigerd, an only child, who was married to Eirík Slagbrellir. Their children were Harald Ungi, Magnus Mangi, Rögnvald, Ingibiorg, Elín, and Ragnhild.

## Chapter 109 · OF HARALD AND SWEIN

109.1

AFTER EARL RÖGNVALD'S death, Earl Harald took possession of the whole of the Islands, and became their sole ruler. He was a mighty

chief, and a man of large stature and great strength. His wife was Afreka, and their children were — Heinrek, Hákon, Helena, and Margarét. When Hákon was only a few winters old, Swein, Asleif's son, offered to foster him, and when he was able to take his part with other men, Swein took him out on marauding expeditions every summer, and honoured him in everything. Swein used to reside at home in Gáreksey, in winter, keeping there eighty men at his own expense. He had such a large drinking-hall that there was none equal to it anywhere else in the Orkneys. In the spring he was very busy sowing a large breadth of seed, and he usually did a great part of the work himself. When this work was finished, he went every spring on marauding expeditions. He plundered in the Sudreyar and Ireland, and returned home after midsummer. This he called spring-viking. Then he stayed at home till the fields were reaped and the corn brought in. Then he went out again, and did not return until one month of winter had passed. This he called autumn-viking.

## Chapter 110 · SWEIN GOES TO IRELAND

### 110.1

ONCE IT HAPPENED that Swein went out on a spring expedition, taking with him Hákon, the son of Earl Harald. They had five rowing ships, all large. They plundered in the Sudreyar. All the inhabitants were so afraid of him that they hid all their movable property in the ground or in heaps of loose stones. Swein went all the way south to Man, and obtained very little booty. Then they went to Ireland and plundered there, but when they were approaching Dýflin (Dublin) two merchant-ships came from England, laden with English cloth and other merchandise; they were going to Dýflin. Swein made for the vessels, and offered them battle. There was little resistance by the English, and Swein's party took every penny in the vessels, leaving to the Englishmen only what they stood in, and a small quantity of provisions. They sailed away in the vessels, but Swein's party went to the Sudreyar, and divided their booty. They sailed from the west with

great pomp. When they were lying in harbours, they covered their ships with the English cloth, to make a show; and when they sailed to the Orkneys, they sewed the cloth upon their sails, and then it looked as if the sails were made entirely of the fine stuffs. This they named the Skrud-viking.

110.2

Swein went home to his estate in Gáreksey. He had taken a large quantity of wine and English mead from the vessels. When he had been at home a short time he invited Earl Harald, and prepared a splendid feast for him. When Earl Harald was at the feast a great deal was said of Swein's magnificence. The Earl said: "I wish, Swein, you would now leave off your marauding expeditions; it is good now to drive home a whole waggon. You know that your plundering has fed you and your men a long time, but to most men of violence it happens that they perish in their raiding, if they do not leave it off in time."

110.3

Swein looked to the Earl and said, smiling: "This is well said, my Lord; you have spoken like a friend, and it is good to take sound advice from you; but some complain that you are not an over just man yourself."

110.4

The Earl replied: "I must be responsible for my own acts, but I spoke as it occurred to me."

110.5

Swein replied: "Your intention is no doubt good, my Lord; and it shall be so, that I will discontinue my marauding expeditions, for I am getting old, and my strength is wasting away in the wet work and the fighting. I am now going to make an autumn expedition, and I wish it to be not less glorious than the spring one. Then I shall leave off war-going."

110.6

The Earl replied: "It is difficult to know, comrade, which comes first — death or lasting fame."

110.7

Then their conversation ceased. When Earl Harald left the feast honourable gifts were presented to him, and he and Swein parted very good friends.

## Chapter 111 · SWEIN, ASLEIF'S SON'S (LAST) EXPEDITION

### 111.1

SHORTLY AFTER THIS Swein prepared to go on a marauding expedition with seven long-ships, all of them large. Hákon, the son of Earl Harald, went with him. They went first to the Sudreyar, and found there little booty. Then they went to Ireland, and plundered there in many places. They went all the way south to Dýflin (Dublin), and took the inhabitants by surprise, so that they did not know till they were in the town. They took a great deal of plunder, and took captive the rulers of the city, and their negotiations ended in the surrender of the town to Swein, and they promised to pay as much money as he might levy on them. He was to quarter his men on the town, and have the command of it, and the Dýflin men confirmed this arrangement with oaths. Swein and his men went down to their ships in the evening, but in the morning they were to come into the town and receive hostages from the inhabitants.

### 111.2

Now it is to be told what was going on in the town during the night. The rulers of the town had a meeting, and considered the difficulties in which they were placed. They thought it a grievous hardship that they should have to surrender their town to the Orkneymen, especially to him whom they knew to be the most exacting man in the whole West; and they came to the determination to play him false if they could. They resolved to dig large pits inside of the city gates, and in many other places between the houses, where it was intended that Swein's men should come in, and armed men were hidden in the houses close by. They placed such coverings over the pits as were sure to fall in when the weight of the men came upon them. Then they covered all

over with straw, so that the pits could not be seen, and waited till morning.

## Chapter 112 · SWEIN, ASLEIF'S SON'S FALL

### 112.1

NEXT MORNING SWEIN and his men arose and armed themselves, and went to the town; and when they came near the gates the Dýflin men ranged themselves on both sides from the gates along by the pits. Swein and his men, not being on their guard, fell into them. Some of the townsmen ran immediately to the gates, and others to the pits, and attacked Swein's men with weapons. It was difficult for them to defend themselves, and Swein perished there in the pit, with all those who had entered the town. It was said that Swein was the last man who died there, and that he spake these words before his fall: "Know all men, whether I die to-day or not, that I am the holy Earl Rögnvald's henchman, and my confidence is where he is with God." Swein's surviving followers went then to their ships, and put out to sea; and nothing is said of their voyage until they came to the Orkneys. Here is the end of Swein's history; and it has been said that he was the greatest man in the Western lands, either in old times or at the present day, of those who had not a higher title than he had. After his death his sons Olaf and Andrés divided their patrimony. The next summer after his death they raised the end walls of the large drinking-hall which he had in Gáreksey. Andrés, the son of Swein, married Frída, the daughter of Kolbein Hruga, and sister to Bishop Bjarni.

## Chapter 113 · OF EARL HARALD AND HIS SONS

### 113.1

NOW EARL HARALD ruled the Orkneys, and was a great chief. Afterwards he married Hvarflod, the daughter of Earl Malcolm, of Mærhæfi (Moray). Their children were Thorfinn, David, Jón, Gunnhild, Herborga, and Langlíf.

### 113.2

When Bishop William the Second was dead, Bjarni, the son of Kolbein Hruga, was made bishop after him. He was a very great man, and a dear friend of Earl Harald. Bishop Bjarni had a large party of kinsmen in the Islands. The sons of Eirík Slagbrellir were Harald Ungi, Magnus Mangi, and Rögnvald. The brothers went east to Norway to see King Magnus, Erling's son, and he gave Harald the title of Earl, and one half of the Islands, which had belonged to the holy Earl Rögnvald, his mother's father. Earl Harald Ungi went to the west, and with him Sigurd Murt, the son of Ivar Galli. The mother of Ivar, who fell at Akr with Erling Skakki, was the daughter of Hávard, Gunni's son. Sigurd Murt was young, handsome, and a great dandy. Magnus Mangi remained with the King, and fell with him in Sogn.

### 113.3

Harald (Ungi) and his followers came first to Hjaltland. Then they went over to Caithness, and then into Scotland, to William, King of Scots. Earl Harald requested King William to give him the half of Caithness which Earl Rögnvald had held. The King granted him this; and Earl Harald went then down to Caithness, and gathered troops. Then Lífólf Skalli, his brother-in-law, came to him. He had many noble kinsmen there. Lífólf had married Ragnhild, the sister of Earl Harald. He was called Earl Harald Ungi (the younger); but Harald, Maddad's son, the elder. Lífólf had the command of the Earl's troops. They sent men to the Orkneys, to Earl Harald the elder, requesting him to give up one half of the Islands, since the King had given them to Earl Harald Ungi. When the Earl received this message, he refused absolutely to divide his dominions on any condition. Lífólf Skalli was the messenger, and the Earl upbraided him greatly before he left. After this, Earl Harald the elder collected troops, and obtained a great many. Earl Harald Ungi's party were in Caithness, and had some gathering too. When they heard that Harald the elder was collecting troops, they sent Lífólf a second time across the Pentland Firth to gather information about the enemy's forces. He landed east in Rögnvaldsey, and ascended a hill, where he found three of Harald's watchmen. Two of them he killed,

and one of them he took with him for information. Then Lífólf saw the Earl's fleet, which consisted of many ships, most of them large. Then he went down from the hill to his boat, and told his companions what he had ascertained. He said Earl Harald had so large an army that it was quite hopeless for them to fight with him. "I would advise," said Lífólf, "that we should go to-day to Thórsá, and there many troops will come to us at once. If you wish to offer battle to Earl Harald now, it is most imprudent, whatever the result may be."

113.4

Then said Sigurd Murt: "Ill has the Earl's brother-in-law fared across the Pentland Firth if he has left his heart behind him;" adding, further, that their prospects were not bright if all should lose heart when they saw Earl Harald's army.

113.5

Lífólf replied: "It is difficult to see, Sigurd, where each one carries his heart when courage is required; and I believe you men of mark will think it a serious matter to remain behind when I run from Harald Ungi."

113.6

They did not go to Thórsá; but shortly after they saw Earl Harald's fleet coming from Rögnvaldsey, and then they prepared for battle. Earl Harald went on shore, and placed his men in battle array. They far exceeded the others in number. Sigurd Murt and Lífólf arranged the troops of Earl Ungi. The former was dressed in a scarlet tunic, and tucked the skirt under his belt. Some said that the same should be done behind, but he told them not to do it, "for," said he, "I shall not go backwards to-day." Lífólf and Sigurd led one wing each, and when they had arrayed their men the battle began with great fury. Among the troops of Earl Harald the elder there were many hardy, fierce, and well-armed men, the Bishop's kinsmen, and many others of the Earl's champions. When the battle had lasted for a while, Sigurd Murt fell, having borne himself well and bravely. Lífólf behaved the most valiantly of them all. The Caithnessmen say he broke three times

through the ranks of Earl Harald's men, yet he fell in this fight, after having earned great fame. When both were dead — Lífólf and Sigurd Murt — Earl Ungi's men fled. Earl Harald Ungi fell at some turf-pits, and that very night a great light was seen where his blood fell on the ground. People said he was truly a saint, and there is now a church where he fell. He is buried in Ness (Caithness). Innumerable miracles are by God granted through his merits, which testify that he wished to go to Orkney to his kinsmen Earl Magnus and Earl Rögnvald. After the battle Earl Harald subdued the whole of Caithness, and went back triumphant to the Orkneys.

## Chapter 114 · OF THE ORKNEYMEN

### 114.1

WILLIAM, KING OF Scots, heard that Earl Harald (Ungi) had been killed, and also that Earl Harald, Maddad's son, had subdued the whole of Caithness without asking his leave. He became enraged at this, and sent men to the Sudreyar to Rögnvald, Gudröd's son, the King of the Sudreyar. Gudröd's mother was Ingibiorg, daughter of Earl Hákon, Paul's son. King Rögnvald was the greatest warrior then in the western lands. Three winters he had been out in war-ships without coming under a sooty rafter. When this message came to Rögnvald, he collected an army from all the kingdom of the Sudreyar and from Satiri (Kintyre). He had also a large army from Ireland. Then he went north to Caithness, took possession of the whole of the territory, and remained there some time. Earl Harald kept in the Orkneys, and took no heed of the King's movements. Towards winter King Rögnvald prepared to go home to his dominions in the Sudreyar. He left three stewards (sýslumenn) over Caithness. One was Máni, Olaf's son; the second Rafn, the lawman; and the third, Hlífólf Alli. Some time after, King Rögnvald returned to the Sudreyar. Earl Harald sent a man over to Ness (Caithness), saying that he would consider his journey a lucky one if he could kill any of the stewards or all of them. This man was brought across the Pentland Firth, and he went on till he came to

Lawman Rafn. Rafn asked him where he was going, and he had little to say in reply. Rafn said: "I can see in you that Earl Harald has sent you over here for some evil purpose, but I have not the heart to slay you, because you are my kinsman." Thus they parted, and he went away to Hlífólf, and their intercourse ended in Hlífólf's murder. Then he fled to the Orkneys to Earl Harald, and told him what he had done.

## Chapter 115 · HARALD TORTURES THE BISHOP

### 115.1

NOW EARL HARALD prepared to leave the Orkneys, and when he was quite ready he went first to Thórsá, and landed from his ships there. The Bishop was in the borg at Skárabólstað (Scrabster). When the Caithnessmen saw Earl Harald's army, they perceived it was so numerous that they had no chance to withstand them. They were told also that the Earl was in such an evil temper that there was no knowing what he might do. Then the Bishop took speech, and said: "If our dealings turn out well, he will give you peace." They did as the Bishop told them. The Earl's men rushed from the ships up to the borg. The Bishop went to meet the Earl, and saluted him with bland words, but their dealing turned out in this way, that Earl Harald had the Bishop seized, his tongue cut out, and then he caused a knife to be thrust into his eyes, and blinded him. Bishop Jón prayed to the holy virgin Tröllhæna during his torture, and then he went on a certain bank, when they let him go. There was a woman on the bank, and the Bishop asked her to help him. She saw that blood was flowing from his face, and said: "Be silent, my lord, and I shall willingly help you." The Bishop was brought to the resting-place of the holy Tröllhæna, and there he recovered both his speech and sight.

### 115.2

Earl Harald went up to the borg, and it was immediately surrendered to him. He proceeded at once to punish the inhabitants severely, and imposed heavy fines on those whom he considered most guilty of treachery to him; and he made all the Caithnessmen acknowledge him

by oath as their lord, whether they liked it or not. Then he took possession of all the property belonging to the stewards, who had fled to the King of Scots. Then Earl Harald resided in Caithness with many men.

## Chapter 116 · OF THE STEWARDS

### 116.1

NOW IT IS to be told of the stewards (*sýslumenn*) that they went six together to Scotland, and saw the King during Advent. They were able to give particular intelligence of everything that had happened in Caithness during Earl Harald's stay there. The King was highly enraged at hearing the news, but he said he would pay back double to those who had lost their own. The first day they stayed with the King twenty-five ells of cloth and an English mark in ready money was given to each of them. They spent the Yule-tide with the King, and were well treated.

### 116.2

After Yule-tide the King sent word to all the chiefs in his kingdom, and collected a large army throughout the country, and with all these troops he went down to Caithness against Earl Harald. With this great army he pursued his journey till he came to Eysteinsdal, where Caithness and Sutherland meet. The camp of the King of Scots stretched far along the valleys.

### 116.3

Earl Harald was in Caithness when he heard the news, and he drew troops together immediately. It is said he obtained six thousand men, and yet he had no chance to withstand the King of Scots. Then he sent men to him to sue for peace. When this request was brought before the King, he said it was no use asking for peace unless he had every fourth penny that was to be found in all the land of Caithness.

### 116.4

When the Earl received this message, he called together the inhabitants and chiefs, and consulted with them. As, however, they had

no means of resisting, it was agreed that the Caithnessmen should pay one-fourth of all their property to the King of Scots, except those men who had gone to see the King in winter. Earl Harald went out to the Orkneys, and was to have Caithness as he had it before it was given to Earl Harald Ungi by the King of Scots. Thorfinn, the son of Earl Harald, who was a hostage with the King of Scots, was blinded during these hostilities.

## 116.5

When peace had been made, the King returned to Scotland. Earl Harald was now the sole ruler of the Orkneys. In the later part of the days of Earl Harald, his brother-in-law, Olaf, and Jón, Hallkell's son, raised a party in the Orkneys, and went east to Norway against King Sverrir. They made Sigurd, the son of King Magnus, Erling's son, their King. Many men of noble birth in the Orkneys joined this party, and it was very strong. They were for a while called Eyjarskeggjar (Islanders) or Gullbeinir (goldenlegs). They fought with King Sverrir in Flóruvogar, and were beaten. Both Jón and Olaf were killed, as also their King, and most of their men. After this King Sverrir became a great enemy of Earl Harald, laying it to his charge that he was the cause of the party being raised. At last Earl Harald went from the west, and Bishop Bjarni went along with him. The Earl left his case without reservation to the decision of King Sverrir. Then King Sverrir took all Hjaltland from Earl Harald, with its taxes (scat) and dues, as a fine; and the Earls of Orkney have never had it since.

## 116.6

Earl Harald was five winters old when he was made Earl, and for twenty winters he and Earl Rögnvald were together Earls of Orkney. After Earl Rögnvald's death, he was forty-eight winters Earl of Orkney, and he died in the second year of the reign of King Ingi, Bard's son. Earl Harald's sons, Jón and David, succeeded him; and Heinrek, his son, had Ross in Scotland.

## 116.7

The following have been the most powerful of the Earls of Orkney, according to the relation of those who have made histories of them: — Sigurd, Eystein's son; Earl Thorfinn, Sigurd's son; and Earl Harald, Maddad's son.

116.8

The brothers Jón and David ruled the land after their father, until David died from disease, the same year as Hákon Galinn died in Norway. After that Jón took the title of Earl of all the Orkneys.

## Chapter 117 · THE BURNING OF BISHOP ADAM

117.1

WHEN BISHOP JÓN, he who was maimed by the order of Earl Harald, died in Caithness, a man who was called Adam was made Bishop in his stead. None knew his family, because when a child he was found at the door of a certain church. The Caithnessmen found him rather exacting in his office, and blamed a certain monk who was with him chiefly for that. It was an ancient custom that the Bishop should receive a spann of butter of every twenty cows. Every Bondi in Caithness had to pay this — he more who had more cows, and he who had fewer less, and so in proportion. Bishop Adam wished to increase the impost, and demanded a spann of every fifteen cows; and when that was obtained, he demanded it of twelve; and when this too was conceded, he demanded it of ten. But this was thought by all men most unreasonable.

117.2

Then the Caithnessmen went to see Earl Jón, who was then in Caithness, and they complained of this before the Earl. He said he would have nothing to do with it, adding that the case was not a difficult one. There were two alternatives: this was not to be endured, yet he would not say what the other might be.

117.3

Bishop Adam was at Há Kirkia, in Thorsdal, and Earl Jón was a short distance off. The Caithnessmen held a meeting on a hill above the

village where the Bishop was. Lawman Rafn was with the Bishop, and begged him to spare the inhabitants, saying that otherwise he feared the consequences. The Bishop asked him to be of good cheer, saying that the Bœndr (farmers) would become quiet of their own accord. Then a man was sent to Earl Jón, requesting him to make peace between them and the Bishop. But the Earl would not meddle with the matter at all. Then the Bœndr ran down from the hill in great excitement, and when Lawman Rafn saw it he warned the Bishop to take care of himself. The Bishop and his friends were drinking in a loft there, and when the Bœndr arrived the monk went to the door, and he was immediately hewn across the face, and fell back into the room dead. When the Bishop heard it, he said: "This did not happen sooner than might have been expected, for his interference in our transactions has generally been unfortunate." Then Rafn asked the Bishop to tell the Bœndr that he was willing to come to an agreement with them; and when they heard it, all the wiser men among them were very glad. Then the Bishop went out to make an arrangement with them; but when he was seen by the more wicked ones, who were most furious, they seized the Bishop, brought him into a small house, and set fire to it, and the house burnt so quickly that those who wished to save the Bishop could not do anything. Bishop Adam perished there. His body was not much burnt when it was found. Then the body was buried suitably and honourably; but those who had been the best friends of the Bishop sent men to the King of Scots. Alexander, son of the holy King William, was then King of Scotland. When he heard the tidings, he became so enraged that the punishments inflicted by him for the burning of the Bishop, by mutilation and death, confiscation and outlawry from the land, are still in fresh memory.

#### 117.4

And now we cannot relate more distinctly than we have here done the events concerning the Earls of Orkney.

## APPENDIX. SAGA OF OLAF, TRYGGVI'S SON

app2.1

*(From the Flateyjarbók.)*

app2.2

The Dominions of King Harald and Earl Rögnvald.

app2.3

179. Earl Rögnvald assisted Harald Harfagri (fair-haired) to conquer the country (Norway), and he gave him the revenues of both Mœri and Raumsdal. Rögnvald had married Ragnhild, the daughter of Hrólf Nefia (nose). They had a son named Hrólf, who conquered Normandy. Hrólf was so big that no horse could carry him, and he was therefore called Gönguhrólf (Hrólf the walker). From him the Earls of Rúda (Rouen) and the Kings of England are descended. They had two other sons, Ivar and Earl Thórir Thegiandi (the silent). Rögnvald had also sons by his concubines. They were Hallad, Hrollaug, and Einar, who was the youngest. One summer Harald Harfagri went to the west across the sea to punish the Vikings, as he was weary of their devastations. They plundered in Norway during the summer, and spent the winters in Hjaltland or the Orkneys. Harald subdued Hjaltland, the Orkneys, and the Sudreyar (Hebrides). He went west as far as the Isle of Man, and destroyed all the dwellings in Man. He fought many battles there, and extended his dominion so far to the west that none of the Kings of Norway since his time has had wider dominions. In one of these battles, Ivar, the son of Earl Rögnvald, fell. So when King Harald sailed from the west he gave Hjaltland and the Orkneys to Earl Rögnvald as a compensation for [the loss of] his son; but Earl Rögnvald gave the Islands to his brother Sigurd, who was King Harald's forecastleman; and the King gave him the title of Earl before he left the west. Sigurd remained out in the west.

app2.4

Earl Melbrigd slain by Sigurd.

app2.5

180. Earl Sigurd became a great chief. He formed an alliance with Thorstein the Red, son of Olaf the White, and Aud Djúpaudga (the very wealthy), and together they conquered all Caithness and much more of Scotland — Mærhæfui (Moray) and Ross. He built a borg on the southern border of Mærhæfui. Melbrigd Tönn (tooth), an Earl of the Scots, and Earl Sigurd, made an arrangement to meet in a certain place, with forty men each, in order to come to an agreement concerning their differences. When the appointed day arrived Earl Sigurd was suspicious of treachery on the part of the Scots. He therefore caused eighty men to be mounted on forty horses. When Earl Melbrigd saw this, he said to his men:— “Now we have been treacherously dealt with by Earl Sigurd, for I see two men’s legs on one side of each horse, and the men, I believe, are thus twice as many as the beasts. But let us be brave, and kill each his man before we die.” Then they made themselves ready. When Sigurd saw it, he also decided on his plan, and said to his men:— “Now, let one-half of our number dismount and attack them from behind, when the troops meet, while we shall ride at them with all our speed to break their battle array.” There was hard fighting immediately, and it was not long till Earl Melbrigd fell, and all his men with him. Earl Sigurd and his men fastened the heads [of the slain] to their saddle-straps, in bravado, and so they rode home triumphing in their victory. As they were proceeding, Earl Sigurd, intending to kick at his horse with his foot, struck the calf of his leg against a tooth protruding from Earl Melbrigd’s head, which scratched him slightly; but it soon became swollen and painful, and he died of it. Sigurd the powerful was buried in a mound at Ekkialsbakki.

*app2.6*

Sigurd’s son was named Guthorm. He reigned one winter, and died childless.

*app2.7*

When Earl Rögnvald heard of the death of Earl Sigurd and his son, he sent his son Hallad out to the west, and King Harald gave him the title of Earl. Hallad came out to the west, and took up his residence in

Hrossey, but Vikings went prowling about the islands and outlying headlands, slaying men and seizing booty. The Bœndr complained of their losses to Earl Hallad, but they thought he did not get them much redress for their wrongs. Then Hallad grew tired of the dignity, and resigned the earldom, took up his odal rights, and returned to Norway, and his journey was regarded as a very ignominious one.

*app2.8*

Einar comes to the Islands.

*app2.9*

181. Two Danish Vikings took up their quarters in the Islands; one of them was called Thórir Tréskegg (wooden beard), the other Kálf Skurfa (scurf). When Earl Rögnvald heard this he became very angry, and called his sons Thórir and Hrollaug. Hrólf was at that time on a war expedition. Rögnvald asked which of them would go to the Islands. Thórir said he would follow his advice.

*app2.10*

The Earl replied: "I foresee that your power will be greatest here; and your ways do not lead from home."

*app2.11*

Hrollaug said: "Father, would you like me to go?"

*app2.12*

The Earl replied: "It will never be your fortune to become an Earl. Your way lies towards Iceland. There you will increase your family, and it will be a noble one."

*app2.13*

Then Einar, his youngest son, came forward and said: "Would you like me to go to the Islands? One thing I will promise, which will be very acceptable to you — viz. that I shall never more come into your presence; little honour do I enjoy at home, and it is hardly likely that my success will be less elsewhere than it is here."

*app2.14*

The Earl said: “You are not likely to become a chief, on account of your birth, for all your kin on the mother’s side are thrall-born; but it is true that the sooner you go and the longer you stay the more agreeable it will be to me.” Earl Rögnvald gave him a fully-equipped vessel, with twenty benches, and King Harald gave him the title of Earl.

*app2.15*

The Vikings slain.

*app2.16*

182. Einar sailed to Hjaltland, and there many men gathered round him. Then he went to the Orkneys to meet Kálf Skurfa and Thórir Tréskegg. There was a great battle, and both the Vikings were killed. This was said about it:

*app2.17*

Tré-skegg gave he to the Trows:  
Skurfa fell before Torf-Einar.

*app2.18*

Then Einar took possession of the lands, and soon became a great chief. He was the man who first cut turf (peat) from the ground for fuel at Torfnæs in Scotland, for fuel was scarce in the Islands. Einar was a tall man, ugly, and with one eye, yet he was very keen-sighted.

*app2.19*

Battle between Earl Einar and Prince Hálfðan.

*app2.20*

183. When the sons of Harald Harfagri grew up they became men of great violence and turbulence, as has been told before. The sons of Snæfríd, Hálfðán Hálegg (high legs) and Guðröð Liomi (splendour) killed Rögnvald, Earl of Mœri. King Harald became very angry at this, and Hálfðán had to flee over seas to the west, but Guðröð became reconciled to his father. When Hálfðán Hálegg came to the Orkneys, Earl Einar fled from the Islands to Scotland, and Hálfðán became King over the Islands. Earl Einar came back during the same year, and when they met there was a great battle, in which Einar had the victory, and Hálfðán fled away. Einar sang this song:

*app2.21*

Why are not the spear-shafts flying,  
From the hands of Hrólfr and Hrollaug,  
Thickly 'gainst the press of warriors?  
Now, my father! I avenge thee.  
While we here are closed in battle,  
Sits Earl Thórir all the evening,  
Silent o'er his cheerless drink.

*app2.22*

Next morning they found Hálfðán Hálegg on Rinar's Hill. The Earl made a blood eagle be cut on his back with the sword, and had his ribs severed from the back-bone, and his lungs pulled out. Thus he gave him to Odinn as an offering for victory, and sang this song:

*app2.23*

Oft it is that bearded men  
Are guilty deemed for taking sheep;  
But my offence is that I slew  
The young son of the Islands' king.  
Men may say that danger waits me  
From the great king's speedy vengeance;  
But his wrath shall never daunt me,  
In whose shield I've made a dint.

*app2.24*

Then he had a cairn raised over him, and sang this song:

*app2.25*

Vengeance for my father's death  
I have ta'en for my fourth share.  
In him the people's champion fell;  
But it was the Norns' decree.  
Heap we now a cairn o'er High-leg,  
Thus the hard skatt we shall pay him  
Which as victors we are due him.  
Let the wise to me now listen.

app2.26

When this was heard in Norway his brothers became greatly enraged, and threatened an expedition to the Islands to avenge him, but Harald delayed their journey. When Earl Einar heard of their threats, he sang:

app2.27

Men of no ignoble birth  
 Are they who, from my native land,  
 Seek my life for vengeance' sake;  
 But the truth is, that they know not,  
 Till their swords have surely slain me,  
 Whom the eagles' claws shall rend.

app2.28

Some time afterwards King Harald set out for the western seas, and came to the Islands. Einar fled from the Islands to Caithness. Then men went between them, and they made peace. King Harald imposed a fine upon the Islands, adjudging them to pay sixty marks of gold. Earl Einar offered [to the Bændr] to pay the money himself, on condition that he should become proprietor of all their freeholds. The Bændr accepted this, because the wealthy men thought they might redeem their freeholds, and the poorer men had no money. Einar paid the whole sum, and for a long time afterwards the Earls held all the odal lands, until Earl Sigurd gave back their odal possessions to the Orkneymen. King Harald went back to Norway, but Earl Einar ruled over the Orkneys a long time, and died on a sick-bed. He had three sons: one was named Arnkell, the second Erlend, and the third Thorfinn Hausakliuf (skull-splitter).

app2.29

When Harald Harfagri died, Eirík Blóðöx (bloody-axe) was King for two winters. Then Hakon, Athelstan's foster son, came to the land, and Eirík fled. Arnkell and Erlend, the sons of Torf Einar, fell with Eirík Blóðöx in England. Gunnhild and her sons then went to the Orkneys, and took possession of them, and stayed there for a time. From thence they went to Denmark, but before they went away they married

Ragnhild, the daughter of Gunnhild and Eirík, to Arnfinn, the son of Earl Thorfinn [Hausakliuf], and Earl Thorfinn took up his residence in the Islands: he was a great and warlike chief. He died on a sick-bed, and was buried in a mound on Hauga Heath, in Rögnvaldsey, and was considered to have been a great man.

*app2.30*

The Murder of Hávard.

*app2.31*

184. Thorfinn had five sons. One was named Hávard Arsæli (blessed with good seasons), the second Hlödver, the third Liót, the fourth Skúli, and the fifth Arnfinn. Ragnhild, the daughter of Eirík, killed her husband Arnfinn at Myrkhof (Murkle), in Caithness, and then she married Hávard Arsæli, his brother. He became Earl, and was a good chief, and blessed with good seasons. There was a man named Einar Klíning (battered bread), the son of Hávard's sister. He was a great chief, and had many men, and went usually on war expeditions during the summer. He accepted an invitation from Hávard, and at that feast he and Ragnhild talked much together. She said that it was more suitable that such a man as he should be chief and Earl than Hávard his kinsman, adding that the woman was well married who had him for a husband. Einar told her not to speak of such things, saying that Hávard was the noblest man in the Islands, and that she was well matched. Ragnhild replied: "Hávard and I shall not be long together after this. But it is true that men will be found in the Islands who will not stick at trifles if you grudge me the dignity." By her persuasion Einar was moved to covetousness and treachery against his kinsman. They agreed that he should kill the Earl, and that she should marry him. Some time after Einar prepared to take out his men, but a certain spæman who was with him said: "Do not engage in this business to-day; wait till to-morrow, or else family murders will be frequent in your family." Einar pretended not to hear this. At this time Hávard was at Steinsness, in Hrossey. There they met, and there was hard fighting, and it was not long till the Earl fell. The place is now called Hávard's

teigar. When this became known, Einar was considered a great nothing for the deed. Ragnhild would have nothing to do with him, saying it was a mere lie that she had given him any promises. Then she sent for Einar Hardkiöpt (hard mouth), who was the son of another sister of Hávard. And when they met, she said it was a great shame to Hávard's kinsmen that they did not avenge him, adding that she would do anything that the Earl might be avenged. "It is evident," she said, "that he who avenges the Earl will be most esteemed by good people, and will most deserve his dominions." Einar replied: "It is said that you sometimes speak differently from what you think. But he who does this deed will expect in return that you will help him to the dominions, as well as to other things which he will consider not less important." This was the end of their talk. After this Einar Hardkiöpt went to Einar Klíning and killed him. But Ragnhild sent for their brother Liót, and married him. Liót became Earl, and was a great chief. Now Einar Hardkiöpt had killed his kinsman, and was not any nearer the earldom than before. He was highly dissatisfied, and wished to collect men together and subdue the Islands by force. He had great difficulty in getting men, for the Orkneymen wished to serve the sons of Thorfinn Hausakliuf. Some time afterwards the Earl had Einar Hardkiöpt slain.

*app2.32*

Battle between Liot and Skuli.

*app2.33*

185. Skúli, the brother of Liót, went to Scotland, and had an Earl's title given him by the King of Scots. Then he went down to Caithness, and collected forces together; from thence he went to the Islands, and fought with his brother for the dominion of them. Liót collected a numerous army, and went against Skúli. When they met, Skúli would nothing but fight. There was a severely contested battle. Liót gained the victory, and Skúli fled over to Ness (Caithness). Liót pursued him, stayed there for a while, and got many men together. Then Skúli came down from Scotland with a large army, and met Liót at Dalir (Dale), in

Caithness, and a great battle ensued. Skúli had a large army given him by the King of Scots and Earl Magbiód. In the beginning of the battle the Scots fought hotly. Earl Liót told his men to act on the defensive, and to stand firm; and when the Scots could not make any impression on them, Liót incited his men, and fought very fiercely himself. When this had been going on for some time, the array of the Scots was broken, and then they fled; but Skúli continued the battle, and was ultimately killed. Liót took possession of Caithness, and he and the Scots were at war, because they were vexed at their defeat. When Earl Liót was in Caithness, Earl Magbiód came down from Scotland with a large army, and they met at Skida-mire (Skitten), in Caithness. Although Earl Liót's forces were not equal to those of the Scots, he fought so bravely that the Scots gave way, and the battle had not continued long when those of the Scots who were left alive fled, and many of them were wounded. Liót returned from the pursuit victorious, but with many men wounded, and he himself had received wounds, of which he died.

*app2.34*

Battle.

*app2.35*

186. Hlödver was Earl after Liót, and became a great chief. He married Audna, the daughter of Kiarval, the King of the Ivar. Their son was Sigurd the stout. Hlödver died on a sick-bed, and was buried at Hofn (Huna), in Caithness. His son Sigurd succeeded him, and became a great chief, with extensive possessions. He kept Caithness by main force from the Scots, and went every summer on war expeditions to the Sudreyar (Hebrides), Scotland, and Ireland. One summer Finnleik, an Earl of the Scots, challenged Sigurd to meet him at Skida-mire on a certain day; but Sigurd went to consult his mother, who was a wise woman. The Earl told her that the difference in numbers would not be less than seven to one. She replied: "I should have reared thee up long in my wool-bag if I had known that thou wouldst wish to live for ever. It is fate that rules life, and not the place where a man may go. It is better to

die with honour than live with shame. Take thou here this banner which I have made with all my skill, and I ween that it will bring victory to him before whom it is borne, but death to its bearer.” The banner was wrought with cunningly executed handiwork and elaborate art. It was made in the shape of a raven, and when floating in the wind it resembled the raven flying. Earl Sigurd was very wroth at his mother’s words. He restored their odal rights to the Orkneymen to induce them to assist him, and went to meet Earl Finnleik at Skidamire, where they both placed their men in battle array. When the forces met, Earl Sigurd’s standard-bearer was killed by an arrow. The Earl ordered another to bear the banner, and when they had fought for a while he also fell. Three standard-bearers were killed, but the Earl gained the victory, and the Orkneymen regained their freeholds.

*app2.36*

Meeting between Olaf (Tryggvi’s Son) and the Earl.

*app2.37*

187. Olaf, Tryggvi’s son, sailed west to the Orkneys, as has been mentioned before. But as the Pentland Firth was not to be passed at the time, he moored his ships in Asmundarvag (Osmondwall) opposite Rögnvaldsey. Earl Sigurd, Hlödver’s son, was there before him with three ships, for he was going on a war expedition. When King Olaf became aware that the Earl was there, he called him into his presence. But when the Earl came to the King’s ship, the King spoke as follows: —

*app2.38*

“You know, Earl Sigurd, that Harald Harfagri came here to the west with an army when he had obtained possession of all Norway. King Harald conquered the Orkneys and Hjaltland, and many other lands here in the west. The King gave the Islands to Rögnvald the Powerful as a compensation for his son, but Rögnvald gave them to his brother Sigurd, and he became the Earl of King Harald. King Harald went a second time against Earl Einar with a large army; but well-disposed men mediated between them, and they agreed to the following terms: — The King claimed all the Orkneys and Hjaltland as his own; and the

result of their negotiations was that the Earl paid the King sixty marks of gold for the murder of his son, Halfdan Hálegg, and Earl Einar then held the lands from King Harald. Shortly afterwards, King Eirík, Harald's son, came from Norway. Then also the Earls, the sons of Torfeinar, were his vassals. This appears from the fact that they gave him many men for his war expeditions. When King Eirík came to the Islands a second time, he took away with him the two Earls, Arnkell and Erlend, and appointed their brother Thorfinn to rule over the land. They were both killed in England with King Eirík. Then the sons of Eirík came from England and ruled over the Islands, and when they departed they appointed Arnfinn, their brother-in-law, ruler of the Islands. Havard first succeeded his brother (Arnfinn), then Liót, and lastly your father, Hlödver. Now you, Sigurd, are Earl over these lands which I claim as my possessions, with all other lands possessed by Harald Harfagri and his kinsmen, and descending from them to me by inheritance from generation to generation. You know that most of the sons of Eirík and Gunnhild have now been killed. And although their sister Ragnhild is still alive, it seems to me that she has been guilty of such wickedness in the Orkneys that she ought not to have dignity or power anywhere; indeed, my view is that she has completely forfeited both property and life if it be true that she has done all the shameful deeds that are reported of her, and generally believed. Now, since it has so happened, Earl Sigurd, that you have come into my power, you have to choose between two very unequal alternatives. One is, that you embrace the true faith, become my man, and be baptized with all your subjects. In that case you may have certain hope of honour from me. You shall hold in full liberty as my subject, and with the dignity of an Earl, all the dominions which you have had before. And besides, you will gain what is much more important — namely, to reign in eternal joy in the kingdom of Heaven with the Almighty God. Of this you may be sure if you keep his commandments. The other alternative is a very hard one, and quite unlike the former — viz. that you shall be slain on the spot, and after your death I will send fire and sword throughout

the Orkneys, burning homesteads and men, unless this people is willing to accept immunity by believing in the true God. And if you and your subjects choose the latter alternative, you and they, who put your trust in idols, shall speedily die, and shall thereafter be tormented in hell-fire, with wicked devils, without end.”

*app2.39*

When Earl Sigurd had listened to King Olaf’s long and eloquent harangue, he hardened his mind against him, and said: “I will tell you, King Olaf, that I have absolutely resolved that I will not, and I dare not, renounce the faith which my kinsmen and forefathers had before me, because I do not know better counsels than they, and I do not know that the faith which you preach is better than that which we have had and have held all our lives.”

*app2.40*

When the King saw that the Earl persisted obstinately in his error, he caught hold of his young son, who was with him, and who had been brought up in the Islands. The King carried this son of the Earl to the forepart of the ship. There he drew his sword, and made ready to hew the boy down, saying at the same time: “Now I will show you, Earl Sigurd, that I shall spare no man who will not serve Almighty God, or listen to my preaching of the blessed message. Therefore I shall kill your son before your eyes this instant, with the sword now in my hand, unless you and your men will serve my God. For I shall not leave these Islands until I have completely fulfilled his blessed commission, and you have been baptized along with this son of yours whom I now hold.”

*app2.41*

And because the Earl was situated as he was, he chose the better alternative of doing as the King desired, and so he embraced the true faith. Then the Earl was baptized, and so were all the people of the Orkneys. Then Earl Sigurd became the Earl of King Olaf according to this world’s dignity, and held from him lands and dominions, and gave him as a hostage his son who has already been mentioned. His name

was Hvelp or Hundi (whelp or hound). King Olaf had him baptized by the name of Hlödver, and took him with him to Norway. Earl Sigurd confirmed all their agreement with oaths. After this King Olaf sailed from the Orkneys, leaving priests to instruct the people in the holy faith. King Olaf and Earl Sigurd parted friends. Hlödver lived but a short time, and after his death Earl Sigurd paid no homage to King Olaf. Then he married the daughter of Melkolf, the King of Scots, and their son was Thorfinn.